

THE
WORKS
OF THE
Rev. John Wesley, M.A.

VOLUME

14

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THE REV. JOHN WESLEY, VOL. 14 (OF 32) ***

The Works of the Rev. John Wesley, M.A.

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THE
WORKS

OF THE
Rev. JOHN WESLEY, M.A.

Late Fellow of *Lincoln-College*, OXFORD.

VOLUME XIV.

BRISTOL:

Printed by WILLIAM PINE, in *Wine-Street*.

MDCCLXXII.

THE
C O N T E N T S

Of the FOURTEENTH VOLUME.

- *Extract of Mrs. L****'s Letters (continued.)*
- *Meditations upon some texts of Scripture.*
- *Extracts from a Little Diary.*
- *Letters written by Jane Cooper.*
- *Some account of her life and death.*
- *Some account of the experience of E. J.*
- *An earnest Appeal to Men of Reason and Religion.*
- *A farther Appeal to Men of Reason and Religion. Part I.*



An E X T R A C T of
L E T T E R S

By Mrs. L****.

[Continued.]

To the Rev. Mr. ****.

Sunday Afternoon, October 13, 1754.

My dear Friend,

I WAS this morning (though unseen by you) present at your sermon on the *public* worship of God, and sat impatiently, expecting and longing to hear that name mentioned, by which alone cometh salvation. Surely, thought I, when all his heathen and moral motives are done, I shall at last hear him urge that *best* and *most* prevailing motive to our joining together in the praise of God, the exceeding riches of his mercy to us in Jesus Christ. But alas! How were my expectations frustrated? And how did my heart sink when the sermon was ended!—If there is any faith to be given, either to the words or behaviour of man, you are a *Christian*. But what did you say *here*, more than *Socrates* might have said? You will pardon my boldness; God knows the sincerity of my heart, when I protest, that it is only from a motive of love to your soul, and the souls of those which hear you, that I write with such freedom. Give me leave then to ask, Have you, for your own soul in particular, found redemption through the blood of Christ? I have all the reason imaginable, from your sweet conversation, to believe that you have. But how is it then that you could preach *one* such sermon as this? Oh search well into your own heart. Is there not some root of bitterness remaining, some evil shame, which renders you thus inconsistent? Had I not heard you myself, I could not have thought it possible, for you to have preached in this manner, after the glorious things you have said to me. You have called me friend. Take this letter as the highest proof of friendship I could possibly give you. Is it not so, for your sake to run the hazard of being thought *bold* and *assuming*? If you are offended, tell me so *plainly*, but at the same time *freely* forgive me; and believe me, with the sincerest wishes for your present usefulness and everlasting happiness,

Your ever obliged and affectionate Friend,

To the Rev. Mr. W*****.

December 25, 1754.

Dear Sir,

*MAY this blessed day in which the sun of righteousness first arose on our dark world, bring a new accession of light, and peace, and joy to *your* precious soul! May the power of God accompany every word you utter, and give you this day to enlarge your conquests over the prince of darkness. Oh, give my full heart leave to expand itself in praying for you, in blessing you, and in thanking you, for your surprizing goodness to me. No, never shall you find me ungrateful; *that* God in whom alone I trust for strength, will preserve me from falling into this meanest of all crimes.—I shall not, I fear, have the delightful satisfaction of hearing you to-morrow, and therefore could not forbear writing to-day; besides, I am by illness prevented attending the public worship of God, so that I have need of this comfort. Every thing has succeeded here beyond my hopes, your presence has greatly dispelled every cloud of prejudice, and fear of man. In short, when I consider the goodness of God and my own absolute unworthiness, I am lost in astonishment: dear Sir, pray that I may make a proper improvement of all these blessings, and particularly of that *exceeding* great blessing, your friendship. Oh Sir! may I *indeed* say *your* friendship? The Lord Jesus bless and reward you! Expression fails me, when I would thank you as I ought, and tell how much I am,

Your ever obliged and affectionate,

Dear Sir,

YOUR answer to my question, on what is the proper foundation of our rejoicing in temporal blessings, is perfectly satisfactory, and I thank you for it. What you say of Mr. P.'s tract is just what I wanted: possibly some fit season may be given me to make a good use of it. One would imagine that if singleness of eye, and sincerity of heart were really found in all those of our ministers, who in a measure preach the gospel, there would scarce be room left even for the shadow of a dispute. But this is only imagination; for I cannot help observing of some, for whose sincerity I would answer with my life, that they are far from being consistent long together. I have lately been attacked with a mighty pretty distinction (and from my ignorance a new one to me) in respect of the doctrine of assurance of forgiveness of sin.—Mr. **** says, it is of the *essence* of *faith*; but most of the old *Puritans*, together with a heap of great names (of which I remember not one) say, it is of the *fruits* of *faith*.—A poor weak woman, who has not learnt logic, may be easily puzzled with the nicety of a logical distinction; but still I could plainly see, that let it be essence or fruits, there was a manifest necessity for enforcing the doctrine: because a tree which brings not forth its proper fruits, is a barren tree.—A faith which brings not forth its proper fruits, is a dead faith, and consequently unprofitable.—The answer is, “A tree may be alive, and yet not bring forth fruit immediately.”—Well, but this makes nothing against the necessity there is that it *should* bring forth fruit, in order to make it a profitable tree.—But then we have a homily to fly to:—“The homily on salvation says ‘nothing of assurance.’”—If the homily contradicts St. *Paul*, the homily is nothing to me.—“O, you won’t refer it to that, ‘because it makes against you.’”—I do not so much as know what is in it.—“It only ‘says a *sure trust* and *confidence*.’”—I think a *sure confidence* is nearly the same with assurance.—“No, they are very different.”—Now, Sir, you must be so good to furnish me with two or three of your strong arguments, to pull down this *Babel* tower, which *our friends* are building. I should also be glad, if you would tell me by what happy art you are always *consistent* in doctrine, as well as practice: for I can find no one else that is so.—Difference of opinion I regard not; I could enjoy fellowship of spirit with a truly sincere *Predestinarian*, *Papist*, or *Quaker*. Inconsistency is the thing alone which hurts me. When I find this in people whom I know to be in so much higher a state of grace than myself, and whom I love and honour, it disquiets me, I own, by far too much: and my soul, like *Noah’s* dove, flies solitary about,

and finds no place of rest on the face of the whole earth: till at last with one olive-leaf, and *only one*, she returns joyful to the ark—Give me leave, Sir, to intreat of you (if you should have a little time to spare) that you will just point out to me, *First*, What are the probable causes of this inconsistency, in those who have *truly* sincerity of heart, and singleness of eye. *Secondly*, What is the most probable means of curing this distemper of the mind. And, *Thirdly*, How I may avoid falling into it myself, and keep my soul from being disquieted, when I find it in those whom I highly esteem.—I hope God continues to preserve to us your precious health, and that your long journies may be a means of strengthening and establishing it.—I doubt not but the work of the Lord prospers in your hands, and that you will have much reason to rejoice in the fruit of your labours. How happy are you to be always thus employed, in such eminent service for your Master? You live almost the life of an unembodied spirit; and I live nearly the life of a *plant*. But thank God, it is absolutely certain, that this immortal spirit of mine, which is thus pressed in on every side, and weighed down with matter, will some time burst its bonds, and break the bars of its prison; and then, how it will soar! Nothing sure can equal the life, the joy, the *glorious liberty*, which a spirit must feel, when first delivered from its heavy clog! Farewel! May our dear Redeemer continually watch over you, and bless you in every thought, word, and action!

I am, &c.

September 17.

Dear Sir,

HOW shall I find words to thank you for your sweet expressions of care and friendship for my soul? Ten thousand thousand blessings on your own for this kindness.—I hope I may in *one* sense say, that my soul prospers, because I desire nothing but that the will of God may be done in me and by me. But I have not at present those overflowings of joy I have at some times experienced: the cries of a sickly infant, which touch all the finest springs of human nature, cast a kind of heaviness over my soul: and the perpetual and strict watch I am obliged to keep over my heart, for fear the least murmuring or complaining thought should arise in it, (which I would rather die than suffer) seem rather to restrain my soul from the glorious freedom she once had, of losing herself in the heights and depths of divine love.—Oh blessed hours of abstraction from all creatures, and joyful communion with the fountain and centre of all happiness, when will ye return? When it is the will of my heavenly Father that you should return; and in that divine will I rest contented, willing, nay pleased, to suffer any thing, every thing, so I may be kept from sin. I have lately had inward temptations, buzzing about my mind, like insects in a summer's day; but, by looking to Jesus, I as easily disperse them, as the waving hand disperses those little troublesome animals: and, thanks to my Redeemer's boundless mercy, I still enjoy in my inmost soul, a peace, which I would not lose for millions of worlds. But I greatly want constant recollection, and a mortified humble spirit. You know the weight your words have with me; give me, I beg of you, some directions for obtaining this. I cannot take my leave, without thanking you again and again, for enquiring after my soul: Oh how dearly do I love you for this goodness; may the tender mercies of God be with you! May the eternal Comforter meet and bless you in every word of your tongue, and in every thought of your heart!

Your ever-grateful and affectionate,

February 28.

I SHALL not forget the great reason I had to be thankful both to God and you, for our *last* conversation. It seemed to me, that I had more liberty of speaking to you than usual, though a thousand things were yet left unsaid; and you led me to make many observations, which I hope will be of *lasting* benefit to my soul. You have taught me to see the amazing wisdom and loving kindness of God in several instances, which I should not else have thought of; and I am fully satisfied with all his disposals: knowing he orders all things well, I cheerfully submit; and I trust that strength will be given me to walk on in the way set before me, “though sorrowful, yet (in one sense) always rejoicing.”—Is it not a great blessing that the thorns are mixed with roses? This is infinitely more than I deserve.—How true is it, that the higher satisfaction we have in any thing, besides God, the greater pain must necessarily attend it? I have often been taught this lesson, in various degrees, each rising above the other; and yet I have not learnt wisdom. And who shall teach me *this* wisdom? Why you yourself can lay down most excellent rules, but it is God alone who can give me power to practise them. I plainly see the necessity of having every thought brought into subjection to Christ: it must be thus, if I would attain settled peace and constant recollection.—In your extract from *Molinos*, the state of mind I am seeking, is well described in these words: “The soul that is entered into the heaven of peace, acknowledges itself full of God, and his supernatural gifts; because it lives grounded in *pure love*, receiving equal pleasure in light and darkness, in night and day, in *affliction* and *consolation*: through this holy and heavenly *indifferency*, it never loses its peace in *adversity*, nor its *tranquility* in *tribulation*, but sees itself full of unspeakable enjoyments.”—And again, “Though the valley of the lower faculties of the soul, is suffering *tribulations*, *combats*, *martyrdoms*, and suggestions, yet at the *same time*, on the lofty mountain of the higher part of the soul, the true sun casts its beams; it enflames and inlightens it, and so it becomes clear, peaceable, resplendent, quiet, serene, being a mere ocean of joy.”—But alas! you will say, “How far are *you* from this state!” True, I am far from it indeed. And yet I have sometimes experienced some little glimmerings of it, but they have been soon disturbed: and then I have fondly said to myself, Well, when this trial, when this temptation, or difficulty is over, I shall return to my sweet peace, and my soul will be wholly swallowed up in the love of God. Vain imagination! I think I have *now experimentally* learnt a truth, which before only floated in my brain,

“That the peace of a Christian does not consist in being free from temptations and difficulties, but in stedfastly and calmly conquering them.”—Once more, the Lord preserve you! Could my prayers avail any thing, what blessings would you receive, in body, soul, and spirit! Oh farewell, farewell! And when your soul is most carried up to God, remember to pray for,

Your grateful and affectionate,

April 2.

Dear Sir,

I RETURN you many thanks for writing so soon, and particularly for filling two sides of your paper. My soul was as much enlivened by your letter, as the earth, the birds, and flowers, are by the rays of the sun, after a long and heavy rain. May your blessed Master reward you for all your goodness to me!

I thank God, I have in some measure learnt that grand lesson, “Not as I will, but as *thou* wilt;” and I continually pray that he may teach it me more and more. The present idle and half-dying life I am obliged to lead, greatly needs this temper of mind; and it is all owing to the free mercy of my Redeemer, that I can *now* say, his grace is sufficient for me.

In regard to temporal blessings, I have now and then a little dispute with some of my religious friends, and I want your authority to strengthen my arguments.—They say, Whatever temporal blessing God gives, you are to rejoice and take a pleasure in it, as his gift. And I say, Whatever temporal blessing God bestows, the motive for your rejoicing should be *merely* the will of God: for if you rejoice in the blessing, considered as a happiness in itself (though referring it to God with a thankful heart) you are building on the sand, and your happiness will be shaken, if not overturned, by the first storm that beats upon it. But if the will of God be the motive of your rejoicing, you build your happiness on a foundation which never can be moved. The present blessing, indeed, may vanish away, but your cause of rejoicing still remaineth sure and stedfast, in time and in eternity.—Some people think the way I am in at present a prodigious happiness, and the greatest of worldly blessings, and will ask me, “Are you not pleased?”—I answer, I am pleased with every thing which is the will of God; and the answer is thought an odd one: but I cannot help it, I dare not make any other.

*You want me to say something upon Christian love ripened in eternity. But this is a theme for angels; my soul is too low, too dull to attempt to write upon it; I can only wish and pray to be a partaker of it. Farewel; may the sweetest streams of redeeming love ever fill your soul.

I am unalterably your's,

July 18.

**Dear Sir,*

I CAN truly say, that I *would* with joy devote all I have, and all I am to God, and gladly spend every hour in his service, But the difficulties I find in the way are *indeed insuperable* to *me*, though not so I think to every one, at least if I may judge from some few instances I have seen since my acquaintance with *you*.—You yourself, *even outwardly*, appear to me to spend every hour to the glory of God; and for this reason I look upon you to be the happiest of mankind. When I see you spent with fatigue, your eyes half closed, and your outward man seeming to *hasten* to its dissolution, though I would freely give my own life and strength to increase yours, I almost *envy* you this *glorious fatigue*, and say to myself, How happy, how blessed is this man, thus to *spend* and be *spent* in the service of his Redeemer! Think me not presumptuous when I say, that I place you constantly before my mind, as my *living* example. Outwardly it certainly is impossible for me to follow you, but inwardly!—Oh, Sir, that I could in every faculty of my *soul* be a follower of you, even as *you are* of *Christ*!—You bid me *love enough*; and doubtless if I could *love enough*, I should (as you say) do enough, for *perfect love is perfect liberty*, liberty to conquer all sin, and attain to all holiness. This is the glorious privilege of the children of God; and this my soul pants after. But though I can sincerely say, that I love God above all things, yet it is very evident that I do not love enough, because the fruits of this perfect love are not produced in my soul. Sometimes my enemies seem intirely conquered, and my mind is smooth and calm, as were the waters after Christ had said to them, *Peace, be still*. But when I seem thus strong, I am (to my inexpressible shame and confusion) found to be *weakness* itself: some trifle, which perhaps had appeared too contemptible even to be thought of, will be the means of my *inwardly* falling. But thanks be to God I have this given me,

“Quick as the apple of an eye,

The slightest touch of sin to feel.”

To feel, and immediately to fly to that blood of sprinkling which alone can cleanse me from this pollution. But indeed, Sir, I find every day more and more the truth of your words, “that I have need to *watch always*.” I am set as it were in the midst of snares, both friends and enemies conspiring together to keep me from that humility, which is so necessary to one who wishes to be really a *Christian*. My enemies lead to pride, by railing at me for what is, and ought to be, in one sense, my glory; and my friends, by having too high an opinion of me. I think there is none, except yourself, who does not in *some measure* hurt me: and therefore, though I dare not call you *my friend*, as implying any particular attachment on your part, you are in fact, my truest and best friend. Praise I now dread as poison; and yet my temper is such as makes some encouragement necessary. Your behaviour to me is exactly fitted to preserve the balance of my mind even; a smile of approbation from you, is *that praise* which *encourages* without endangering. You will pardon my speaking so much of myself: a patient, you know, must fully lay open his case to his physician; and I have been emboldened even by you yourself, to increase the length of my letters. Oh may your blessed Master reward you for all your labours in his service, and for all your goodness to,

*Your unworthy, though
ever-grateful and affectionate,*

M E D I T A T I O N S

Upon some TEXTS of SCRIPTURE.

The heart is deceitful above all things, and desperately wicked.

O MY God, how fatally do I experience the truth of this assertion! My heart is indeed deceitful above all things. And how great is my sorrow on the melancholy reflection? Lord, I have by the deceitfulness and wickedness of my own heart, justly forfeited my title to the joys of eternity, incurred thy indignation, and made myself obnoxious to that dreadful sentence, *Depart ye cursed!* And how just is this sentence, after the crimes my deceitful heart has betrayed me into; after the many good resolutions I have broke; after the sins of ingratitude, presumption, and repining, with which I have defiled my soul! How often have I resolved, firmly resolved, to keep a strict watch over my eyes and heart in the house of God; and let no thought have entrance, which could prevent my addressing my Creator with the reverence I ought? But, merciful God! How contrary have I acted to all this! Have not my eyes been amused by vanity, and my heart so distracted by idle and ridiculous ideas, that I have not known the words my lips pronounced? Nay, have not even unclean and blasphemous thoughts attacked me at this sacred time, and, wretch that I am! been indulged, or but coldly rejected? Horrible proof, that my heart is deceitful above all things, and desperately wicked! Lord, I abhor myself, for having thus often, and thus heinously offended thee! I am utterly ashamed and confounded, at my daring, my monstrous impiety! How shall I dare to hope for pardon of a sin so frequently repeated, and with such aggravations? When I consider the greatness of my guilt, my astonished soul is ready to sink in black despair. Blessed God! I sin against the clearest conviction, against the checks of my conscience, and the kind admonitions of thy holy Spirit; and, strange perverseness! against all the hopes I have of happiness; sin against that God, whom I love and adore from my soul, and whose favour I would this moment lay down my life to procure. The thoughts of immortality, and the surprising goodness of the Almighty, in the works of creation and redemption, fill my mind with gratitude and wonder; I am lost in admiration, and could dwell for ever on the delightful theme. And yet, inconsistent wretch that I am! I go on to offend this divine author of my being, by my careless, supine, and irreverent addresses; and my wicked and fantastic thoughts. My prayers are turned into sin: and now is it not presumption, the highest presumption, to hope for pardon? Or rather, would it not be a greater sin than I have yet committed, to despair of it? Is not mercy the darling attribute of God? It is; and I embrace and adore that mercy: that mercy which is so freely offered to the worst of sinners: that

mercy which is made sure to us by the blood of a crucified Saviour. Oh my only refuge! my dearest hope and everlasting confidence! Teach me words to express the sentiments I have of thee, and the abhorrence I have of my guilt. I detest myself, hate my vile ingratitude, and am fully convinced of my own weakness, and the vanity of my best resolutions, without thy assisting grace. Oh grant me that, for the sake of my Redeemer; on that alone will I rely; never more will I trust to the strength of my own reason. I have found, by dear experience, that I am folly and inconstancy itself: without thy aid I am worse than nothing, but with the blessing I implore, I shall be more than conqueror. But is the sin I have now been lamenting, the only instance of the wickedness and deceitfulness of my heart? Alas! it is not: I have innumerable proofs of its treachery; every day, every hour brings some, and gives me new cause for grief and repentance. I resolve frequently, no more to repine at the misfortunes I lie under; no more to look back with discontent, or forwards with distrust. And these resolutions I strengthen, by reflections on the wisdom of God: how much better he knows to chuse for me, than I could for myself; and how unavailing impatience is under ills, I cannot prevent. Then I consider how small my punishment is, in comparison of what I deserve, and should suffer, was not the Almighty infinitely merciful; and what blessings afflictions are productive of, when received with humility and resignation. *And yet after all this, how often do I catch my deceitful heart breathing an impious sigh, and by this secret complaint accusing Providence! How often are my eyes lift up, with a “Lord! why am I thus miserable? Why, while I see all around me gay and prosperous, must I alone be unfortunate, and mourn, without finding one to pity me? What have I done to deserve the being disappointed in every thing I have set my affections on, and deceived by every friend I have trusted?”—With this surprising boldness have I dared to expostulate with my Maker; and yet his mercy still allows me life, and time for repentance. Oh thou adorable Being! may I never more offend thee by a discontented word or thought: but grant that every faculty of my soul, may be in perfect resignation to thy will; and by this resignation, acquire that tranquillity and peace, which all the delights of the earth are not able to give.

Again. I resolve every day to be perfectly easy under every little mortification I may meet in the common occurrences of life. How weak (I cry) is it to be affected by the folly or ill-nature of the world! Why should I regard the sneers of people, whose low sentiments are only deserving pity? Can the unreasonable, and unjust notions of another, rob me of any real merit? Can an envious, a malicious, or a detracting speech, do me any material injury, unless I give it force myself, by my impatience and want of temper? No certainly: nothing from without can hurt me, but by my own fault. A mind fortified with religion, is proof against the darts of senseless tattle, or ill-natured wit. Firm and collected within itself, it smiles superior, and looks down on the ignorant and the malicious with pity.—These reflections are just; and Oh that I could reduce them into practice! But here I miserably fail. *After my soul has plumed herself with these fine notions, and is ready to pronounce herself equal to every trial, she sinks in the most shameful manner. A word, a look, nay the very appearance of a slight, throws me into the greatest uneasiness and confusion; and though I can govern my temper enough to hide it from the world, my heart is ready to burst with indignation. Strange weakness!—But why do I call it strange? Am I not too well acquainted with the fatal cause of this, and almost every sin I am guilty of? 'Tis vanity, that intolerable vanity, which mixes itself with all I act, or speak, or think. When I look strictly into my deceitful and wicked heart, I find it so full of this abominable vice, that I regard myself with horror and amazement; and yet perhaps the next moment, indulge in airy schemes and self-complacency. Sure there is not in the whole universe, so vain and sinful a wretch as I am! What can I hope for? What can I expect? Will not eternal rejection from the presence of God be justly my portion? Oh, thought of unutterable horror! My God! My only hope! Can I think of being for ever cast out from the light of thy countenance, and live? Why does not the dreadful idea at once put an end to my being? All the torments of damnation are summed up in these shocking words—Eternal rejection from thy presence!—Oh gracious and adorable being! let me not be thus beyond imagination cursed. In the name of my blessed Saviour, I implore thy pity! Oh look with compassion on a soul which pants for grace and forgiveness! A soul sensible of her weak and polluted state, and entirely relying on thy mercy. O speak peace to this troubled sea, and all shall be calm! Give me strength to resist those temptations I so often sink under! But above all, change this wicked and deceitful heart, and give me a

new heart and a new spirit. Mortify in me all proud thoughts and vain opinions of myself, and let not the blessings thou hast bestowed upon me increase my condemnation, by being made motives for pride and vainglory. Hear and grant my requests, Oh ever-merciful God, for the sake of Jesus Christ, our only Mediator and Redeemer. *Amen.*

1748.

◆ “pollued” replaced with “polluted”

Come unto me all ye that labour and are heavy laden, and I will refresh you.

THESE, Oh compassionate Saviour, were thy words; this thy gracious call, and I obey it. I come unto thee, Oh thou light of the world! for rest, peace and everlasting refreshment. Wearied with treading the paths of folly and vanity; wearied with deceitful hopes and idle fears, and all the gay delusions of this world, I come to thee for peace, and with full assurance of obtaining it. Assurance founded on thy promises; those promises which are truth itself: merciful as thy own [beneficent](#) nature, and unalterable as thy being. Heaven and earth shall pass away, but thy word shall never fail. Encouraged by this word, I come: not even the reflection of my absolute unworthiness shall keep me from thee. 'Tis to sinners that this heavenly call is addressed; sinners that labour under the heavy burden of their offence; and such am I. The miserable wretch who is chained to the oar, is not more weary of his slavery, than I am of my sins: the sins which so easily beset me, and so often conquer my best resolutions. Every hour I have new reason to lament my weakness, and to confess that thy grace is my only refuge. O let that grace, which has kept me from all infamous crimes, be also my preservative against those sins of the mind, which, though hid from the short-sighted world, are all open to thee, and render my soul equally odious to the eye of heaven. Oh save me from myself! From my own proud thoughts and vain affections! I come to thee, blessed Jesus, that I may have rest: Oh give me that rest! Then shall all be perfect peace and harmony, and my soul shall feel no emotions but those of joy and gratitude, eternal gratitude to my gracious and Almighty Benefactor.

[beneficent](#) "beneficent" replaced with "beneficent"

This corruptible must put on incorruption, and this mortal must put on immortality.

O H glorious and ever transporting thought! Sure and never failing remedy for all the troubles and disappointments of life!—Incorruption and immortality!—Let me dwell on the charming words: they carry peace and everlasting joy in the sound. And yet how little can my soul understand of their full import, clogged by the weight of flesh and blood? Darkened by this cloud of sin and error, what true idea can she form of incorruption? But if the faint shadow and distant prospect affords such delight, what will the full enjoyment give? Imagination is lost in the dazzling reflection! All the scenes of this lower world vanish as a mist before the sun: and my elevated soul wholly absorbed in contemplation of those mighty blessings seems to soar above the stars, and launch into the sea of eternity. My God! My everlasting hope! Great and adorable Creator of all things! Where shall I find words expressive of my wonder, my joy, and gratitude? Thy mercy, thy free, and boundless mercy, from nothing called me into being, and made that being capable of an endless duration: formed me for eternity! And what raises the benefit infinitely higher, for an eternity of happiness! Not the united power of men and devils can deprive me of this without my own consent: and if I am miserable I have no one to blame, except myself. O merciful God! I adore thee past all expression, and the notions I have of thy divine attributes inspire me with an unbounded confidence. Unworthy as I am of the least of all thy mercies, I cannot but hope for the greatest; and in the midst of my continual offences, I look up to thee, as my friend, my only refuge, and constant benefactor. When I grieve for my sins, 'tis not from fear of punishment, but from the cutting reflection of my black ingratitude, in offending my Creator and Preserver, the God in whom I live, and move, and have my being; the God to whom I owe infinitely more than I can conceive; to whom I owe the glorious, and the assured hopes of incorruption and immortality. And here again, O my soul, take wing, again lose thyself in the blissful prospect! Think on the joy thou wilt feel, when this corruptible shall have put on incorruption; when this companion (which in spite of the miseries it betrays thee into, is still dear and still too tenderly beloved) shall become (instead of a clog, or a prison) a vehicle pure and ethereal, perfectly fitted for all the purposes of thy enlarged faculties, and the completion of thy glory and happiness. O blessed and desirable re-union! State of permanent delight, and never fading joy! With what rapture does thy idea inspire my soul! Fired by thoughts like these, I rise far above the most glorious prospects, earth, with all her

boasted varieties, can give. Pleasures, riches, honours, what are ye all? Emptiness and nothing.—At the least glimpse of eternal day, how ye vanish into soft air! Lost are all your shining toys; your painted glories intirely lost! And Oh may their deluding shadows never return to darken my soul! May the God whom I trust, preserve me from all their temptations; may his mercy ever protect and guide me, and bring me in the end to that state of incorruption and immortality, which I hope for through the merits and mediation of our blessed Lord and Saviour Jesus Christ. *Amen.*

*Then Peter said, Now know I that God is no respecter of persons;
but in every nation, he that feareth him and worketh
righteousness, is accepted of him.*

THIS text is so strong a proof of the unreasonableness and folly of national or religious prejudices, that one would imagine it should intirely banish those odious and pernicious principles, from the whole Christian world. But daily experience too plainly discovers the contrary; and the very people who would be thought to have the greatest zeal for the good of souls, are of all others the readiest to condemn those who dissent from them. 'Tis a common (though false assertion) of libertines, that priests of all religions are the same. But they might truly affirm, that bigots of all religions are the same, equally destructive of the peace of their fellow-creatures, and the laws of civil society. What wild havock, what horrid scenes of blood and slaughter, have been produced by mistaken zeal and blind prejudice? The histories of former times abound with shocking instances of this kind; and, strange inconsistency! the persecuted party have no sooner got the upper hand, but they have, with the power, assumed the spirit of their persecutors, and been guilty of the very acts of injustice they had so loudly exclaimed against. 'Tis true, the degrees and kinds of persecution differ, according to the particular notions of the sects, or the particular law of the states where it is practised. But persecution, in whatever shape or degree, is still persecution, and proceeds from that spirit of prejudice and bigotry, which make us look on God as a respecter of persons, and on all those who differ from us as his enemies, and consequently, deserving nothing at our hands but contempt and cruelty. Thus the furious *Roman Catholic* brands with the name of heretic, all who are without the pale of his church, pursues them with fire and sword in this world, and sentences them to eternal punishment in the next. And the staunch, sour *Protestant* devoutly expatiates on the crying sin of idolatry, never thinks of the Pope without joining with him antichrist and the devil, absolutely pronounces the church of *Rome* to be the whore of *Babylon*, and expects (with great Christian charity) that in a few ages more, she and all her members will be swallowed up in the bottomless pit, the lake of fire and brimstone. Nay, the bigots of (even) the little trifling sects into which the reformed religion is subdivided, all agree to damn each other, and wholly to appropriate to those of their own denomination, the title of God's church, and God's chosen.—Surprizing narrowness of soul! Worse than *Jewish* stupidity! They had some excuse for their arrogance: the particular manner in which Providence had distinguished them from the rest of the world, seemed to be some foundation for their pride to build on. And 'tis not to be

wondered, that the dark shadow of the law should obscure the principle of universal benevolence. But that people under the glorious dispensation of the gospel, men who pretend to be followers of that Jesus, whose whole life was a scene of moderation and charity, who laid down his life for his enemies, and prayed for his murderers: in a word, that Christians should despise, hate, and persecute their fellow Christians, is a consideration equally melancholly and amazing! *Mistaken men! Is then the great Creator of the universe, the Preserver of all his creatures, the God of mercy, who would not that any one should perish, is this adorable Being a respecter of persons? Is his justice to be biassed by your foolish distinctions? Or his mercy lessened by your uncharitable judgments? In vain you would make the Almighty a party in your quarrel, and pretend to be fighting his cause! He disclaims such furious champions; nor will true religion allow of defenders, who are destroying the most glorious part of her system, that principle of universal charity, which in the apostolical times was the distinguishing mark of Christianity. It was then said, See how these Christians love one another! But now (sad contrast!) see how these Christians hate one another! Oh blessed and ever-merciful God! look down with compassion on the deplorable state of the Christian world! See how thy church is laid waste and rent asunder, by the fraud, malice, or blind zeal of particular men: in one place, over-run by superstition; in another, undermined by scepticism: and every where robbed of her primitive peace and purity. Oh restore that purity! Restore that peace! Heal her breaches, reform her superstitions, and grant that we may, with one heart and one mind, with universal love and unbounded charity to our fellow-creatures, and a firm and lively faith in our blessed Redeemer, adore thee the only true God; and, after a life of piety and virtue, attain one of unalterable glory and happiness. *Amen.*

O God, thou art my God! Early will I seek thee.

WHEN we are deprived of all the joys of life, betrayed by those we trusted, forsaken by our friends, triumphed over by our enemies, and robbed of our dearest hopes, where and to whom must we go for relief? What comfort can be hoped in a condition so desperate.—Will reflection on the past give us ease?—Alas! it makes our wounds still deeper; and every remembrance of the treachery of our friends, or the malice of our enemies, draws a new sigh from the oppressed and aching heart, and a fresh tear from the sinking eye.—Shall we look forwards?—All dark and gloomy is the prospect, and the mind, wearied with affliction, and wholly deprest by grief and disappointments, shudders at the thought of launching again into the sea of delusions, of again trusting, and being again deceived. In circumstances so deplorable, nothing can calm our grief, nothing afford us one moment's peace, but seeking early after God. And happy! Thrice happy! That soul, which can say with the royal *Psalmist*, *O God! thou art my God, my refuge in all my distresses, my only hope, and everlasting peace!*—A man who can look up to the great Author of nature, with a confidence like this, who can seek after God with full assurance of finding him, and in him a sure relief for all the troubles and miseries of life, is superior to all events, and may be happy in the most terrible afflictions. Is he deprived of his estate, reduced to a despised and unrelieved poverty? He is still rich in the pleasing hopes, that his God will one day bestow on him a glorious and never-failing inheritance. Is he by death robbed of his dearest friends? His grief is immediately calmed, by the thoughts of that eternal state to which he is every moment approaching, and where he will meet those dear objects of his tenderness, never, never to be parted from them more. Is his reputation made a sacrifice to spite and calumny, and himself condemned, reviled, and hated, by his acquaintance? Still true to his principles, and firm in his trust on the Almighty, he braves the storm, and with joy he looks forward to that day, when his accusers shall be covered with shame and confusion, and his innocence declared in the sight of men and angels. *Is he betrayed by those he trusted with an unbounded confidence, by those who were dear to him as himself, and for whose life he would freely have paid his own? Even in this affliction (which is of all others grating to human nature) he is still the most master of himself, and possessing his soul in patience and resignation, looks up to that friend who will never deceive him, to that God who is truth itself. Convinced of the folly of placing his love and trust on creatures, he fixes it wholly on the

eternal Creator, and acknowledges with sincerity the mercy of God, in thus graciously releasing his heart from those deluding ties, which had so often drawn him from the centre of true happiness, the end of his being. Thus blessed is he, who can say with faith, gratitude, and humility, *O God, thou art my God!*—Grant, Oh most adorable and omnipotent Being! Grant me this glorious privilege! I have nothing more to ask. That thou art my God, is a blessing infinitely greater than the whole creation can bestow; infinitely beyond all I can ask or conceive. Possessed of this, I can defy the combined malice of men and devils. Welcome distress, poverty, disappointment, and affliction of all kinds, even what I have most dreaded! Welcome all, if it is the will of heaven! What hurt are ye capable of doing me, while I can say to the rock of ages, “Thou art my God?” And certainly, Oh thou fountain of life, and author of all good, ’tis thy gracious will that I should thus address thee; else why this firm reliance on thee in all my afflictions? Why this entire confidence on thy mercy and goodness, in the midst of my sufferings? How often, when my heart has been sinking under a load of sorrow, have I found relief and comfort, by applying to thee? In troubles, which I have thought impossible to be endured, thou hast been my support; and when at any time I have been tempted to discontent, and dared to murmur and complain, how quickly has thy grace inspired me with remorse for my impiety; and enabled me to make a new act of resignation to thy Providence! Sure and infallible proofs, that thou art my God! And Oh may I never repay those instances of thy compassion and tender mercy with ingratitude! Never more distrust the power which has so often delivered me! But grant, Almighty Father, that in all the trials thou hast allotted me in this mortal state, I may seek thee early, and in seeking thee, find all the blessings thou hast promised, peace and perfect tranquillity in this life, and everlasting joy and happiness in the next! These favours, these blessings I implore in the name, and for the sake of my merciful Redeemer, Jesus Christ.

E X T R A C T from a

L I T T L E D I A R Y .

* J A N U A R Y 5, 1754–5. Glory to the God of boundless mercy, who has this day, when sinking under great heaviness, both of soul and body, lifted up the light of his countenance upon me, and made me drink deep of his redeeming love.—Oh sweetest and most compassionate Jesus! How do thy tender mercies follow and support my soul! And still I am ungrateful, and still I am not as thou wouldst have me to be! Oh when wilt thou make a full end of sin, and bring in thy perfect righteousness? All things are possible to thee. And do I not know, do I not *taste*, that thou art gracious! O my sun, my shield, life of my life, look into my heart; I dare appeal to thine all-searching eye, that there is nothing so dear to it, but I would this moment part with it for thee! And why then, dearest Lord, wilt thou not form thy whole blessed image in my soul? My unworthiness I know is greater than that of any other creature in the universe; but this unworthiness will the more magnify thy mercy. I have only my unworthiness to plead; and I have no hope but in thy atoning blood: Oh let this blood, which has bought my peace, cleanse me also from every sin; and let that blessed Spirit, who has sealed and witnessed this *peace* to my soul, be now a spirit of burning, to consume all my dross, and to purify me even as—Oh glorious prospect, heart-enlivening hope, let me sink into the dust before thee! God of glory, God of purity, I am lost in self-abasement! But hast thou not promised? And wilt thou not fulfil thine own gracious word? O give me then perfect sanctification of body, soul, and spirit; and let this heavy cross, which seems now coming upon me, be, by thy all-powerful grace, turned into a means of forwarding thy blessed work in my soul. Let every bitter cup which thou permittest to be given me, be joyfully received, as serving in some degree to conform me to thy sufferings; and let me in all things, though ever so contrary to my corrupt nature, give thanks, and say continually, Lord, not my will, but thine be done. *Amen.*

LETTERS

Wrote by

JANE COOPER:

To which is prefixt

Some *Account* of her LIFE and DEATH.

The PREFACE.

1. THE good *Armelle* has been heard of far and wide. Her life has been written at large, containing several hundred pages, translated into various languages, and published almost in all parts of *Europe*, by persons of various persuasions. Her deep, solid, unaffected piety, has recommended her to those of all denominations, who regarded not mere opinions, but the genuine work of God; *righteousness, and peace, and joy in the Holy Ghost.*

2. But it is impossible to give so full an account of this good young woman, whose station in life, was the same for some years. She had no such director of her conscience, who was informed (like those in the *Roman* church) of the minutest particulars, relating either to her internal or external walking with God. And she wrote no circumstantial account of herself. We have only some hints occasionally written, either for her own private use, or the satisfaction of her friends. And the greatest part even of her letters are lost: particularly those of which she took the most pains in writing. So that what follows are little more than fragments.

“But though they’re little, they are golden sands.”

In several respects not inferior to any thing in the life of *Armelle Nicholas*: in others greatly superior thereto. For first, All here is *genuine*; which I fear is not the case in the account given us of *Armelle*. For words are there put into her mouth, which I think she could not possibly utter. For instance. She is made to say, “I had always such a sense of my sins, that I never felt pride in my life.” Could any one born of a woman say this? Is it not an embellishment added by her historian?

3. Secondly, All here is *strong, sterling sense*, strictly agreeable to sound reason. Here are no extravagant flights, no mystic reveries, no unscriptural enthusiasm. The sentiments are all just and noble; the result of a fine natural understanding, cultivated by conversation, thinking, reading, and true Christian experience. At the same time they shew an heart as well improved as the understanding; truly devoted to God, and filled in a very uncommon degree, with the entire *fruit* of his Spirit.

4. Thirdly, This strong genuine sense is expressed in such a *stile*, as none would expect from a *young servant maid*: a stile simple and artless in the highest degree, but likewise clear, lively, proper: every phrase, every word being so well chosen, yea, and so well placed, that it is not easy to mend it. And such an inexpressible sweetness runs through the whole, as art would in vain strive to imitate.

So JANE COOPER wrote, and spoke, and lived! Thou that reatest, *go and do likewise!*

SOME ACCOUNT
OF THE
LIFE AND DEATH
OF
JANE COOPER.

1. JANE COOPER was born at *Hingham*, in the county of *Norfolk*, in the year 1738. Her father died when she was very young, and some time after, her mother married again. She was a daughter of affliction from her childhood; her father-in-law meeting with many misfortunes: But rather than be burdensome to any, when she was about twenty years of age, she chose to go out to service. For this purpose she came to *London*, and undertook to do all work in a small family. What sweetened all her labour was, that she had frequent opportunities of hearing what she believed to be the pure gospel. But after some months, she judged it best to leave this place, though much against the desire of her master. She then lived with a gentlewoman in *Pall-mall*, who for a considerable time, used her more like a companion than a servant. Her mistress afterwards removing to *Brentford*, she remained with her till spring 1762, though exceedingly to the prejudice of her health, which continually decayed. When she quitted *Brentford*, finding her strength so entirely lost that she was no longer capable of service, she hired a lodging in *London*, by the advice of her friends, designing to work plain-work: but before she settled, she took a journey into *Norfolk*, to visit her friends and relations. Part of the time she was in the country was spent at *Norwich*, where she indeed “lived as an angel here below,” comforting the sick and afflicted, supporting the weak, lifting up the hands that hung down, confirming the wavering, and in every possible way *ministering to the heirs of salvation*.

2. Of her spiritual experience during this time, we have no account, but in some of her letters, and in her diary: part of which runs thus: (it is dated *January 16, 1762.*)

“I received peace in believing four years ago. For some time after, I felt no sin, and thought I never should any more. How far it was owing to my unfaithfulness, I cannot tell; but it was not long, before I found my inward parts were very wickedness. I was amazed to feel, that notwithstanding this, I loved him who died for *me*, that I still retained my confidence in God, and had the witness in myself, that I was a child of God. But with all I thought, I should always have a carnal mind, which would sometimes be at *enmity with God*.

“In this belief I continued, till about two years ago God brought me to hear the *whole* gospel. Not long after, those words were continually on my mind, *Once have I heard, yea twice hath God spoken, that power belongeth unto God*; and I was deeply convinced, that I had in effect denied his power. Even after I had tasted his love, I limited the Holy One of *Israel*: and from this time I began to plead the promises of sanctification; but I still set them at a distance, supposing the accomplishment of them to be afar off.

“In *March* following I heard a letter read from one, who had entered into the rest of the people of God. It described a happiness in religion, which I was a stranger to: I was much stirred up to seek after it, and was determined to wrestle with God till I prevailed. One day in prayer, that promise was applied, *The Lord whom ye seek, shall suddenly come to his temple*. From that time, I expected him in every means I used, to come and destroy the works of the devil. I was agonizing with God in family prayer, when he gave me power to venture upon Jesus, as of God *made unto me wisdom, and righteousness, and sanctification, and redemption*. He spoke into my heart, ‘The Lord, even the king of *Israel*, is in the midst of thee; *and the enemies thou hast seen this day, thou shalt see them no more for ever.*’ From this time I have rejoiced indeed, and yet loathed myself in my own sight. I feel no desire but to please him, and know of nothing in me that is not subjected to Jesus: I depend upon him every moment, as my advocate with the Father: I daily feel my coming short of what I would be, yet without any condemnation. The blood of sprinkling speaks me clean. Indeed if I could perform the obedience I desire, I should still be ashamed before him.”

3. In the midst of various outward trials, her soul was now kept as a watered garden. She was *satisfied with the favour, and full blessing of the Lord*: she enjoyed deep communion with God, and that without any interruption: she sought for and found direction from him in every circumstance of life. She truly proved him to be her counsellor, who instructed her by his small still voice. She walked continually in his presence, and felt her soul always approved of him. She used to say, “Would Jesus on this or the other occasion, have acted or spoken thus?” And this rule she steadily copied after, in all her life and conversation. She knew a little of what our Lord meant, when he said, *The Father which dwelleth in me, he doth the works*. To his will she was entirely given up, in sickness and health, ease and pain.

4. In the beginning of *November*, she seemed to have a foresight of what was coming upon her, and used frequently to sing these words:

“When pain o’er this weak flesh prevails,
With lamb-like patience arm my breast.”

And when she sent to let me know she was ill, she wrote in her note, “I suffer the will of Jesus. All he sends is sweetened by his love. I am as happy as if I heard a voice say,

For me my elder brethren stay,
And angels beckon me away,
And Jesus bids me come.”

5. Upon my telling her, “I can’t chuse life or death for you,” she said, “I asked the Lord, that if it was his will, I might die first; and he told me, you should survive me, and that you should close my eyes.” When we perceived it was the small-pox, I said to her, “My dear, you won’t be frightened, if we tell you what is your distemper.” She said, “I *can’t* be frightened at *his* will.”

6. The distemper soon was very heavy upon her: but so much the more was her faith strengthened. Tuesday, *November 16*. She said to me, “I have been worshipping with you before the throne in a glorious manner, my soul was so let into God.” I said, “Did the Lord give you any particular promise?” “No, replied she; it was all

That sacred awe that dares not move,
And all the silent heaven of love.”

7. Wednesday 17. Mrs. C. said to her, “Is there any thing you think me particularly deficient in?” She answered, “No, love. He will guide you by his eye, and be your only counsellor. All around you is God and heaven. You little know how dearly Jesus loves you.” To Mr. M. she said, “I thank God for your preaching. You must still preach simple faith. Man will despise you, but God will love you; and yourself must *believe*.” On Thursday, upon my asking, “What have you to say to me?” She said, “Nay, nothing but what you know already; God is love.” I asked, “Have you any particular promise?” She replied, “I don’t seem to want any. I can live without. I shall die a lump of deformity, but shall meet you all glorious; and mean time, I shall still have fellowship with your spirit.”

8. When Mr. M—— came again, he asked, “What she thought the most excellent way to walk in, and what were its chief *hindrances*?” She answered, “The greatest *hindrance* is generally from the natural constitution. It was mine, to be reserved, to be very quiet, to suffer much, and to say little. Some may think one way more excellent, and some another. But the thing is, to live in the will of God. For some months past, when I have been peculiarly devoted to this, I have felt such a guidance of his Spirit, and *the unction which I have received from the Holy One, has so taught me of all things*, that I *needed not any man should teach me, save as this anointing teacheth*.”

“When you speak upon acquaintance with Jesus, it is food to the soul. And when you preach of devotedness to God, and living to him, it is the joy of one’s heart.” He asked, “Have you any conviction you shall die?” She answered, “No: only from the disorder. But I feel his will so precious to me, that it is impossible for me to chuse.” He said, “We leave you in our Lord’s hands.” She said, “We shall meet above. I have no doubt of it.”

9. On Friday morning, she said, “I believe I shall die.” She then sat up in her bed, and said, “Lord, I bless thee, that thou art ever with me, and all thou hast is mine. Thy love is greater than my weakness, greater than my helplessness, greater than my unworthiness. Lord, thou *sayest to corruption, thou art my sister!* And glory be to thee, O Jesus, thou art my brother! Let me *comprehend with all saints, the length, and breadth, and depth, and height of thy love!* Bless these: (some that were present) Let them be every moment exercised in all things, as thou wouldst have them to be.”

10. Some hours after, it seemed as if the agonies of death were just coming upon her. But her face was full of smiles of triumph, and she clapped her hands for joy. Mrs. C. said, “My dear, you are more than conqueror, through the ‘blood of the lamb’.” She answered, “Yes, O yes, sweet Jesus. O death, where is thy sting?” She then lay as in a doze for some time. Afterwards she strove to speak, but could not. However she testified her love, by shaking hands with all in the room. Then she took Miss M——’s hand, with Mrs. C. and Mrs. D——’s, and put them to her heart.

11. The apothecary soon came in. She strove to speak to him, but had not utterance. One asked of the Lord, to give her power to speak; and in a few moments she spoke distinctly. Immediately she exhorted him to believe. He said, “I hope I do.” “Do you then, replied she earnestly, find in Christ all you want? You may. And I want you to be happy *now*. Why won’t you believe, when Christ has given all his divinity to save you?” He started, and said, “I hope I shall.” “Hope! said she, that is not the thing. *The hope of the hypocrite shall perish.* Indeed you are not an hypocrite. Yet unless you are on the rock, when the winds and floods come, your building will not stand.”

*12. Mr. W. then came. She said, "Sir, I did not know that I should live to see you. But I am glad the Lord has given me this opportunity, and likewise power to speak to you. I love you. You have always preached the *strictest* doctrine. And I loved to follow it. Do so still, whoever is pleased or displeased." He asked, "Do you now believe you are saved from sin?" She said, "Yes. I have had no doubt of it for many months. That I ever had, was because I did not abide in the faith. I now feel, I have kept the faith: and *perfect love casteth out all fear*." Mr. W. said, "Loving faith is all." She answered, "Ah Sir, I never had a grain of faith but what brought love, and I never had any love but by faith. As to you, the Lord promised me, your latter works should exceed your former, though I do not live to see it." He said, "Perhaps the Lord may restore you." She said, "His will be done. I have been a great *Enthusiast* (as they term it) these six months; but never lived so near the heart of Christ in my life. You, Sir, desire to comfort the hearts of thousands. Comfort the hearts of hundreds, by following that simplicity your soul loves."

13. To one who received the love of God under her prayer, she said, "I feel I have not followed a cunningly devised fable; for I am as happy as I can live. Do you press on, and stop not short of the mark." To Miss M——s, she said, "Love Christ, he loves you. I believe I shall see you at the right hand of God. But *as one star differs from another star in glory, so shall it be in the resurrection*. I charge you, in the presence of God, meet me at that day all glorious within. Avoid all conformity to the world. You are robbed of many of your privileges. I know, I shall be found blameless. Do *you* labour to be found of him in peace, without spot."

14. Saturday morning, she prayed nearly as follows. "I know, Lord, my life is prolonged, only to do thy will; and though I should never eat or drink more, (she had not swallowed any thing for near eight and twenty hours) thy will be done. I am willing to be kept so a twelve-month: *Man liveth not by bread alone*. I praise thee, that there is not a shadow of *complaining in our streets*. In that sense we know not what sickness means. Indeed, Lord, *neither life, nor death, nor things present, nor things to come, no nor any creature shall separate us from thy love one moment*. Bless these, that there may be no lack in their souls. I believe there shall not. I pray in faith."

*On Sunday and Monday she was light-headed, but sensible at times. It then plainly appeared her heart was still in heaven. One said to her, "Jesus is your mark." She replied, "I have but one mark. I am all spiritual." Miss M. said to her, "You dwell in God." She answered, "Altogether." A person asked her, "Do you love *me*?" She said, "O, I love Christ: I love my Christ. Jesus is precious, very precious indeed." She said to Miss M. "The Lord is very good. He keeps my soul above all." For fifteen hours before she died, she was in strong convulsions. Her sufferings were extreme. One said, "You are made perfect through sufferings." She said, "More and more so." After lying quiet some time, she said, "Lord, thou art strong!" Then pausing a [◆](#)considerable space, she uttered her last words, "My Jesus is all in all to *me*: glory be to him through time and eternity." After this she lay still for about half an hour, and then expired without a sigh or groan.

[◆](#) "conderable" replaced with "considerable"

L E T T E R S wrote by
J A N E C O O P E R.

LETTERS to Mrs. M. M.

August 29, 1757.

I SINCERELY rejoice, to find you are convinced of a most important, but self-abasing truth, that you are *yourself* utterly unable to work out your own salvation, or to form so much as one good thought, or one desire towards it. Rest not in this conviction, but seek, ask, knock: and you shall assuredly obtain that faith which is the gift of God. Give me leave to repeat, that religion consists, first, in a true knowledge of our want of Christ: Secondly, in knowing him to be not only the Saviour of the world, but *our* Saviour in particular; in knowing him to have died for *us*, that we might live through *him*. There is a great difference between this scheme of religion, and that we form to ourselves when we begin to desire eternal happiness. I then thought I must refrain from evil works, and be constant at church. And I should doubtless go to heaven, though I walked not in a narrow, but much frequented way. I saw not that Christ alone was the way to heaven; but though I could not but see my works were insufficient, yet I hoped God would accept this patch-work obedience, and supply what was wanting. Beware of building *your* hopes on this sandy foundation. Seek, but seek forgiveness and acceptance with God, through him who is the rock of ages. Let him not go until he bless you. For there is no safety but in his friendship, and no peace but in his favour.

May every blessing attend my dear friend. Wherever her abode is, she has a place in my heart.

November 9.

*DON'T you think me cruel, that I can rejoice to see you under the cross? I believe both our souls would wither, did not the rough wind rise to blow away the dust from our branches. When this is done, how salutary is the rain of grace, how refreshing the beams of love! I am persuaded there is not one tree of the Lord's planting, but must be purged, that it may bring forth much fruit. If you have been on the mount with *Peter, James, and John*, remember that was not the only proof our Lord gave them of his peculiar love: they, and they only were admitted to *Gethsemane*. Think on this, my dear friend, when you are under the cross, and wonder at the grace that calls, and that enables you to drink of that cup, and to have some fellowship with Christ in his sufferings. I believe your heart and mine have said,

"No cross, no suffering I decline:

Only let all my heart be thine."

This was recorded in the courts above, and is answered as we are able to bear. Look not so much at the trial, as at the grace which keeps you from sinking under it. You may be greatly oppressed: but omnipotence shall undertake for you. The enemy may thrust sore at you that you may fall: but claim *his* help who can and will deliver you. The floods of temptation may seem ready to overflow your soul. *But the Lord sitteth above the water-floods, and remaineth a King for ever. He shall give strength to his people; the Lord shall give his people the blessing of peace.* Fear not then, thou worm in thine own eyes. Since thou hast been precious, being bought with blood, thou art fair in his sight, who yet is of purer eyes than to behold iniquity. Therefore he sits as a refiner's fire, and as fuller's soap, on the souls of his people.

I feel Jesus near: he is better to me than I could ask or think. May your spirit find him nigh at this hour, and to the end of your warfare!

London.

*YOUR letter came in an acceptable time: I feared you would not write so soon, and the thought pained me. I found such union of heart with you last week, as it is pleasing pain to experience. I looked upon your's as an answer to prayer. The Lord generally causes me to ask for a letter before it comes: how shall I speak his praise? He is indeed Immanuel: and what can we ask more? That we may each moment feel his power in our hearts, and testify to all, that God is with us. But what are we, that God should dwell on earth! I am lost in the enquiry. And will God make a sinner happy? Or what is the same thing, will he make us holy? He will, our hearts cry out, he will! We shall be filled with the fulness of his love. He knows I pant, I thirst to prove this, to know more fully the grace of our Lord Jesus Christ: the Lord lets me drink of the brook in the way, before I reach the fountain-head. And I feel love to you, such love as only friendship knows, animated by the love of God.

I am better in body, but I believe the days of my appointed time are short. O blessed prospect beyond the grave! There I shall see him face to face! Help me by your prayers to keep the bright prize in view, that I may be ever running toward the mark. Jesus direct us to aim aright, and keep us from swerving aside into crooked paths!

Let me recommend much prayer to you: not only that praying frame of mind, which a Christian should continually possess, but frequent acts of secret prayer. And not only pray, but wait and expect the answer. I long, I love to hear, that you are sinking deeper in the knowledge of yourself, and rising higher in the love of God.

If I had time I should give you a week's journal. Sunday se'nnight I received the sacrament from Mr. *Madan*. It was indeed the communion of the body and blood of Christ. His banner over me was love. I was constrained to say, How plentiful is thy goodness, which thou hast laid up for the sons of men!

I hear frequent mention of persons who have great grace; some of whom are called *perfect*. I do not much like the term: but I am persuaded, the only way to overcome sin, and to inherit all things, is by enjoying uninterrupted communion with our God. I found something of this on Monday, and was much refreshed with the presence of the Lord. But on Tuesday I found my heart ready to depart from the living God. Yet I had reason to wonder and adore the grace that would not let me go. On Thursday I heard Mr. *Whitefield*, and had cause to rejoice with reverence. On Friday night a watch was kept at the Foundery, and I found the promise literally fulfilled, *They that trust in the Lord shall renew their strength*. Indeed his mercies are so oft repeated, that if I had not the most ungrateful heart, I should be always praising him. But I often find such an inward contest with pride, self-will, impatience, and all the legion which is contrary to the mind of Christ, that I groan being burthened: Yet I am persuaded, he can save to the uttermost, and believe he will save even me. Even now my soul rejoices in hope. He will perfect what is lacking in either of our spirits. O trust him with all your heart! Lean not to your own understanding. Believe the Lord; so shall you prosper. Be vigilant in all things; so shall you disappoint our enemy, and bring glory to our everlasting friend. Unto his protection I commit you, until the day we meet to part no more.

May 6, 1760.

I AM glad you are so conscious of danger. It is necessary to be exceedingly afraid of our hearts departing from the living God; this never goes without correction: and though these chastisements are proofs of his love, yet beware you do not bring them upon yourself.

I look upon your being at that place, as a very particular providence; yet I feel for you. I know many of nature's latent mazes will be discovered to you. Perhaps the cause and the effects will pain you. And what shall I say to comfort my friend? I cannot give the waters of consolation: such power belongs unto God only. O may he undertake for you in every hour of oppression! You may this moment find relief, by looking to an exalted Redeemer. I have been asking, that we might drink deep into the spirit of a crucified Saviour. Indeed I knew not the depth of what I asked: Lord, make us strong, to bear the answer of our request! Make us esteem it our greatest privilege, to taste that cup of which thou drankest so largely! Only saying with thee, *If it may not pass from me, Father, thy will be done.*

It is his absolute promise, *From all your idols will I cleanse you*; and your heart hath said, Amen! Do you now retract your petition? Do you not rather say still, in spite of nature's struggle, "Let all my heart be thine?" Is your *Isaac* called for? Ascend the mount, bid all things contrary to resignation stay behind. Have you endeavoured to do this, and are you still interrupted by the birds of prey? Are you still molested, when you would offer the sacrifice which God requires? O watch and keep off those enemies to your peace! And he that is your peace shall give you power.

Yes, "when your all of strength doth fail,

You shall with the God-man prevail."

He loves, he pities you, he requires your heart. And he is worthy to have it. O may he now reign therein, the Lord of every motion there!

Jesus has not left me comfortless. He still sustains me with his grace. May he bring us through this wilderness, to meet and part no more!

December 4.

I KNOW not whether the providence of God will ever permit me to see you again. But I can leave it to him, in sure hopes that I shall meet your happy spirit, in the realms of endless day. There we shall surely exult in a Redeemer's presence. We shall see him as he is. And indeed when I have a view, though a transient one, of the glory which shall be revealed, I am almost impatient of delay. I am ready to cry out, Why are thy chariot wheels so long in coming? I want leave to go hence, and be no more seen as an inhabitant of the earth. This has been for some time past my habitual desire. I cannot help being glad at night, that one day more of my allotted portion is past, and eternity is nearer to me than when I first believed. Yet at the same time, I have reason to be ashamed before the Lord, that I do not live to his glory. I do not love him with all my heart and strength; so far from it, that I sometimes feel I never did one action with a single eye to his glory. My own will has mixed,

And "Pride, that busy sin,

Spoil'd all that I perform'd."

'Tis well for *me*, that our high-priest bears the iniquity of my holy things. Indeed, if the altar did not sanctify the gift, I could not approach with one offering. O may he purify the sacrifice which I have often made, of all I have, or can, or am!

Watch! Stand stedfast, my dear friend, and be strong in the Lord! Remember, the God of peace shall shortly bruise Satan under your feet. May he give you every thing that will forward your growth in grace!

Norwich, May 11, 1762.

I AM but weak, but my soul is kept in peace. Who can express the blessing of feeling Christ our friend every moment? Indeed, I see no other way to profit my soul, but to come the present moment, as I am, to Jesus: He never sends me empty away. If I wish any thing, it is for more opportunity for private prayer. Between the sick, the afflicted, and those seeking the Lord, I have very little time to myself. However, I feel no desire, but to do and suffer his will. While I speak to you, I taste his goodness, above what words can describe. He knoweth, I desire to glorify him, to be altogether his, and to feel him all my own. I know of nothing in my soul, which is not given up to God. Pray him to examine and prove me, and to supply what is lacking.

To Mrs. J. C. M.

November 29, 1761.

I KNOW nothing of myself. But I know and feel, that God is love. I feel, I love him in a measure, and long for full conformity to Jesus. My soul is happy in him; and though I have not what I used to think was implied in the blessing which has been poured out upon many, yet I have (what I am not sufficiently thankful for) a deeper union with the source of blessedness, a constant sense of his unmerited love, and a knowledge that I am less than the least of all saints. I am persuaded, nothing shall separate me from the Lord Jesus. From him is my fruit found. In him are the springs of consolation, which revive and endue my soul with much strength. I trust in him, and know in whom I trust: therefore life or death is equal.

Labour still for all the Spirit's peaceful fruit. Jesus will bless your attempts to glorify him. He will make you unblameable in love before men, and unproveable before God. Know, that the eye of earth and heaven is upon you. Many wait for your halting: More, I trust, wish you success in the name of the Lord: I am sure I do, and therefore write without reserve. Take heed of your own understanding. Do not suffer yourself to think of it, but with abasement, that you have made no better use of it. Excuse this freedom: the motive is love unfeigned. I find the fruit of the cross even while I write. I sit under the shadow of my beloved, and feel him sustaining my soul. O Jesus, great is thy goodness! great is thy mercy! even toward the meanest, me! Bless, I pray thee, the sister of my spirit. Let her

“Antedate the joys above:

Ever feel her Saviour's love.”

I feel my insufficiency to speak of the goodness of God. It is more than I can express. He deals tenderly with me; and if I follow the best pattern, I shall be patient towards all. I have felt much bodily weakness, but no power to chuse its removal or continuance. I seem to enjoy all I want, while I pursue what I have not attained. I am daily more sensible how little I am. I think never one soul so utterly wanted a complete Saviour.

*I have taken the first opportunity to write, in hopes of profiting by your answer. I want to know the most effectual way to grow in grace; how to improve by all things; how to make good use of the dulness which often creeps upon my mind, and makes my soul stupidly inactive. I want to be all attention to God; to have every faculty of my mind fixedly waiting upon him: but I find myself beat off of this by weariness or listlessness. I often seem to stand fast in the Lord, and am steddily looking unto him; but (I suppose, through unwatchfulness) often lose the deep consciousness, that, “God is here:” yet he does not condemn me; but I abhor myself, while I see the Saviour graciously near. My heart crieth without a voice, “Come and mould thy passive clay. Keep my attention rightly exercised every moment.” And while I call, my Jesus answers. O, did I pray without fainting, I should then be what I wish.

I praise the lover of your soul, that he delights to bless you. May you ever see his full sufficiency to save, and live in the fountain-head of bliss!

January 26, 1762.

BLESSED be God, I only seek his approbation, and am content with that alone. The night you wrote, the Lord spake to my heart, “All is your’s.” I feel it true, for Christ is mine. Indeed he is precious to me. My soul is satisfied with its portion. Yet “eager I ask and pant for more.” But my wants do not discourage me. I delight to feel them, for I am persuaded out of his fulness I shall receive a supply. Even while I am receiving from him, he makes me capable of more. I am amazed at his grace.

“I cannot praise him as I wou’d,
But he is merciful and good,”

and does not despise the day of small things.

I know I have been unfaithful to the grace of God; yet ◆he pardons without upbraiding. O that every future moment may prove, I feel the time past sufficeth! When I consider you as a younger scholar, I am ashamed; yet I rejoice the Master loveth us both. And though he may justly say to me, “O, slow of heart to understand,” yet he teaches me, as I am able to receive, the lesson of his love. I often meet your spirit, when I go in secret before our Lord. He only knows, how much I desire you may increase, with all the increase of God. May you follow the Lamb in all things! I praise him, that he unites me to himself, and to all whose fellowship is with him: I thank him who gives us to drink into one spirit. My heart feels God continually nigh. My only wish is his will; my only desire his glory.

◆ “ye” replaced with “he”

Good Friday.

***I**T is given to you to suffer: and happy are you, if our Lord counts you meet to be his companion in the garden. I love his tempted followers above all: and his peculiar care is towards such as drink of his cup. I am thankful to him on behalf of your soul. Faithful is he that hath called you. He will establish your heart, and keep you from all evil, unto his heavenly kingdom.

I always find a fight before a conquest. I am generally warned of approaching trials, and when I am most filled with the consolations of God, I see how amiable it is to follow my Captain, who was made perfect through sufferings. He is daily teaching me the lesson of his cross. When it ceases to be necessary I shall suffer no more. I am often sensible, my own folly obliges him to put me to pain. I know he never willingly afflicts, but chastens in order to make us partakers of his holiness.

O praise our everlasting Friend, who never shews us a defect, but in order to amend it: my soul longeth to live to him. I feel his mercies new every morning. My spirit is so united to the Lord Jesus, that I am persuaded nothing shall separate me from his love. But I have no fruit of the Spirit, in the fulness I desire or expect. I am sensible my privileges are far higher than my attainments: and I want to be stirred up daily, to take the kingdom which is before me by violence.

Of late I have found private prayer the means which brought me nearest to God: but this he often varies, as his wisdom sees best. My soul is more simple than it was: I am learning to leave others to the care of our Shepherd, and desire only to hear and follow him. Let your soul delight itself in him: learn to know how he hath loved you. Be very active in his cause, and passive to his will. My spirit is all peace. May your's be preserved in Christ Jesus, who hath called you to glory and immortality.

April 21.

PEACE be with your spirit! The Lord shall guide thee continually, and satisfy thy soul in drought: thou shalt be like a watered garden; for the Lord Jesus is your well of salvation. With joy may you draw from his fulness, grace for every moment's want. His design is still to do us good; his delight is with the sons of men.

*I find my fellowship with heaven is increased since I wrote last: the King of eternity makes me capable of communing with him, and though I tread but the outward borders of his sanctuary, he causes me to hear his voice, inviting me to come forward. He assures me, he will help me to overcome, and gives me to inherit all things. But at the same time, he shews me my works are not perfect; and that I must watch and strengthen the things that remain. I find my safety and happiness depend, upon my dependance on Jesus. I want every moment to begin afresh the life of faith; to forget all things else, and be (as you said) "a person of one business," I have been much tempted lately, but I count it all joy, for it profiteth my soul. I have gained more self-contempt, and I love an empty spirit, because then there is room for Jesus.

"O what are all our sorrows here,
If, Lord, thou count us meet
With that inraptur'd host t' appear,
And worship at thy feet?"

It will soon be our employ. O let us now live in eternity! Antedate the joys above, by bringing all you have and are, to his feet. Cast all you have before him, and ascribe salvation to him, who of a stone, hath made a daughter of *Abraham*.

I think the grace you want most is thankfulness. Stir me up to patience. Pray that I may be nothing,

"Mean and vile in my own eyes,
Only in his wisdom wise."

Norwich, May 6.

THE Lord hath of late kept me much from reasoning myself into perplexity. When any thing occurs which I cannot understand, I carry it to him, who is a *wonderful Counsellor*: and he wipes away the tears from my eyes, by assuring me he is all my own. I feel a constant necessity of walking with the Lord, as I first received him: and I retain peace, as it was imparted, by simple faith. Who knows the value of faith? None but they who constantly exercise it, to their own profit, and the Redeemer's glory.

*I think your fears of deceiving the people, are only the result of strong temptations. We cannot see clearly in the time of a storm. This is not a season to examine whether we be in the faith: neither is reason alone sufficient to determine in spiritual matters. One thing is needful in your present situation, even to cast yourself upon the Lord, just as you are. Now come to him who waiteth to be gracious; who saith concerning sin or infirmity, "I will cleanse the blood which I have not cleansed." I fear, you have reasoned with the enemy, while you should have been looking unto Jesus; and by living a little beneath your privileges, have been ready to give up your claim to them. But Jesus was present, though your eyes were holden: And,

"Round you and beneath are spread

The everlasting arms."

Sunday Night.

THE Lord who inclined your heart to write, will reward your labour of love. I find him faithful who hath promised, *My grace is sufficient for thee*. I feel a measure of that love, which shall overcome by enduring: all I have and am is but a small offering; but this I can give up to Jesus. Ever since I tasted his love, I have been led in the way of the cross. It is a royal way: the King of kings walked in it: and while I tread in his steps, I experience the rugged way is pleasantness, and the thorny path is peace. Since I have more than ever gone through *evil report*, I have found more increase of faith and love. I cannot sufficiently praise the *friend who sticketh closer than a brother*. His banner over me is love, and my soul confesses he doth all things well.

I praise him on your behalf also. He rejoices over you to do you good. O lean on your Beloved with all your weight; so shall you find a sure support. If storms rise and winds blow, they will only settle you on the rock which cannot be moved. Believe simply; believe constantly; so shall you love steddily and entirely. I know no other way for the just to live, but by faith; and as we exercise faith it grows, 'till we can say in all circumstances, *This is the victory*.

I bless my God, I feel no desire to vindicate my conduct. I know the light of heaven shone on my path, and I am content to be approved of God alone. I feel my heart is given up without reserve, and see fresh cause to be daily more devoted to him. Blessed be God for Jesus Christ! In him I enjoy all I want. Bear me on your heart before him, and ask him to lead me to the thing and place he chuseth.

July 22.

YOUR's came in a seasonable time, as the return of prayer. I felt some pain because I did not hear from you sooner. But our God doth all things well; he shall supply all your wants, and make all grace to abound towards you. He delights to complete the work he begins, and happy is the soul that does not resist his will. He will call for the corn and will increase it, and will lay no famine upon you. Great is his faithfulness! Hearken diligently to the Shepherd's voice. He will teach us to profit by the present cross, and keep us in the spirit of sacrifice.

I feel my need of patience. I am closely and constantly exercised, but his grace is sufficient even for me. He generally teaches me by applying his word to my heart, so that I have cause to esteem it more than fine gold. I was greatly oppressed some nights ago, and found immediate deliverance from these words, *As birds flying, so will the Lord of hosts defend Jerusalem. Defending also he will deliver, and passing over he will preserve it.* I find much union with you, and believe you bear my burdens, and abide in prayer for me. I cannot forget you, and our friend in heaven remembers you for good.

I can no longer refrain from saying, Be strong in the grace that is in Christ Jesus. Let none beguile you of your simplicity, or the reward that attends it. I believe your light is shining out of obscurity, and will shine unto the perfect day. You are coming unto the light that your deeds may be made manifest, that they are wrought in God. In his light you behold yourself of *the circumcision, who worship God in the Spirit, rejoice in Christ Jesus, and have no confidence in the flesh.*

**They have great peace who love his law, and nothing shall offend them; he keeps us night and day.* I pleaded this promise last night, and made it my own by believing. He did keep my imagination, while I slept, subject to himself. Since I returned into the country, I have been blest with peace, which temptation of various kinds did not ruffle. My determination to know nothing but Jesus crucified, is much strengthened. This moment I can give up all for him, and do all things through him strengthening me. I have a testimony that I please him, and count his dear reproach greater treasure than the wealth or praise of men.

Be faithful in all things; this is your privilege; live up to it this moment. You know the way, walk therein, and pray always for

*Your affectionate sister,
And obliged friend.*

REJOICE in the Lord always; again I say rejoice. For he is become your everlasting light, and the days of your mourning are ended. I believe your sun shall no more go down, but you shall dwell on high. Your place of defence is in the munition of rocks; bread of life is given you; your waters shall not fail. Your eyes see the King in his beauty, and he will cause you to know him who was from the beginning. I drink with you into one spirit. Help me to bless God for the consolation; it increases by being mutual. My soul seems lost in wonder, love and praise, and is melted into thankful tears. Every sensation of gratitude in earth or heaven is bought with thy blood, O precious Jesus! the power to feel my obligations to him, proceedeth from above, and when we reach the top-stone, we shall still shout "Grace, grace unto it."

*I have all this day been in a disposition to cast my crown at his feet. I cannot express how much I choose to give all the glory to Christ my Lord. All within me acknowledges he is worthy to receive all glory. My love to Mrs. ——. Tell her, not one tittle shall fail of all the good things God hath spoken to her of. Only let her be strong, and not stagger at any of the promises. I believe, I need not say, pray always for

Your most affectionate sister in Jesus.

To Mrs. E. D.

My dear friend,

I Know you will rejoice to hear, God has gotten himself the victory, in the most stubborn heart, that ever submitted to Jesus.

He is my king, and makes me sit
In willing bonds beneath his feet.

Praise him, O my soul, praise him, O my sister, for still he is bringing lost sinners to God. Yea, he has brought *me* to God. I feel myself weak as helpless infancy; but Christ my strength is with me: at last I am a fool for his sake.

*When I left you on Friday, and had finished my business, I sat down alone and in misery. The Lord directed me to those words: *be not affrighted: I know whom ye seek; Jesus of Nazareth: he is not here, he is risen, and lo he goeth before you into Galilee; there shall you see him.* I believed I should, and came home in peaceful expectation. One who had seen his great salvation prayed, that he would bless me also: but my own wisdom opposed his coming, and the conflict was great. At length my vehement soul stood still, and the mountains flowed down at his presence. My heart was filled with holy shame and humble joy: I was a little child. I entered the kingdom; we praised our King till morning, and his praise is ever new and sweet. The Lord causes us to cease from our own works, and he is glorified. O pray for us! Pray for *me*, who every moment need the merit of his death. I can say no more, but I do love Christ, and I love *you* better than ever.

My dear friend,

TRULY God is loving unto *Israel*, even unto me: nevertheless my feet had well nigh slipt, for I was grieved at the wicked, and pained by the good. I have been more exercised in mind than ever I was before, and the last conflict always felt severest: but I begin to see that all these things work together for my good. I never was so much saved from trusting in any creature; Jesus was never more lovely in my eyes; I feel him only desirable; I cannot repeat his compassions, for they are endless. I proved them to be sufficient for me, when all besides failed me. I doubt not but I made my cross heavier than love intended, by my own folly: but the teacher of *Israel* rectifies mistakes with tenderness known only to himself. At present my desire is, to overcome by enduring. I want to think and act under the eye of him who loves me, and every moment to feel it upon me. My soul longs for nearer acquaintance with God. I know neither men nor devils need hinder my intercourse with Jesus. O that I were wise to improve what I receive, and faithful to retain what his mercy gives!

Use your interest for me at the throne of grace: and go on through your croud of difficulties, aiming at Jesus. He alone is worthy your pursuit!

We are forced to *feel* as well as *see*: God alone is our support. I have had much of his peaceful presence. He is indeed greater than our fears, and better than our hopes. I was much tried on Friday; but since that I have had no painful emotion. I feel for *you* in the tenderest manner my heart is capable. I see Jesus will vindicate his own, and claim all your heart for himself. He sees what wounds it, and will give medicine to heal all its sickness. I believe “all you feel is mercy.” But are you strong enough to support the weight? Why should his blessings be insupportable, through our softness of spirit? O that my friend were less susceptible of those impressions! O that a dull disciple might teach you to be in some matters more slow of understanding, of a more insensible spirit!

I see the commandment is exceeding broad, and this makes Christ exceeding precious. How valuable the advocate with the Father! My soul desires to know nothing but him crucified. May you feel life, abundant life in that knowledge! O how much my Saviour loves you? I feel a little of the sounding of his bowels toward you, and my heart cleaves to him, for his goodness to you. He counts you worthy to suffer. O be thankful for this special mark of his love!

* **A**LL this week I have been tried, but with intervals of rest. God is a jealous God, and will be loved alone: Jesus will convince us in time, that he alone is worthy of every power of the soul. I see a field of religion before me, which I want to walk in. I know I am called to make a perpetual offering of myself, and every enjoyment, to the will of God. I do long to be a Christian. My heart goeth out after this: when will it once be? That promise is now brought to my mind, *They shalt grow as willows by the water-courses*. 'Tis a mournful tree; I think we shall be weeping willows, 'till we are taken into the paradise of *God*. The peculiar privilege *there* is, all tears shall be wiped away from our eyes.

O how little do I know the meaning of Jesus? Surely 'tis mercy all. Even the minutest circumstance is by his order, and under his inspection. And he will suffer nothing to hurt the apple of his eye.

*I am to-day very weak in body. I feel the power of sympathizing with all in the house. All are tried. O Adam, what hast thou done? O Jesus, what hast thou suffered? How thou canst recover! Lord, let us know thy utmost power to save!

MY heart feels pure union with yours. I love you as disinterestedly as I think I can. Sure the Lord is pouring upon you the spirit of sacrificing all to him. I wish you good luck in his name! Go on, my dear friend. Life is a noble thing, while our employment is doing the will of God from the heart. May you clearly see what it is concerning you. I have at present, peace inward and outward. Pray, pray that I may

“Be thankful and humble,
But never stand still.”

***I** WANT your prayers and advice. I feel myself daily weaker, and more foolish than ever. I am as a little child learning to walk, and cannot go alone. At present I am guided by Jesus, and feel his grace sufficient for me; but there are depths of the Deity I want to fathom. I long to be lost in the immensity of his love!

My soul enjoys peace, solid peace at bottom: but its surface is filled with fights and fears. I am afraid of being too *outward*; I want grace to *deepen* in my soul. Blessed be God, my every want shall be supplied, from his fulness who filleth all.

MY dear friend gave me another proof of her tenderness, by not upbraiding me with neglect. I think you ought to go to the meetings [on Fridays] by all means: pray for those who speak not according to the law and the testimony. You will feel more deeply the help that is done upon earth: the Lord doth it himself. What is man that he is mindful of him! What is God, that he can be gracious to us! O may our souls every moment know, by a nearer acquaintance with him, that he is love!

You are laid upon my heart to pray for: sure God is faithful to his word, he *will* hear and answer, and endue your soul with much strength.

“Suffering faith shall brighter grow,
As gold when in the furnace tried.”

*I am persuaded your Lord will be with you, and make your weakness more than conquer. He is wonderful in counsel; he has a way in the whirlwind: he cannot mean any thing but mercy to your soul: for he has given himself and all that he counted dear to you! What then would you with-hold from him? Methinks I hear you say, “Nothing. I would offer all I have or am to his will, when I know it is *his*.” And can you doubt this? *Is there an evil in the city, and the Lord hath not done it?* Can a sparrow fall, or *Shimei* curse *David* without permission? Nay, Satan himself can do nothing without leave. O my God, shine on thy servant’s heart, that she may see thy hand of love holds the cup. And if she is called

“To bear the full anguish,
The uttermost load,
Yet give her to languish
And suffer like God!”

My dear friend, what shall I say, to dissuade you from over much sorrow? I can only love you, and speak to Jesus, that he may order your conduct to his glory.

May, 1762. Norwich.

JJOIN to praise the Lord, who still supports my feebleness of mind, carries all my burdens, and suffers me to desire nothing but his righteous, glorious will. I see infinite wisdom and unfathomable love, in all his dispensations towards me: I can now believe, that all things shall work together for good: I want words to tell you the sense I have of the goodness of God, far better felt than described: I find his consolations sufficient to support me under present difficulties, and am persuaded his grace will be equal to every future trial. I like your proposal, but dare scarce form one plan. May the Lord do with me as is good in his sight!

To the Reverend Mr. —.

February 21, 1761.

YOUR obliging request lays me under a happy necessity, of calling to mind the past mercies of God. May every review of them bring trust for future blessings, and thankfulness for the present.

*Ever since I can remember, I was desirous of happiness; but I did not seek it in God. I thought if I was religious, I should go to heaven; but I knew not the nature of true religion, and I was unwilling to be under the restraint of that I did know: yet so great a stranger was I to myself, that I often thought, if I knew what God required, I would perform it. At sixteen I was confirmed, and made many resolutions; but they soon wore off. I had a strong impression on my mind, that I should die when I was four and twenty. I reflected on those who were put apprentice seven years to learn a trade, and thought I ought to use like application, to learn the business of eternity.

I went to the sacrament the day I was eighteen, and found uncommon satisfaction: I exhorted others to do the same, thinking I had now done all that was commanded me, and that if I continued in the same way, I should be a very profitable servant.

Soon after this I went to *London*, for eight weeks, where I heard Mr. *Jones* (of *Southwark*) preach, and was affected at hearing of the sufferings of Christ, much as I used to be at seeing or reading of a tragedy. I was afterwards asked to hear Mr. *Romaine*. I did so, but could not understand him. The night I left *London*, some persons were debating about the Millennium. One of them repeated part of the 20th chapter of the *Revelation*. I was struck at the awful words, and thought if Christ was then to come, I was not prepared to meet him. I went home very serious, and began to search the scriptures, and to be more strict than ever. I was often troubled, but knew not the cause, and was ashamed to confess my fears. My friends thought I had a fever on my spirits, and I thought so too; but as I read much, I began to fear, that with all my religion, I was not converted. I wanted to go to *London*, that I might hear Mr. *Romaine*. A year after I went to *London* with my father-in-law. At the inn where we lay, I saw Mr. *Whitefield's* sermons. I read what I could, and determined to hear him. He was not in town; but I was much affected with Mr. *Dyer's* preaching. Afterwards I not only went to St. *Dunstan's*, but to all the methodist places of worship I knew, and one evening heard Mr. *Walsh*, at *West-street*. He preached the necessity of that *holiness, without which none can see the Lord*. His words were as arrows in my heart: I found all my former righteousness deficient: I knew this could not obtain mercy; but I did not feel I deserved hell. I wrote to Mr. *Romaine* to know, what I should do to be saved? He desired to see me, and told me, two things were necessary, to know my want of Christ, and my interest in him. I went home with the greatest reluctance; for I knew no Christians in the town where I lived. My former acquaintance thought me mad: my mother was greatly alarmed. Not long after I went to *Norwich* for a few days, and found out Mr. *Mitchell*. He spoke to me of the peace which faith brings to the conscience. I knew myself a stranger to this; but would willingly have suffered the rack, so I might attain it. I went home, and was, for five or six weeks, in a most unhappy situation. Before, I was not bad enough to come to Christ; now, I was too bad for him to receive; yet the Lord dealt tenderly with me, and at different times brought many encouraging scriptures to my mind. But still the stupidity and unbelief I felt caused me to mourn in secret. Still I was constrained to say,

“Scarce I begin my sad complaint,
When all my warmest wishes faint:
Hardly I lift my weeping eye,
When all my kindling ardors die:
Nor hopes nor fears my bosom move,
For still I cannot, cannot love!”

I could not rest thus, though I concluded, it would always be the case: I expected to be miserable all my life, and to perish at the last: I found it as easy to reach heaven with my hand, as to believe Jesus died for *me*. I felt, *no one can come to Christ, except the Father draw him*. Now I knew, it was the work of God, to believe on him whom he hath sent. I prayed he would work faith in *me*, but seemed as distant from God as hell from heaven: I was cut off from all self-dependence: I was a sinner stript of all.

I was on my knees striving to pray, when I heard inwardly a voice say, “Thy sins are forgiven thee.” I felt the truth of it in my heart, and in a moment prayer was lost in praise. I called upon the angels to join with me, in blessing him who died for *me*! He caused his goodness to pass before me, and I rejoiced with joy unspeakable.

Yet in a few hours after I began to fear I had deceived myself, and all was delusive. I was much distressed, and had recourse to prayer, and the Lord repeated his mercies, and impressed the same words on my mind, more strongly than before. I was more assured of his forgiving love, and enjoyed much peace in believing. I now thought, I never could sin more. My mind was taken up with God, and I conversed with him as a man would with his friend. My confidence in him was unshaken, and my hope full of immortality.

I wanted others to rejoice with me; but they were *strangers to Jesus*, and *intermeddled not with my joy*. I lamented being alone. My nearest friends thought I carried things too far. My mother was more alarmed; for I could not speak but on religious subjects. A neighbouring clergyman advised her to confine me, if I offered to hear the Methodists. This I did at all opportunities, though none was nearer than four miles off. Her tenderness gave me much pain. I was sorry to grieve her in any thing; and yet I did not dare to oblige her, by acting contrary to my conscience. I could not play at cards, nor join in trifling discourse, though my refusal was deemed preciseness.

I was near two years at home after this. Then the Lord fulfilled his promise: He *gave me the bread of adversity and the water of affliction*; but *my eyes did see my teachers*. I was now more desirous than ever, to be made conformable to the will of God: but I thought, to believe the doctrine of perfection, was derogating from the priestly office of Christ.

When I first saw you, Sir, at *Norwich*, notwithstanding my prejudice to your opinions, I found that reverence and esteem for you, which have increased ever since. My understanding was then better informed, and my desires more fervent for all the grace God had in store for me. I trust my soul is still alive to God, and athirst for righteousness. He has borne my manners in the wilderness, and sustains me in my utter helplessness. He continues to multiply his pardons, and heap his benefits upon me. Every trial is sent in mercy; every temptation is permitted for my good; every cross has proved a blessing in disguise. In *his* light I see this: I believe he is able to keep me from falling, and to make me perfect and entire, lacking nothing. My present situation requires more of every grace, than any I have been in before: but, I trust, he in whom all fulness dwells, will supply my every want.

I would not have troubled you with so long a letter, but indeed “I had not time to make it shorter.” And I am desirous to prove by every means, that I regard your advice, and on all occasions speak with freedom. I am, dear Sir,

Your obliged Servant,

J. C.

April 14, 1761.

Reverend and dear Sir,

GOD has been more gracious to my soul than I could ask or think. I find him as a place of broad waters, deep and large, and I feel my inability to fathom that depth of love. In Jesus are all the treasures of wisdom and knowledge hid: and he has begun to reveal them to the most ignorant soul. But it is impossible to describe the goodness of God, the great God, to so unworthy an object!

From the last morning you preached, I was stirred up to seek him more diligently than ever. You then discovered my heart to me, and what was wanting there. I was kept in prayer, and would have parted with all things, so I might win Christ. I wanted to love him with all my heart; but my own wisdom was his rival. Nothing less than Omnipotence could destroy this: and his own right hand got the victory. I was made sensible how compleatly foolish, and entirely helpless I was. My vehement soul stood still; and I saw Jesus was all my salvation. He was all my desire; and I knew he was made unto me sanctification and redemption. He appears as a priest, upon the throne, who shall bear the glory for ever. I feel my continual need of him, in all his offices. He is truly precious to my soul; but I want to know him more, and the power of his resurrection. I am happy in his love; but I want more intimate acquaintance and a deeper union with him. I see, the just shall live by faith: and unto me, who am less than the least of all saints, is this grace given. If I were an archangel, I should veil my face before him, and let silence speak his praise!

May 2.

I BELIEVE, while memory remains in me, gratitude will continue. I know, many are the troubles of the righteous: but out of them all doth the Lord deliver. I have never desired to hide any distress or difficulty from you at any time. Is this any reason, why you should tell *me*, what those are which now surround you? If I could remove the least of them by knowing it, I should be importunate.

From the time you preached on *Galatians* v. 5. I saw clearly the true state of my soul. That sermon described my heart, and what it wanted to be truly happy. You read Mr. M.'s letter, and it described the religion which I desired. From that time the prize appeared in view, and I was enabled to follow hard after it. I was kept watching unto prayer, sometimes in much distress, at others in patient expectation of the blessing. For some days before you left *London*, my soul was stayed on a promise I had applied to me in prayer, *The Lord whom ye seek shall suddenly come to his temple*. I believed he would, and that he would sit there as a refiner's fire. The Tuesday after you went, I thought I could not sleep, unless he fulfilled his word that night. I never knew, as I did then, the force of these words, *Be still, and know that I am God*. I became nothing before him, and enjoyed perfect calmness in my soul. I knew not whether he had destroyed my sin; but I desired to know, that I might praise him. Yet I soon found the return of unbelief, and groaned, being burdened. On Wednesday I went to *London*, and sought the Lord without ceasing. I promised, if he would save me from sin, I would praise him. I could part with all things, so I might win Christ. But I found all these pleas nothing worth, and that if he saved *me*, it must be freely for his own name's sake. On Thursday, after I had been with *S. Guildford*, and *B. Dixon*, I was so much tempted, that I thought of destroying myself, or never conversing more with the people of God. And yet I had no doubt of his pardoning love: but "'twas worse than death my God to love, and not my God alone." On Friday my distress was deepened. I endeavoured to pray, and could not. I went to Mrs. *D.* who prayed for me, and told me, it was the death of nature. I opened the bible on *the fearful and unbelieving—shall have their part in the lake which burneth with fire and brimstone*. I could not bear it. I opened it again on *Mark* xvi. 6, 7. *Be not affrighted: Ye seek Jesus of Nazareth.—Go your way; tell his disciples, he goeth before you into Galilee; there shall ye see him*. I was encouraged, and enabled to pray, believing I should see Jesus at home. I returned that night, and found Mrs. *G.* She prayed for me: and the Predestinarian had no plea, but, "Lord, thou art no respecter of persons." He proved he was not, by blessing *me*. I was in a moment enabled to lay hold on Jesus Christ, and found salvation by simple faith. He assured me, the Lord, the King was in the midst of me, and that I should see evil no more. I now blessed him, who had visited and redeemed me, and was become my wisdom, righteousness, sanctification, and redemption. I saw Jesus altogether lovely, and knew he

was mine in all his offices. And glory be to him, he now reigns in my heart without a rival. I find no will but his. I feel no pride, nor any affection but what is placed upon him. I know, it is by faith I stand, and that watching unto prayer must be the guard of faith. I am happy in God this moment, and I believe for the next. I have often read the chapter you mention, and compared my heart and life with it. In so doing, I find my short-comings, and the need I have of the atoning blood. Yet I dare not say, I do not feel a measure of the love there described, though I am not all I shall be. I desire to be lost in that love which passeth knowledge. I wish for no joy, but what increases love.

London, September 29, 1762.

Reverend and dear Sir,

I THANK you for another proof of your care for my soul, in the enquiries you make. I bless my Lord, his grace is sufficient to make me answer, without hesitation, every question you propose. I have for many months enjoyed such a continuance of the presence of my beloved, as makes me feel I am less than the least of his mercies. The beholding of him, who is fairer than the sons of men, the sight of Christ crucified, prevents the touch of pride, and makes me hate the garment spotted by the flesh. The testimony that I desire is not from man, and the approbation of God never makes me high-minded. Rather I rejoice to him with reverence. He teaches me to delight myself in him: and I feel, I cannot be displeased with any thing that is his choice, I know that I please him; for he testifies of my works, that they are wrought in him.

Indeed Jesus is unspeakably precious.

“Words are too mean to speak his worth,
Too mean to set my Saviour forth.”

He daily makes to me new discoveries of his grace and power, and every fresh manifestation more effectually unites my heart to him who is altogether lovely. I love my friends in him: he gives the affection I feel, and it always leads to him. I believe, when I quit the inconveniencies of mortality, I shall love with greater “strength and elegance,” every friend to whom Jesus has now united my soul. And what we now know in part, we shall prove in eternity, *God is love; and whoso dwelleth in love, dwelleth in God, and God in him.* My desire for you is, that you may increase with all the increase of God, and return to us in the fulness of the gospel of peace. I believe you will, and that you will be a blessing to me and many.

I think Mr. *Bell* is willing to take any advice you think proper to give him. I repeat what I said before: they that seek dissension, are not friends to the work of God. I trust you labour for peace, and the God of peace shall be with you always.

I daily give up all to Jesus, and have no sacrifice to make, which is not offered up already. He gives me strength for all he calls me to bear: and I find it easy for the love which *believes*, to *endure all things*.

May the God whom you serve bless your labours with great success! I wish you good luck in his name. The weapons of your warfare are mighty through him: you need not fight uncertainly, as one that beateth the air, but prove in every circumstance, *This is the victory, even our faith*. Continue to shew your care over me, by reproving and advising me as you judge needful. I am sensible of all my obligations to you, and am,

Dear Sir,

Your obliged and affectionate Servant.

SOME ACCOUNT
OF
THE EXPERIENCE
OF
E. J.

1. FOR many years I had a desire to love God, and thought I could submit to be of any sect or denomination, if this would bring me nearer to him: only rejecting the name of a *Methodist*. For I thought them to be a deluded people, and the off scouring of the earth. I was in this temper, when I heard a Minister preach on *All mine are thine, and thine are mine*. It came to my heart, and I found such a measure of happiness, as I never had done before. But having none to strengthen my hands, or build me up, it gradually died away.

2. After this, a clergyman having been at prayers, a gentlewoman asked me, how I liked him? I said, "Very well: he has had a liberal education, and speaks in a graceful manner." She said, "But man cannot reach the heart. Did you ever hear the small still voice, whispering peace to your soul?" I felt something of prejudice rise at the question, and replied, "I have lived a good life. I have done no harm, and I do not omit my duty. I go to church every day." She said, "I am sorry you have got no further." I was surprised at her impertinence, and rose up to go away. She intreated me to stay a little, saying, "I have but another word to speak. If you are not delivered by a higher power than you have known yet, you will never be saved." The word *higher power* struck me to the heart, and brought a ray of light, which shewed me, that notwithstanding all my works, I was *without God in the world*. I found a load of guilt which struck me with terror. I saw my heart was as a cage of unclean birds. I believed, now I shall be a castaway, and knew not where to hide me. I could not speak, but withdrew and retired to my closet, and wrestled with God in mighty prayer. I resolved not to let him go till he had blessed me: crying, "I renounce all I am and all I have: if thou hast any blessing for me, bless me now!" Thus I continued an hour, when those words came with power, *Abide in me and I in thee*. I cried out with much assurance, "My Lord and my God! What is this thou hast done for me?" In the twinkling of an eye my soul was quickened. The seed of God was sown in my heart. My sins were blotted out, and I was raised from the dead, by the word of reconciliation. I felt virtue proceed from Christ, which took away my sins. I now partook of Angel's food, and knew that I was born of God.

3. For three weeks I remained exceeding happy. My lamp was lighted, and I had oil in my vessel. The scriptures were opened to me, and were spirit and life: in the Lord's supper I found the peace that passeth all understanding. None can express the excellency of the virtue which flows from the merits of Christ. I was grafted into the vine, and thereby enabled to *draw water out of the wells of salvation*. Yet I found, there was much in me contrary to the will of God. I had not all the mind that was in Christ. Nay, there remained much of the carnal mind. There was enmity, and strife, and vainglory, which soon embittered my sweets. My heart was bent to backsliding, and continually ready to comply with the suggestions of Satan. I gave way to evil reasoning, which caused peevishness and impatience: and these ate the life of God out of my soul. I could not *endure hardness*: in every storm I was ready to give up my confidence. I could not love God with an undivided heart. It was my desire, to praise him without ceasing: but I could not perform it, for some hindrance was still coming in the way. The Lord often refreshed me by the way: but this did not satisfy. What I wanted was, to have my heart entirely devoted to him. But I found there remained in me a root of bitterness, a stubborn will, and a diabolical nature, capable of committing all manner of wickedness, were it not for restraining grace. Yet I had no light into the scriptures, so as to divide the word, and make a distinction between the justifying and the sanctifying promises. So I was content to be a babe, if my inward corruptions would have let me be at peace. Yea, I had in my heart an utter aversion to the doctrine of entire sanctification, and found all the enmity in me rose against those who spoke of experiencing it. One day hearing a preacher say, we could not live many hours after we were sanctified, my heart readily joined with him. But presently I was struck with those words, *Without holiness no man shall see the Lord*. I fain would have stifled this conviction. At least, I cared not to think of it yet. I thought, Why it is but thirteen months since I was justified. And need I think of being sanctified already? However, if ever I should be, none shall ever know it. But the light increased more and more, and my desires at the same time, till I hungred and thirsted vehemently for something, but I knew not what. One day I was constrained to come unto the Lord, and was seized with an awful sense of his Majesty. I trembled, and for some moments was as in a silent darkness. I was ready to cry, Whither am I going? For it seemed, as if he was going to strike the blow, and send me to everlasting destruction. But I found a spark of light, and

cried, "Where is my Jesus? He can *save to the uttermost*." Presently I cried, "Lord, come quickly!" Yet I had a dread of his coming; for it appeared, as if something strange was going to happen to me. But I said, "Lord, thou prayest for me: O pray for me, that I may *now* get the victory! Help *now* my unbelief! Renew me wholly in thy image and likeness! Give me faith, and faith's increase, that I may be wholly saved from sin." I then found fresh strength, and cried vehemently, "If thou hast any blessing for me, bless me now! Unworthy as I am, yet I claim, in Christ, my full redemption. I mean to take no denial. Give me all thou hast purchased. Loose me from myself, that I may lie passive in thy hand. Lord, if thou wilt, thou canst make me clean!" But I found there was a dark cloud, which still remained between God and my soul. Then I cried, "Lord, let me touch the scepter of thy righteousness. I resign my life and my all. Make me now whole, and take me to thyself." While I thus pleaded, I was in an agony between hope and despair, till those words came as a mighty rushing wind, *A clean heart I give unto thee*. I received the word with gladness and in much assurance. Soon after came, *Be not faithless, but believing*. At these happy words every cloud was dispelled, and I saw the light which shineth to the perfect day. I found access to the holy of holies, where I now see the Trinity in Unity. The Lord *shineth* unto me *in perfect beauty*: I enjoy an inseparable union with him without intermission. The little leaven has leavened the whole lump. All my senses are now fully employed in spiritual exercise. The love of God, flaming in my heart as an unquenchable fire, has burnt up all the dross, and destroyed every plant which was not of his own planting. I find that oneness with him, being made *one spirit with the Lord*, which enables me to walk with him like *Enoch*, so that I converse with him by his Spirit, as ♦*familiarly as a man doth with his friend*. I find now no want, no inward conflict, but my soul dwells in a peaceable habitation. I am enabled to walk as in the noon-day sun: my heart is fixed, and my soul is watered every moment. Yet the fear of the Lord is ever before me, lest I should grieve the Holy Spirit. I watch and guard the sacred treasure in my heart, not daring to give way to a word or thought, without finding the approbation of the Lord, by the powerful operation of his Spirit. Hereby I know and *prove what is that good, and acceptable, and perfect will of God*. He manifests his strength in my weakness. I am but a worm; yet he delights to bless me, and has made me perfect in his love, so that nothing interrupts my joy. He enables me, not to lose a moment of time, and to live but a moment at once.

My *hope* is *full of immortality*; and I find no want of spiritual food, no more than if I was in heaven already. Nothing in me opposes the will of God: in nothing can I either wish or chuse. For he hath given me to *walk before him in all well-pleasing*, and to *sit in heavenly places with Christ Jesus*. My loins are girt, my lamp burning, and my soul flourishing as the palm-tree.

◆ “familiar” replaced with “familiarily”

4. For these ten years I have enjoyed this haven of rest. It has been to me as a day without a cloud. I never have had a tedious moment, nor a murmuring thought. I have been tempted in all things; yet nothing obscures my light, or obstructs my way; but still *I rejoice evermore, pray without ceasing, and in every thing give thanks*. My heart is prepared, whenever my Lord knocks, to open to him immediately. For grace has overcome death: the thoughts of death are my glory and joy. I know, that I am every moment ready to be offered, being made in Christ unrebukeable, without spot, a spiritual sacrifice, wholly devoted to God.

5. God now permitted the grace he had given to be tried. I was not born to dwell on one spot of ground, but was banished from all that was near and dear to me, and driven from city to city. I now proved the happy effects of faith. When I was buffeted by Satan, his darts took no place in me: I defied him, and all his works. When I am roughly treated by the world, *I stand still, and see the salvation of God*. And the more I am tempted, so much the more the pure flame revives; and the love of God, ever flaming in the heart, keeps out every occasion of stumbling. This enables me to *rejoice in tribulation*, and glory in the cross: for I find, by his grace, my soul is *even as mount Zion, which cannot be moved*. I am freed from all anxious thoughts and painful fears. I *take no thought for the morrow*. I live to-day, and have nothing to do but to die. I know, my soul is prepared to meet my God. In nothing hitherto have I been ashamed, with all boldness giving thanks unto the Lord. And now I ascribe all glory to him, who hath made me a partaker of that holiness, without which no man shall see the Lord.

6. Think it not strange, that he should give this suddenly. When he comes to justify, he comes quickly. And when he comes to sanctify, he comes quickly. This also is an instantaneous work. And no man can love God with all his heart, and grow up into Christ in all things, so as to enjoy all the mind that was in Christ, till he is *sanctified throughout, body, soul, and spirit*.

7. As we were justified, so are we sanctified by one single act of faith. Then is the soul made like a flame of fire, and the heart is in one continual frame of praising God. Then the fulness of Christ is brought into the soul; even as much of the glory of God as this earthly tabernacle can bear. Then is our inbred sin destroyed. This is the cause of all our transgressions, and while any of this remains, it is the believer's hell, and makes him cry out, *Who shall deliver me from the body of this death?* Christ will deliver you. He has purchased for you a full redemption. He has regained paradise, and restores the soul to that acquaintance with God which *Adam* lost. By faith, I ever see him that is invisible, and converse with him, as it were, face to face. I stand naked before the Lord, and am not ashamed; but rejoice in being sensible, that he knows the secret thoughts of my heart. I rejoice, that he has taught me to *put on the whole armour of God*, and has made it as easy to me, to do and suffer the will of God, as it is to *the sparks to fly upward*.

8. Pull off then this veil of unbelief, and trample sin and Satan under your feet. Be you also a faithful witness of Christ, that he is *able to save to the uttermost*, that he hath power even on earth to save from all sin, *from all filthiness both of flesh and spirit*. My experience will profit another nothing, unless applied to the heart by the Spirit of God. And is not this the one thing needful for you, to be *filled with faith and with the Holy Ghost*? May the Lord hasten the time, when this faith shall cover the earth, *as the water covers the sea*! Then shall they not need to teach this to one another: For *all shall know Him, from the least even to the greatest*.

9. O that sinners would give up their own wisdom, and become fools, that they may be made wise! Cannot the Lord do a great work in a little time? In the hour that he convinced *me* of the necessity of it, before that hour was expired, I was justified. Thirteen months after (as I before observed,) I was convinced of the necessity of full sanctification. That night, before I slept, God gave me the blessing. And is he a *respector of persons*? Who then would not cry unto him? Who would not spend a few hours in fervent prayer? O let your hearts yield! Draw near unto the Lord, and he will draw near unto *you*. He will draw you after him by the cords of his love, and you will begin to *smell the sweet odour of his ointments*. Then open your hearts to my beloved; for *his voice is sweet, and his countenance comely. Let my beloved come into his garden, and eat his pleasant fruit*. He says, *Arise, my love, and come away!* I will chide thee no more for thy past follies. Only now *give me thy heart*. Thou shalt then find, *the winter is past, the singing of birds is come, and the voice of the turtle is heard in the land*. Then will you get new eyes, new hearts, new delights, and every thing will have a satisfying relish. Then will you chide yourselves, for having been so long in pursuit of the things that perish in the using! Then will he give you the pearl that *Adam* lost, that heart-felt union with God, whereby you shall steadily enjoy his immediate presence: and his presence makes our paradise. You shall walk in the light, having his bright beams ever shining upon you. So that

Not a cloud shall arise,

To darken the skies,

Or hide for a moment the Lord from your eyes.

An E A R N E S T A P P E A L
TO MEN OF
REASON and RELIGION.

JOHN vii. 51.

*Doth our law judge any man BEFORE it HEAR him, and KNOW WHAT
HE DOTH?*

ALTHOUGH it is with us a very *small thing to be judged of you or of man's judgment*, seeing we know God will *make our innocence as clear as the light, and our just dealing as the noon-day*; yet are we ready to give any that are willing to hear, a plain account, both of our principles and actions: as having *renounced the hidden things of shame*, and desiring nothing more, *than by manifestation of the truth to commend ourselves to every man's conscience in the sight of God*.

*2. We see (and who does not?) the numberless follies and miseries of our fellow-creatures. We see on every side, either men of no religion at all, or men of a lifeless, formal religion. We are grieved at the sight, and should greatly rejoice, if by any means we might convince some, that there is a better religion to be attained, a religion worthy of God that gave it. And this we conceive to be no other than love; the love of God, and of all mankind; the loving God with all our heart and soul, and strength, as having first loved *us*, as the fountain of all the good we have received, and of all we ever hope to enjoy; and the loving every soul which God hath made, every man on earth, as our own soul.

*3. This love we believe to be the medicine of life, the never-failing remedy, for all the evils of a disordered world, for all the miseries and vices of men. Wherever this is, there are virtue and happiness, going hand in hand. There is humbleness of mind, gentleness, long suffering, the whole image of God, and at the same time a peace that passeth all understanding, and joy unspeakable and full of glory.

“Eternal sunshine of the spotless mind;
Each pray’r accepted, and each wish resign’d:
Desires compos’d, affections ever even,
Tears that delight, and sighs that waft to heav’n.”

4. This religion we long to see established in the world, a religion of love, and joy, and peace, having its seat in the inmost soul, but ever shewing itself by its fruits, continually springing forth not only in all innocence, (for love worketh no ill to his neighbour) but likewise in every kind of beneficence, spreading virtue and happiness all around it.

5. This religion have we been following after for many years, as many know, if they would testify: but all this time, seeking wisdom we found it not; we were spending our strength in vain. And being now under full conviction of this, we declare it to all mankind: for we desire not that others should wander out of the way, as we have done before them; but rather that they may profit by our loss, that they may go (tho’ we did not, having then no man to guide us) the straight way to the religion of love, even by faith.

*6. Now faith (supposing the scripture to be of God) is πραγμάτων
♦ἐλέγχος οὐ βλεπομένων, the demonstrative evidence of things unseen, the supernatural evidence of things invisible, not perceivable by eyes of flesh, or by any of our natural senses or faculties. Faith is that divine evidence, whereby the spiritual man discerneth God, and the things of God. It is with regard to the spiritual world, what sense is with regard to the natural. It is the spiritual sensation of every soul that is born of God.

♦ “ἔαγχος οὐ βλπομένων” replaced with “ἔλεγχος οὐ βλεπομένων”

7. Perhaps you have not considered it in this view; I will then explain it a little further.

Faith, according to the scriptural account, is the eye of the new-born soul. Hereby every true believer in God, *seeth him who is invisible*. Hereby (in a more particular manner, since life and immortality have been brought to light by the gospel) he *seeth the light of the glory of God in the face of Jesus Christ*; and, *beholdeth what manner of love it is, which the Father hath bestowed upon us, that we* (who are born of the Spirit) *should be called the sons of God*.

It is the ear of the soul, whereby a sinner *hears the voice of the Son of God and lives*; even that voice which alone wakes the dead, *Son, thy sins are forgiven thee*.

It is (if I may be allowed the expression) the palate of the soul: for hereby a believer *tastes the good word, and the powers of the world to come*; and *hereby he both tastes and sees that God is gracious, yea, and merciful to him a sinner*.

It is the feeling of the soul, whereby a believer perceives, thro' the *power of the Highest over-shadowing him*, both the existence and the presence of him, in whom *he lives, moves, and has his being*; and indeed the whole invisible world, the entire system of things eternal. And hereby, in particular, he feels *the love of God shed abroad in his heart*.

*8. *By this faith we are saved* from all uneasiness of mind, from the anguish of a wounded spirit, from discontent, from fear, and sorrow of heart, from that inexpressible listlessness and weariness, both of the world and of ourselves, which we had so ♦ helplessly laboured under for many years; especially when we were out of the hurry of the world, and sunk into calm reflection. In this we find that love of God, and of all mankind, which we had elsewhere sought in vain. This we know and feel, and therefore cannot but declare, saves every one that partakes of it, both from sin and misery, from every unhappy and every unholy temper.

◆ “helplesly” replaced with “helplessly”

“Soft peace she brings, wherever she arrives,
She builds our quiet, as she forms our lives;
Lays the rough paths of peevish nature even,
And opens in each breast a little heaven.”

9. If you ask, “Why then have not all men this faith? All at least who conceive it to be so happy a thing? Why do they not believe immediately?”

We answer, (on the scripture hypothesis) *It is the gift of God*. No man is able to work it in himself. It is a work of Omnipotence. It requires no less power thus to quicken a dead soul, than to raise a body that lies in the grave. It is a new creation; and none can create a soul anew but he who at first created the heavens and the earth.

*10. May not your own experience teach you this? Can you give yourself this faith? Is it now in your power to see, or hear, or taste, or feel God? Have you already, or can you raise in yourself any perception of God, or of an invisible world? I suppose you do not deny, that there is an invisible world: you will not charge it in poor old *Hesiod*, to Christian prejudice of education, when he says, in those well known words,

Millions of spiritual creatures walk the earth
Unseen, whether we wake, or if we sleep.

Now, is there any power in your soul, whereby you discern either these, or him that created them? Or, can all your wisdom and strength open an intercourse between yourself and the world of spirits? Is it in your power to burst the veil that is on your heart, and let in the light of eternity? You know it is not. You not only do not, but cannot (by your own strength) thus believe. The more you labour so to do, the more you will be convinced, *it is the gift of God*.

*11. It is the *free gift* of God, which he bestows not on those who are *worthy* of his favour, not on such as are *previously holy*, and so *fit* to be crowned with all the blessings of his goodness: but on the ungodly and unholy; on those who till that hour were *fit* only for everlasting destruction; those in whom was no good thing, and whose only plea was, *God, be merciful to me a sinner*. No merit, no goodness in man precedes the forgiving love of God. His pardoning mercy supposes nothing in us but a sense of mere sin and misery: and to all who see, and feel, and own their wants, and their utter inability to remove them, God freely gives faith, for the sake of him *in whom he is always well pleased*.

12. This is a short, rude sketch of the doctrine we teach. These are our fundamental principles: and we spend our lives in confirming others herein, and in a behaviour suitable to them.

Now, if you are a reasonable man, although you do not believe the Christian system to be of God, lay your hand upon your breast, and calmly consider, what it is that you can here condemn? What evil have we done to *you*, that *you* should join the common cry against us? Why should *you* say, *Away with such fellows from the earth: it is not fit that they should live?*

13. 'Tis true, your judgment does not fall in with ours. We believe the scripture to be of God. This you do not believe. And how do you defend yourselves against them who urge you with the guilt of unbelief? Do you not say, "Every man *must* judge according to the light he has, and that if he be true to this, he ought not to be condemned?" Keep then to this, and turn the tables. *Must* not we also judge according to the light we have? You can in no wise condemn *us*, without involving *yourselves* in the same condemnation. According to the light *we* have, we cannot but believe the scripture is of God; and, while we believe this, we dare not turn aside from it, to the right hand, or to the left.

*14. Let us consider this point a little farther. You yourself believe there is a God. You have the witness of this in your own breast. Perhaps sometimes you tremble before him. You believe there is such a thing as right and wrong, that there is a difference between moral good and evil. Of consequence, you must allow, there is such a thing as conscience; I mean, that every person, capable of reflection, is conscious to himself, when he looks back on any thing he has done, whether it be good or evil. You must likewise allow, that every man is to be guided by his own conscience, not another's. Thus far, doubtless, you may go, without any danger of being a *volunteer* in faith.

15. Now then, be consistent with yourself. If there be a God, who being just and good, (attributes inseparable from the very idea of God) is a *rewarder of them that diligently seek him*, ought we not to do whatever we believe will be acceptable to so good a Master? Observe: if we *believe*, if we are fully persuaded of this in our mind, ought we not thus to seek him? And that with all diligence? Else, how should we expect any reward at his hands?

16. Again: Ought we not to do what we believe is morally good, and to abstain from what we judge is evil? By good I mean, conducive to the good of mankind, tending to advance peace, and good-will among men, promotive of the happiness of our fellow-creatures; and by evil, what is contrary thereto. Then surely you cannot condemn our endeavouring after our power, to make mankind happy; (I now speak only with regard to the present world) our striving, as we can, to lessen their sorrows, and to teach them in whatsoever state they are, therewith to be content.

17. Yet again. Are we to be guided by *our own* conscience, or by that of other men? *You* surely will not say, that any man's conscience can preclude *mine*. *You*, at least, will not plead for robbing us, of what you strongly claim for yourselves. I mean, the right of private judgment, which is indeed unalienable from reasonable creatures. *You* well know, that unless we faithfully follow the dictates of *our own* mind, we cannot have a conscience void of offence toward God and towards man.

*18. Upon your own principles therefore you must allow us to be, at least, innocent. Do you find any difficulty in this? You speak much of prepossession and prejudice; beware you are not entangled therein yourselves. Are you not prejudiced against *us*, because we believe and strenuously defend that system of doctrines which you oppose? Are you not enemies to *us*, because you take it for granted we are so to *you*? Nay, God forbid! I once saw one, who, from a plentiful fortune, was reduced to the lowest extremity. He was lying on a sick bed, in violent pain, without even convenient food, or one friend to comfort him: so that when his merciful landlord, to compleat all, sent one to take his bed from under him, I was not surprized at his attempt to put an end to so miserable a life. Now, when I saw that poor man, weltering in his blood, could I be angry at him? Surely no. No more can I at *you*. I can no more hate than I can envy you. I can only lift up my heart to God for *you* (as I did then for him) and, with silent tears, beseech the Father of mercies, that he would look on you in your blood, and say unto you, *Live*.

*19. “Sir, (said that unhappy man, at my first interview with him) I scorn to deceive you or any man. You must not tell me of your bible; for I don’t believe one word of it. I know there is a God, and believe he is all in all, the *Anima mundi*, the

“vastam

Mens agitans molem, & magno se corpore miscens.”

“But farther then this, I believe not; all is dark, my thought is lost. But I hear (added he) you preach to a great number of people every night and morning. Pray, what would you do with them? Whither would you lead them? What religion do you preach? What is it good for?” I replied, “I do preach to as many as desire to hear, every night and morning.” You ask, “What I would do with them?” I would make them virtuous and happy, easy in themselves, and useful to others. “Whither would I lead them?” To heaven; to God the Judge, the lover of all, and to Jesus the Mediator of the new covenant. “What religion do I preach?” The religion of love; the law of kindness brought to light by the gospel. “What is this good for?” To make all who receive it enjoy God and themselves: To make them like God; lovers of all; contented in their lives; and crying out at their death, in calm assurance, *O grave where is thy victory! thanks be unto God, who giveth me the victory, thro’ my Lord Jesus Christ.*

20. Will you object to such a religion as this; that it is not reasonable? Is it not reasonable then to love God? Hath he not given you life, and breath, and all things? Does he not continue his love to you, filling your heart with food and gladness? What have you not received of him? And does not love demand a return of love? Whether therefore you do love God or no, you cannot but own it is reasonable so to do; nay, seeing he is the parent of all good, to love him with all your heart.

21. Is it not reasonable also to love our neighbour? Every man whom God hath made? Are we not brethren? The children of one father? Ought we not then to love one another? And should we only love them that love us? Is that acting like our Father which is in heaven? He causeth his sun to shine on the evil and on the good, and sendeth rain on the just and on the unjust. And can there be a more equitable rule (the only adequate measure of brotherly love, in all our words and actions) *Whatsoever ye would that men should do unto you, even so do unto them.*

22. Is it not reasonable then, that as we have opportunity, we should do good unto all men? Not only friends but enemies, not only to the deserving, but likewise to the evil and unthankful. Is it not right that all our life should be one continued labour of love? If a day passes without doing good, may one not well say, with *Titus, Amici, diem perdidit!*¹ And is it enough, to feed the hungry, to cloath the naked, to visit those who are sick or in prison? Should we have no pity for those

Who sigh beneath guilt's horrid stain,

The worst confinement, and the heaviest chain?

Should we shut up our compassion toward those who are of all men most miserable, because they are miserable by their own fault? If we have found a medicine to heal even that sickness, should we not, as we have freely received it, freely give? Should we not pluck them as brands out of the fire? The fire of lust, anger, malice, revenge? Your inmost soul answers, It should be done; it is reasonable in the highest degree. Well, this is the sum of our preaching, and of our lives, our enemies themselves being the judges. If therefore you allow, that it is reasonable to love God, to love mankind, and to do good to all men, you cannot but allow, that religion which we preach and live, to be agreeable to the highest reason.

¹ My friends, I have lost a day!

23. Perhaps “all this you can bear. It is tolerable enough: and if we spoke only of being *saved by love*, you should have no great objection: but you do not comprehend what we say of being *saved by faith*.” I know you do not. You do not in any degree comprehend what we mean by that expression; have patience then, and I will tell you yet again. By those words, *we are saved by faith*, we mean, that the moment a man receives that faith which is above described, he is saved from doubt and fear, and sorrow of heart, by a peace that passes all understanding; from the heaviness of a wounded spirit, by joy unspeakable; and from his sins, of whatsoever kind they were; from his vicious desires, as well as words and actions, by the love of God, and of all mankind, then shed abroad in his heart.

24. We grant, nothing is more unreasonable, than to imagine that such mighty effects as these, can be wrought by that poor, empty, insignificant thing, which the world *calls* faith, and you among them. But supposing there be such a faith on the earth, as that which the apostle speaks of, such an intercourse between God and the soul, what is too hard for such a faith? You yourselves may conceive, that *all things are possible to him that thus believeth*: to him that thus *walks with God*, that is now a citizen of heaven, an inhabitant of eternity. If therefore you will contend with *us*, you must change the ground of your attack. You must flatly deny there is any faith upon earth: but perhaps this you might think too large step. You cannot do this, without a secret condemnation in your own breast. O that you would at length cry to God for that heavenly gift! Whereby alone this truly reasonable religion, this beneficent love of God and man, can be planted in your heart.

25. If you say, “But those that profess this faith are the most unreasonable of all men;” I ask, “Who are those that profess this faith?” Perhaps you do not personally know such a man in the world. Who are they that so much as profess to have *this evidence* of things not seen? That profess to *see him that is invisible*? To *hear the voice* of God, and to have *his Spirit* ever *witnessing with their spirits*, that *they are the children of God*? I fear you will find few that even profess *this faith*, among the large numbers of those who are called believers.

*26. "However, there are enough that profess themselves Christians." Yea, too many, God knoweth: too many that confute their vain professions, by the whole tenour of their lives. I will allow all you can say on this head, and perhaps more than all. 'Tis now some years since I was engaged unawares in a conversation with a strong reasoner, who at first urged the wickedness of the *American Indians*, as a bar to our hope of converting them to Christianity. But when I mentioned their temperance, justice, and veracity, (according to the accounts I had then received) it was asked, "Why, if those Heathens are such men as these, what will they gain by being made Christians? What would they gain by being *such Christians* as we see every where round about us?" I could not deny, they would lose, not gain, by such a Christianity as this. Upon which she added, "Why, what else do you mean by Christianity?" My plain answer was, What do you apprehend to be more valuable than good sense, good nature, and good manners? All these are contained, and that in the highest degree, in what I mean by Christianity. Good sense, (so called) is but a poor, dim shadow of what Christians call faith. Good nature is only a faint, distant resemblance of Christian charity. And good manners, if of the most finished kind that nature assisted by art can attain to, is but a dead picture of that holiness of conversation, which is the image of God visibly expressed. All these put together by the art of God, I call Christianity. "Sir, if this be Christianity, (said my opponent in amaze) I never saw a christian in my life."

27. Perhaps it is the same case with *you*. If so, I am grieved for you, and can only wish, 'till you do see a living proof of this, that you would not say, *you see a christian*. For this is scriptural christianity, and this alone. Whenever therefore you see an unreasonable man, you see one who perhaps calls himself by that name, but *is* no more a *christian* than he is an *angel*. So far as he departs from true, genuine reason, so far he departs from christianity. Do not say, this is only asserted, not proved. It is undeniably proved by the original charter of christianity. We appeal to this, to the written word. If any man's temper, or words, or actions are contradictory to right reason; it is evident to a demonstration, they are contradictory to this. Produce any possible or conceivable instance, and you will find the fact is so. The lives therefore of those who are *called* christians, is no just objection to christianity.

28. We join with you then in desiring a religion founded on reason, and every way agreeable thereto. But one question still remains to be asked, what do you mean by *reason*? I suppose you mean the eternal reason, or, the nature of things: The nature of God, and the nature of man, with the relations necessarily subsisting between them. Why, this is the very religion we preach: a religion evidently founded on, and every way agreeable to eternal reason, to the essential nature of things. Its foundation stands on the nature of God and the nature of man, together with their mutual relations. And it is every way suitable thereto: to the nature of God; for it begins in knowing him; and where but in the true knowledge of God, can you conceive true religion to begin? It goes on in loving him, and all mankind, (for you cannot but imitate whom you love:) It ends in serving him; in doing his will; in obeying him whom we know and love.

29. It is every way suited to the nature of man; for it begins in a man's knowing himself; knowing himself to be what he really is, foolish, vicious, miserable. It goes on to point out the remedy for this, to make him truly wise, virtuous, and happy; as every thinking mind (perhaps from some implicit remembrance of what it originally was) longs to be.

It finishes all, by restoring the due relations between God and man; by uniting for ever the tender Father, and the grateful, obedient Son; the great Lord of all, and the faithful servant, doing not his own will, but the will of him that sent him.

30. But perhaps by reason you mean, the faculty of reasoning, of inferring one thing from another.

There are many, it is confessed, (particularly those who are stiled mystic divines) that utterly decry the use of reason, thus understood, in religion: nay, that condemn all reasoning concerning the things of God, as utterly destructive of true religion.

But we can in no wise agree with this. We find no authority for it in holy writ. So far from it, that we find there both our Lord and his apostles continually reasoning with their opposers. Neither do we know, in all the productions of antient and modern times, such a chain of reasoning or argumentation, so close, so solid, so regularly connected, as the epistle to the *Hebrews*. And the strongest reasoner whom we have ever observed, (excepting only *Jesus of Nazareth*) was that *Paul of Tarsus*; the same who has left that plain direction for all christians, *In malice, or wickedness, be ye children; but in understanding, or reason, be ye men.*

31. We therefore not only allow, but earnestly exhort all who seek after true religion, to use all the reason which God hath given them, in searching out the things of God. But your *reasoning justly*, not only on this, but on any subject whatsoever, presupposes *true judgments* already formed, whereon to ground your argumentation. Else, you know, you will stumble at every step: because *ex falso non sequitur verum*. It is impossible, if your premisses are false, to infer from them true conclusions.

32. You know likewise, that before it is possible for you to form a *true judgment* of them, it is absolutely necessary, that you have a *clear apprehension* of the things of God, and that your ideas thereof be all *fixed, distinct, and determinate*. And seeing our *ideas* are not innate, but must all originally come from our *senses*; it is certainly necessary that you have *senses* capable of discerning objects of this kind. Not those only which are called *natural senses*, which in this respect profit nothing, as being altogether incapable of discerning objects of a spiritual kind; but *spiritual senses*, exercised to discern spiritual good and evil. It is necessary that you have *the hearing ear*, and the *seeing eye*, emphatically so called; that you have a new class of senses opened in your soul, not depending on organs of flesh and blood, to be *the evidence* of things not seen, as your bodily senses are of visible things; to be the avenues to the invisible world, to discern spiritual objects, and to furnish you with ideas of what the outward eye *hath not seen, neither the ear heard*.

33. And till you have these *internal senses*, till the eyes of your understanding are opened, you can have no *apprehension* of divine things, no *idea* of them at all. Nor consequently, till then, can you either *judge truly*, or *reason justly* concerning them: seeing your reason has no ground whereon to stand, no materials to work upon.

34. To use the trite instance. As you cannot *reason* concerning colours, if you have no *natural sight*, because all the *ideas* received by your other senses are of a different kind; so that neither your *hearing*, nor any *other sense*, can supply your want of *sight*, or furnish your reason in this respect with matter to work upon: So you cannot *reason* concerning spiritual things, if you have no *spiritual sight*; because all your ideas received by your *outward senses* are of a different kind. Yea, far more different from those received by faith or *internal sensation*, than the idea of colour from that of sound. These are only different species of one genus, namely, sensible ideas, received by external sensation: whereas the ideas of faith differ *toto genere* from those of *external sensation*. So that it is not conceivable, that *external sensation* should supply the want of *internal senses*; or furnish your *reason* in this respect with matter to work upon.

35. What then will your reason do here? How will it pass from things natural to spiritual? From the things that are seen to those that are not seen? From the visible to the invisible world? What a gulph is here? By what art will reason get over the immense chasm? This cannot be, till the Almighty come in to your succour, and give you that faith you have hitherto despised. Then upborn as it were on eagle's wings, you shall soar away into the regions of eternity; and your enlightened reason shall explore even *the deep things of God*, God himself *revealing them to you by his Spirit*.

36. I expected to have received much light on this head, from a treatise lately published, and earnestly recommended to me, I mean, *Christianity not founded on argument*. But on a careful perusal of that piece, notwithstanding my prejudice in its favour, I could not but perceive, that the great design uniformly pursued throughout the work, was to render the whole of the christian institution both odious and contemptible. In order to this, the author gleans up, with great care and diligence, the most plausible of those many objections that have been raised against it by late writers, and proposes them with the utmost strength of which he was capable. To do this with the more effect, he *personates* a christian: he *makes a shew* of defending an avowed doctrine of christianity, namely, the supernatural influence of the Spirit of God; and often, for several sentences together, (indeed in the beginning of almost every paragraph) speaks so *like a christian*, that not a few have received him according to his wish. Meanwhile with all possible *art and show of reason*, and in the most laboured language, he pursues his point throughout, which is to prove, “that christianity is contrary to reason;” or, “that no man acting according to the principles of reason, can possibly be a christian.”

37. It is a wonderful proof of the power that smooth words may have even on serious minds, that so many have mistook such a writer as this for a friend of christianity: since almost every page of his tract is filled with gross falshood and broad blasphemy: and these supported by such *exploded* fallacies, and *common-place* sophistry, that a person of two or three years standing in the university, might give them a sufficient answer, and make the author appear as *irrational* and contemptible as he labours to make Christ and his apostles.

38. I have hitherto spoken to those chiefly, who do not receive the christian system as of God. I would add a few words to another sort of men; (though not so much with regard to *our* principles or practice, as with regard to *their own*;) to you who *do* receive it, who believe the scripture, but yet do not take upon you the character of *religious men*. I am therefore obliged to address myself to you likewise under the character of *men of reason*.

39. I would only ask, Are you such indeed? Do you answer the character under which you appear? If so, you are consistent with yourselves. Your principles and practice agree together.

Let us try whether this is so or not. Do you not take the name of God in vain? Do you remember the sabbath-day, to keep it holy? Do you not speak evil of the ruler of your people? Are you not a drunkard, or a glutton, faring as sumptuously as you can every day? Making a God of your belly? Do you not avenge yourself? Are you not a whoremonger or adulterer? Answer plainly to your own heart, before God the judge of all.

Why then do you say, you believe the scripture? If the scripture is true, you are lost. You are in the broad way that leadeth to destruction. Your damnation slumbereth not. You are heaping up to yourself wrath against the day of wrath, and revelation of the righteous judgment of God. Doubtless, if the scripture is true, (and you remain thus) it had been good for you if you had never been born.

40. How is it that you call yourselves men of reason? Is reason inconsistent with itself? You are the farthest of all men under the sun from any pretence to that character. A common swearer, a sabbath-breaker, a whoremonger, a drunkard, who says he believes the scripture is of God, is a monster upon earth, the greatest contradiction to his own, as well as to the reason of all mankind. In the name of God, (that worthy name whereby you are *called*, and which you daily cause to be blasphemed) turn either to the right hand or to the left. Either profess you are an infidel, or be a christian. Halt no longer thus between two opinions. Either cast off the bible, or your sins. And in the mean time, if you have any spark of your boasted reason left, do not *count us your enemies* (as I fear you have done hitherto, and as thousands do wherever we have declared *they who do such things shall not inherit eternal life*) *because we tell you the truth*: seeing these are not our words, but the words of him that sent us. Yea, though in doing this, we use *great plainness of speech*, as becomes the ministry we have received. *For we are not as many who corrupt* (cauponize, soften, and thereby adulterate) *the word of God. But as of sincerity, but as of God, in the sight of God, speak we in Christ.*

*41. But, it may be, you are none of these. You abstain from all such things. You have an unspotted reputation. You are a man of honour, or a woman of virtue. You scorn to do an unhandsome thing, and are of an unblameable life and conversation. You are harmless, (if I understand you right) and useless from morning to night. You do no hurt,—and no good to any one, no more than a straw floating upon the water. Your life glides smoothly on from year to year; and from one season to another, having no occasion to work,

“You waste away

In gentle inactivity the day.”

42. I will not now shock the easiness of your temper, by talking about a future state. But suffer me to ask you a question about present things. Are you now happy?

*I have seen a large company of *reasonable creatures*, called *Indians*, sitting in a row on the side of a river, looking sometimes at one another, sometimes at the sky, and sometimes at the bubbles on the water. And so they sat, (unless in the time of war) for a great part of the year, from morning to night.

These were doubtless much at ease. But can you think they were happy? —And how little happier are you than they?

*43. You eat, and drink, and sleep, and dress, and dance, and sit down to play. You are carried abroad. You are at the masquerade, the theatre, the opera-house, the park, the levee, the drawing-room. What do you do there? Why, sometimes you talk; sometimes you look at one another. And what are you to do to-morrow? The next day? The next week? The next year? You are to eat, and drink, and sleep, and dance, and dress, and play again. And you are to be carried abroad again, that you may again look at one another! And is this all? Alas, how little more happiness have you in this, than the *Indians* in looking at the sky or water!

*Ah poor, dull round! I do not wonder that Colonel *M*—— (or any man of reflection) should prefer death itself, even in the midst of his years, to such a life as this! And should frankly declare, “that he chose to go out of the world, because he found nothing in it worth living for.”

44. Yet it is certain there is business to be done: and many we find in all places (not to speak of the vulgar, the drudges of the earth) who are continually employed therein. Are you of that number? Are you engaged in trade, or some other reputable employment? I suppose, profitable too; for you would not spend your time, and labour, and thought, for nothing. You are then making your fortune; you are getting money. True: but money is not your ultimate end. The treasuring up gold and silver, for its own sake, all men own, is as foolish and absurd, as grossly unreasonable, as the treasuring up spiders, or the wings of butterflies. You consider this but as a means to some farther end. And what is that? Why, the enjoying yourself, the being at ease, the taking your pleasure, the living like a gentleman. That is plainly, either the whole, or some part of, the happiness above described.

*Supposing then your end to be actually attained, suppose you have your wish, before you drop into eternity: go and sit down with *Thleeanowhee* and his companions, on the river side.—After you have toiled for fifty years, you are just as happy as they.

45. Are you, can you, or any reasonable man, be *satisfied* with this? You are not. It is not possible you should. But what else can you do? You *would* have something better to employ your time; but you know not where to find it upon earth.

*And indeed it is obvious, that the earth, as it is now constituted, even with the help of all *European* arts, does not find sufficient employment, to take up half the waking hours of half its inhabitants.

*What then can you do? How can you employ the time that lies so heavy upon your hands? This very thing which you seek, declare we unto you. The thing *you* want, is the religion *we* preach. That alone leaves no time upon our hands. It fills up all the blank spaces of life. It exactly takes up all the time we have to spare, be it more or less: so that *he that hath much, hath nothing over, and he that has little, has no lack.*

46. Once more. Can you (or any man of reason) think, you was made for the life you now lead? You cannot possibly think so, at least, not till you tread the bible under foot. The oracles of God bear thee witness in every page, (and thine own heart agreeth thereto) that thou wast made in the image of God, an incorruptible picture of the God of glory. And what art thou even in thy present state? An everlasting spirit, going to God. For what end then did he create thee, but to dwell with him, above this perishable world, to know him, to love him, to do his will, to enjoy him for ever and ever! O look more deeply into thyself! And into that scripture, which thou professest to receive as the *word of God*, as *right concerning all things*. There thou wilt find a nobler, happier state described, than it ever yet entered into thy heart to conceive. But God hath now revealed it to all those who *rejoice evermore*, and *pray without ceasing*, and *in every thing give thanks*, and *do his will on earth as it is done in heaven*. For this thou wast made. Hereunto also thou art called. O be not disobedient to the heavenly calling! At least, be not angry with those who would fain bring thee to be a living witness of that religion, *whose ways are indeed ways of pleasantness, and all her paths peace*.

47. Do you say in your heart, “I know all this already. I am not barely a man of reason. I am a religious man; for I not only avoid evil and do good, but use all the means of grace. I am constantly at church, and at the sacrament too. I say my prayers every day. I read many good books. I fast——every *thirtieth of January, and Good-friday*.” Do you indeed? Do you do all this! This you may do; you may go thus far, and yet have *no religion* at all; *no such religion* as avails before God: nay, much farther than this, than you have ever gone yet, or so much as thought of going. For you may *give all your goods to feed the poor*, yea, *your body to be burned*, and yet very possibly, if St. Paul be a judge, *have no charity*, no true religion.

48. This religion, which alone is of value before God, is the very thing you want. You want (and in wanting this, you want all) the religion of love. You do not love your neighbour as yourself, no more than you love God with all your heart. Ask your own heart now, if it be not so? 'Tis plain you do not love God. If you did, you would be happy in him. But you know, you are not happy. Your *formal* religion no more makes you happy, than your neighbour's *gay* religion does him. O how much have you suffered for want of plain-dealing! Can you now bear to hear the naked truth? You have *the form of godliness*, but not *the power*. You are a mere whited wall. Before the Lord your God I ask you, are you not? Too sure. For your *inward parts are very wickedness*. You love *the creature more than the Creator*. You are *a lover of pleasure more than a lover of God*. A lover of God! You do not love God at all, no more than you love a stone. You love the world; therefore the love of the Father is not in you.

49. You are on the brink of the pit, ready to be plunged into everlasting perdition. Indeed you have a zeal for God: but not according to knowledge. O how terribly have you been deceived! Posting to hell, and fancying it was heaven. See, at length, that *outward religion* without *inward*, is nothing; is far worse than nothing, being indeed no other than a solemn mockery of God. And *inward religion* you have not. You have not the faith *that worketh by love*. Your *faith* (so called) is no living, saving principle. It is not the apostle's faith, *the substance* (or subsistence) *of things hoped for, the evidence of things not seen*. So far from it, that *this* faith is the very thing which you call *enthusiasm*. You are not content with being without it, unless you blaspheme it too. You even revile that *life which is hid with Christ in God*; all seeing, tasting, hearing, feeling God. These things are *foolishness unto you*. No marvel; *for they are spiritually discerned*.

50. Oh! no longer shut your eyes against the light. Know you have a name that you live, but are dead. Your soul is utterly dead in sin; dead in pride, in vanity, in self-will, in sensuality, in love of the world. You are utterly dead to God. There is no intercourse between your soul and God. *You have neither seen him* (by faith, as our Lord witnessed against them of old time) *nor heard his voice at any time*. You have no spiritual senses exercised to discern spiritual good and evil. You are angry at infidels, and are all the while as mere an infidel before God as they. You have *eyes that see not, and ears that hear not*. You have a *callous, unfeeling* heart.

51. Bear with me a little longer: my soul is distress for you. *The God of this world hath blinded your eyes*, and you are *seeking death in the error of your life*. Because you do not commit gross sin, because you give alms, and go to the church and sacrament, you imagine that you are serving God; yet in very deed you are serving the devil. For you are doing still your own will, not the will of God your Saviour. You are pleasing yourself in all you do. Pride, vanity, and self-will, (the genuine fruits of an earthly, sensual, devilish heart) pollute all your words and actions. You are in darkness, in the shadow of death. Oh! That God would say to you in thunder, *Awake thou that sleepest, and arise from the dead, and Christ shall give thee light*.

52. But blessed be God! He hath not yet left himself without witness!

“All are not lost! There be, who faith prefer,
Tho’ few, and piety to God!”

Who know the power of faith, and are no strangers to that inward, vital religion, *the mind that was in Christ, righteousness, and peace, and joy in the Holy Ghost*. Of you who *have tasted the good word of God, and the powers of the world to come*, I would be glad to learn if we have *erred from the faith*, or walked contrary to *the truth as it is in Jesus*. *Let the righteous smite me friendly, and reprove me*; if haply that which is amiss may be done away, and what is wanting supplied, till we all come to the measure of the stature of the fulness of Christ.

53. Perhaps the first thing that now occurs to your mind, relates to the doctrine which we teach. You have heard, that we say, “Men may live without sin.” And have you not heard that the scripture says the same? (We mean without committing sin.) Does not St. *Paul* say plainly, that those who believe, *do not continue in sin?*——That they cannot *live any longer therein?* Romans vi. 1, 2. Does not St. *Peter* say, *He that hath suffered in the flesh, hath ceased from sin?*——*that he no longer should live—to the desires of men, but to the will of God,* 1 Peter iv. 1, 2. And does not St. *John* say expressly, *He that committeth sin is of the devil.—For this purpose the Son of God was manifested, that he might destroy the works of the devil. Whosoever is born of God, doth not commit sin: for his seed remaineth in him, and he cannot commit sin, because he is born of God,* 1 John iii. 8. &c. And again, *We know that whatsoever is born of God sinneth not,* chapter v. 18.

54. You see then, it is not we that say this, but the Lord. These are not our words, but his, And who is he that replieth against God? Who is able to make God a liar? Surely he will be justified in his saying, and clear when he is judged! Can you deny it? Have you not often felt a secret check, when you was contradicting this great truth? And how often have you wished for what you was taught to deny? Nay, can you help wishing for it at this moment? Do you not now earnestly desire, to cease from sin? To commit it no more? Does not your soul pant after this glorious liberty of the sons of God? And what strong reason have you to expect it? Have you not had a foretaste of it already? Do you not remember the time when God first lifted up the light of his countenance upon you? Can it ever be forgotten? The day when the candle of the Lord first shone upon your head?

“Butter and honey did you eat,
And lifted up on high,
You saw the clouds beneath your feet,
And rode upon the sky.
“Far, far above all earthly things
Triumphantly you rode;
You soar’d to heav’n on eagle’s wings,
And found, and talk’d with God.”

You then had power not to commit sin. You found the apostle’s words strictly true, *he that is begotten of God keepeth himself, and that wicked one toucheth him not*. But those whom you took to be experienced Christians, telling you, “This was only the time of your espousals; this could not last always: you must come down from the mount,” and the like, shook your faith. You looked at men more than God, and so became weak, and like another man. Whereas, had you then had any to guide you according to the truth of God, had you then heard the doctrine which now you blame, you had never fallen from your stedfastness: but had found, that in this sense also, *the gifts and calling of God are without repentance*.

55. Have you not another objection nearly allied to this, namely, that we preach perfection? True; but what perfection? The term you cannot object to; because it is scriptural. All the difficulty is, to fix the meaning of it, according to the word of God. And this we have done again and again, declaring to all the world, that Christian perfection does not imply an exemption, from ignorance, or mistake, or infirmities, or temptations: but that it does imply, the being so crucified with Christ, as to be able to testify, *I live not, but Christ liveth in me*, (Galatians ii. 23.) and *hath purified my heart by faith*, (Acts xv. 9.) It does imply, *the casting down every high thing that exalteth itself against the knowledge of God, and bringing into captivity every thought to the obedience of Christ*. It does imply, *the being holy, as he that hath called us is holy, in all manner of conversation*, (2 Corinthians x. 5. 1 Peter i. 15.) And, in a word, *the loving the Lord our God with all our heart, and serving him with all our strength*.

56. Now, is it possible for any who believe the scripture, to deny one tittle of this? You cannot. You dare not. You would not for the world. You know it is the pure word of God. And this is the whole of what we preach; this is the height and depth of what we (with St. *Paul*) call perfection: a state of soul devoutly to be wished, by all who have tasted of the love of God. O pray for it without ceasing. It is the one thing you want. Come with boldness to the throne of grace, and be assured that when you ask this of God, you shall have the petition you ask of him. We know indeed that to man, to the natural man, this is impossible. But we know also, that as *no word is impossible with God, so all things are possible to him that believeth.*

57. For *we are saved by faith.* But have you not heard this urged as another objection against us, that we preach salvation by faith alone! And does not St. *Paul* do the same thing? *By grace,* saith he, *ye are saved through faith.* Can any words be more express? And elsewhere, *Believe in the Lord Jesus, and thou shalt be saved,* Acts xvi. 31.

What we mean by this (if it has not been sufficiently explained already) is, that we are saved from our sins, only by a confidence in the love of God. As soon as we *behold what manner of love it is which the Father hath bestowed upon us, we love him,* (as the apostle observes) *because he first loved us.* And then is that commandment written in our heart, *that he who loveth God love his brother also:* from which love of God and man, meekness, humbleness of mind, and all holy tempers, spring. Now these are the very essence of salvation, of Christian salvation, salvation from sin. And from these, outward salvation flows, that is, holiness of life and conversation. Well, and are not these things so? If you know in whom you have believed, you need no further witnesses.

58. But perhaps you doubt, whether that faith whereby we are thus saved, implies such a trust and confidence in God as we describe. “You cannot think faith implies assurance: an assurance of the love of God to our souls, of his being now reconciled to us, and having forgiven all our sins.” And this we freely confess, that if number of voices is to decide the question, we must give it up at once; for you have on your side, not only some who desire to be Christians indeed, but all nominal Christians in every place, and the *Romish* church, one and all. Nay, these last are so vehement in your defence, that in the famed council of *Trent*, they have decreed, “If any man hold (*fiduicam*) trust, confidence, ♦or assurance of pardon to be essential to faith, let him be accursed.”

♦ word missed in typeset “or”

59. Thus does that council anathematize the church of *England*. For she is convicted hereof, by her own confession. The very words in the Homily on Salvation are, “Even the devils believe, that Christ was born of a virgin; that he wrought all kind of miracles, declaring himself very God; that for our sakes he suffered a most painful death, to redeem us from death everlasting. These articles of our faith the devils believe; and so they believe all that is written in the Old and New Testament. And yet for all this faith, they be but devils. They remain still in their damnable estate, lacking the very true, Christian faith.”

“The right and true Christian faith is, not only to believe the holy scriptures, and the articles of our faith, are true; but also to have a sure trust and confidence, to be saved from everlasting damnation through Christ.” Or, (as it is exprest a little after.) “A sure *trust and confidence which a man hath in God, that by the merits of Christ his sins are forgiven, and he reconciled to the favour of God.*”

60. Indeed the bishop of *Rome* saith, “If any man hold this, let him be an Anathema Maranatha.” But ’tis to be hoped, *Papal* Anathemas do not move *you*. You are a member of the church of *England*. Are you? Then the controversy is at an end. Then hear the church. Faith is a sure trust which a man hath in God, that his sins are forgiven. Or if you are not, whether you hear our church or no, at least hear the scriptures. Hear believing *Job*, declaring his faith, *I know that my Redeemer liveth*. Hear *Thomas*, (when having seen, *he believed*) crying out, *My Lord and my God!* Hear *St. Paul* clearly describing the nature of *his faith*, *The life I now live, I live by faith in the Son of God, who loved me, and gave himself for me*. Hear (to mention no more) all the believers who were with *Paul*, when he wrote to the *Colossians*, bearing witness, *We give thanks unto the Father, who hath delivered us from the power of darkness, and hath translated us into the kingdom of his dear Son: in whom we have redemption thro’ his blood, even the forgiveness of sins*, *Colossians* i. verses 12, 13, 14.

61. But what need have we of distant witnesses? You have a witness in our own breast. For am I not speaking to one that loves God? How came you then to love him at first? Was it not, because you knew that he loved you? Did you, could you love God at all, ’till you tasted and saw that he was gracious? That he was merciful to you a sinner? What avails then controversy, or strife of words? Out of thy own mouth! You own, you had no love to God, ’till you was sensible of his love to you. And whatever expressions any sinner who loves God uses, to denote God’s love to him, you will always upon examination, find, that, they directly or indirectly imply forgiveness. Pardoning love is still at the root of all. He who was offended is now reconciled. The new song which God puts in every mouth, is always to that effect, *O Lord, I will praise thee: tho’ thou wast angry with me, thine anger is turned away. Behold, God is my salvation. I will trust and not be afraid; for the Lord Jehovah is my strength and my song: he is also become my salvation*, *Isaiah* xii. 1, 2.

62. A confidence then in a pardoning God, is essential to saving faith. The forgiveness of sins is one of the first of those unseen things, whereof faith is the evidence. And if you are sensible of this, will you quarrel with us concerning an indifferent circumstance of it? Will you think it an important objection that we assert, that this faith is usually given in a moment? First, let me intreat you to read over that authentic account of God's dealings with men, the Acts of the apostles. In this treatise you will find, how he wrought from the beginning on those who received remission of sins by faith. And can you find one of these, (except perhaps *St. Paul*) who did not receive it in a moment? But abundance you find of those who did, besides *Cornelius* and the three thousand, and to this also agrees the experience of those who now receive the heavenly gift. Three or four exceptions only have I found in the course of several years, (perhaps you yourself may be added to that number, and one or two more whom you have known.) But all the rest of those, who from time to time among us have believed in the Lord Jesus, were in a moment brought from darkness to light, and from the power of Satan unto God.

63. And why should it seem a thing incredible to you, who have known the power of God unto salvation; (whether he hath wrought thus in your soul or no; *for there are diversities of operations, but the same Spirit*) that *the dead should hear the voice of the Son of God*, and in that moment live? Thus he useth to act, to shew that when he willeth, to do is present with him. *Let there be light*, said God, *and there was light. He spoke the word, and it was done. Thus the heavens and the earth were created, and all the hosts of them.* And this manner of acting in the present case, highly suits both his power and love. There is therefore no hindrance on God's part; since *as his majesty is, so is his mercy*. And whatever hindrance there is on the part of man, when God speaketh, it is not. Only *ask* then, O sinner, *and it shall be given thee*, even the faith that brings salvation: and that, without any merit or good work of thine; for *it is not of works, lest any man should boast*. No; it is of grace, of grace alone. For *unto him that worketh not, but believeth on him that justifieth the ungodly, his faith is counted to him for righteousness*.

64. “But by talking thus you encourage sinners.” I do encourage them—to repent: and do not you? Do not you know how many heap sin upon sin, purely for want of such encouragement? Because they think, “they can never be forgiven: there is no place for repentance left?” Does not your heart also bleed for them? What would you think too dear to part with? What would you not do? What would you not suffer, to bring one such sinner to repentance? Could not your love *endure all things* for them? “Yes—if you believed it would do them good; if you had any hope that they would be better.” Why do you not believe it would do them good? Why have you not a hope that they will be better? Plainly, because you do not love them enough; because you have not that charity, which not only endureth, but at the same time believeth and hopeth all things.

65. But that you may see the whole strength of this objection, I will shew you without any disguise or reserve, how I encourage the chief of sinners: my usual language to them runs thus:

O ye that deny the Lord that bought you, yet hear the word of the Lord. You seek rest, but find none. Even in laughter your heart is in heaviness. How long spend ye your labour for that which is not bread, and your strength for that which satisfieth not? You know, your soul is not satisfied. It is still an aking void. Sometimes you find (in spite of your principles) a sense [♦](#)of guilt, an awakened conscience. That grisly phantom, religion, (so you describe her) will now and then haunt you still. Righteousness looking down from heaven, is indeed to us no unpleasing sight. But how does it appear to you?

Horribili super aspectu mortalibus astans?

How often are you in fear of the very things you deny? How often in racking suspense? “What if there be an hereafter? A judgment to come? An unhappy eternity?” Do you not start at the thoughts? Can you be content to be always thus? Shall it be said of you also,

“Here lies a dicer, long in doubt
If death could kill the soul, or not?
Here ends his doubtfulness; at last
Convinc’d.—But, O the die is cast!”

Or, are you already convinced, there is no hereafter? What a poor state then are you in now? Taking a few more dull turns upon earth, and then dropping into nothing! What kind of spirit must you be of, if you can sustain yourself under the thought! Under the expectation of being in a few moments swept away by the stream of time, and then for ever

“swallow’d up, and lost
In the wide womb of uncreated night!”

But neither indeed are you certain of this; nor of any thing else. “It may be so; it may not. A vast scene is behind. But clouds and darkness rest upon it.” All is doubt and uncertainty. You are continually tossed to and fro, and have no firm ground for the sole of your foot. O let not the poor wisdom of man any longer exalt itself against the wisdom of God. You have fled from him long enough: at length suffer your eyes to be opened by him that made them. You want rest to your soul. Ask it of him, who giveth to all men liberally, and upbraideth not! You are now a mere riddle to yourself, and your condition full of darkness and perplexity. You are one among many restless inhabitants of a miserable, disordered world, *walking in a vain shadow, and disquieting yourself in vain*. But the light of God will speedily disperse the anxiety of your vain conjectures. By adding heaven to earth, and eternity to time; it will open such a glorious view of things, as will lead you, even in the present world, to a peace which passeth all understanding.

♦ duplicate word “of” removed

66. O ye gross, vile, scandalous sinners, hear ye the word of the Lord. *Turn ye, turn ye from your evil ways; so iniquity shall not be your ruin. As I live, saith the Lord, I have no pleasure in the death of a sinner, but rather that he should turn and live. O make haste; delay not the time. Come, and let us reason together. Though your sins be as scarlet, they shall be white as snow; though they be red as crimson, they shall be as wool.*——Who is this that cometh from Edom, with dyed garments, red in his apparel? It is he on whom the Lord hath laid the iniquities of us all! Behold, behold the Lamb of God, that taketh away thy sins! See the only begotten Son of the Father, full of grace and truth! He loveth thee. He gave himself for thee. Now, his bowels of compassion yearn over thee! O believe in the Lord Jesus, and thou shalt be saved! *Go in peace, sin no more!*

67. Now cannot you join in all this? Is it not the very language of your heart? O when will you take knowledge, that *our* whole concern, our constant labour is, to bring all the world to the religion which you feel, to solid, inward, vital religion! What *power* is it then that keeps us asunder? *Is thine heart right, as my heart is with thy heart? If it be, give me thy hand. Come with me and see, and rejoice in my zeal for the Lord.* No difference between us (if thou art a child of God) can be so considerable as our agreement is. If we differ in smaller things, we agree in that which is greatest of all. How is it possible then that *you* should be induced, to think or speak evil of us? How could it ever come into your mind, to oppose us, or weaken our hands? How long shall we complain of the wounds which we receive in the house of our friends? Surely the children of this world are still *wiser in their generation than the children of light*. Satan is not divided against himself: Why are they who are on the Lord's side against us? How is it that *wisdom* is not *justified of her own children*?

68. Is it, because you have heard, “That we only make religion a cloak for covetousness? And because you have heard abundance of particulars alleged in support of that general charge?” ’Tis probable, you may also have heard, “How much we have *gained* by preaching already:” and, to crown all, “That we are only papists in disguise, who are undermining and destroying the church?”

69. “You have heard this.” Well: and can you believe it? Have you then never heard the fifth chapter of St. *Matthew*? I would to God you could believe it. What is written there? How readest thou? *Blessed are ye when men shall revile you, and persecute you, and say all manner of evil against you falsely for my name’s sake. Rejoice and be exceeding glad; for great is your reward in heaven: for so persecuted they the prophets that were before you: namely, by reviling them, and saying all manner of evil of them falsely.* Do not you know, that this (as well as all other scriptures) must needs be fulfilled? If so, take knowledge, that this day also it is fulfilled in your ears. For our Lord’s sake, and for the sake of his gospel which we preach, *men do revile us and persecute us, and (blessed be God, who giveth us to rejoice therein) say all manner of evil of us falsely.* And how can it be otherwise? *The disciple is not above his master. It is enough for the disciple, that he be as his master, and the servant as his Lord. If they have called the master of the house Beelzebub, how much more shall they call them of his household?*

70. This only we confess, that “we preach *inward* salvation, now attainable by faith.” And *for preaching this*, (for *no other crime* was then so much as pretended) we were forbid to preach any more in those churches, where, till then, we were gladly received. This is a notorious fact. Being thus hindered from preaching in the places we should first have chosen, we now declare the *grace of God which bringeth salvation, in all places of his dominion*: as well knowing, that God dwelleth not only in temples made with hands. This is the real, and it is the only real ground of complaint against us. And this we avow before all mankind, we do preach this salvation by faith. And not being suffered to preach it in the usual places, we declare it ♦wherever a door is opened, either *on a mountain, or a plain, or by a river side*, (for all which we conceive we have sufficient precedent) or in prison, or, as it were, *in the house of Justus, or the school of one Tyrannus*. Nor dare we refrain. *A dispensation of the gospel is committed to me; and woe is me, if I preach not the gospel.*

♦ “whereever” replaced with “wherever”

71. Here we allow the fact, but deny the guilt. But in every other point alleged, we deny the fact, and call upon the world to prove it, if they can. More especially we call upon those who for many years saw our manner of life at *Oxford*. These well know, that *after the straitest sect of our religion, we lived Pharisees*: and that the grand objection to us for all those years, was the being *righteous overmuch*: the reading, fasting, praying, denying ourselves; the going to church, to the Lord's table; the relieving the poor, visiting those that were sick and in prison; instructing the ignorant, and labouring to reclaim the wicked,—more than was necessary for salvation. These were our open, flagrant crimes, from the year 1729 to the year 1737; touching which our Lord shall judge in that day.

72. But waving the things that are past: which of you now convinceth us of sin? Which of you (I here more especially appeal to my brethren, the clergy) can personally convict us of any ungodliness or unholiness of conversation? Ye know in your own hearts, (all that are candid men, all that are not utterly blinded with prejudice) that we *labour to have a conscience void of offence both toward God and toward man*. Brethren, I would to God that in this ye were even as we. But indeed (with grief I speak it) ye are not. There are among yourselves ungodly and unholy men; openly, undeniably such: drunkards, gluttons, returners of evil for evil, liars, swearers, prophaners of the day of the Lord. Proof hereof is not wanting, if ye require it. Where then is your zeal against these? A clergyman, so drunk he can scarce stand or speak, may, in the presence of a thousand people¹, set upon another clergyman of the same church, both with abusive words and open violence. And what follows? Why, the one is still allowed to dispense the sacred signs of the body and blood of Christ. But the other is not allowed to receive them.—Because he is a field preacher.

¹ At Epworth, in Lincolnshire.

73. O ye pillars and fathers of the church, are these things well-pleasing to him, who hath made you overseers over that flock which he hath purchased with his own blood? O that ye would suffer me to boast myself a little! Is there not a cause? Have ye not compelled me? Which of your clergy are more unspotted in their lives, which more unwearied in their labours, than those whose *names ye cast out as evil*, whom ye count *as the filth and off-scouring of the world*? Which of them is more zealous *to spend and be spent*, for the lost sheep of the house of *Israel*? Or, who among them is more ready *to be offered up for their flock upon the sacrifice and service of their faith*?

74. Will ye say, (as the historian of *Catiline*) *Si sic pro patria!* If this were done in defence of the church, and not in order to undermine and destroy it! That is the very proposition I undertake to prove, That “we are now defending the church, even the church of *England*, in opposition to all those who either secretly undermine, or more openly attempt to destroy it.”

75. That we are *Papists*, (we, who are daily and hourly preaching that very doctrine which is so solemnly anathematized by the whole church of *Rome*) is such a charge, that I dare not waste my time in industriously confuting it. Let any man of common sense only look on the title pages of the sermons we have lately preached at *Oxford*, and he will need nothing more to shew him the weight of this senseless, shameless accusation;—unless he can suppose the governors both of *Christ-Church* and *Lincoln-College*, nay, and all the university, to be *Papists* too.

76. You yourself can easily acquit us of this; but not of the other part of the charge. You still think we are secretly undermining, if not openly destroying the church.

What do you mean by the church? A visible church (as our article defines it) is, *A company of faithful (or believing) people: cætus credentium*. This is the essence of a church: and the properties thereof are, (as they are described in the words that follow) *Among whom the pure word of God is preached, and the sacraments duly administered*. Now then (according to this authentic account) what is *The church of England*? What is it indeed, but the *faithful people*, the *true believers in England*? It is true, if these are scattered abroad, they come under another consideration. But when they are visibly joined, by assembling together to hear the pure word of God preached, and to eat of one bread, and drink of one cup, they are then properly the visible church of *England*.

77. It were well if this were a little more considered by those, who so vehemently cry out, *The church! the church!* (as those of old, *The temple of the Lord! the temple of the Lord!*) not knowing what they speak, nor whereof they affirm. A provincial or national church, according to our article, is, the true believers of that province or nation. If these are dispersed up and down, they are only a part of the invisible church of Christ. But if they are visibly joined by assembling together to hear his word and partake of his supper, they are then a visible church, such as the church of *England*, *France*, or any other.

78. This being premised, I ask, How do we undermine or destroy the church? The provincial, visible church of *England*? The article mentions three things as essential to a visible church: 1st, Living faith, without which indeed there can be no church at all, neither visible nor invisible: 2dly, Preaching (and consequently hearing) the pure word of God, else that faith would languish and die: and, 3dly, A due administration of the sacraments, the ordinary means whereby God increaseth faith. Now come close to the question: in which of these points do we undermine or destroy the church?

Do we shut the door of faith? Do we lessen the number of believing people in *England*? Only remember what faith is, according to our homilies, (viz. “A sure trust and confidence in God, that through the merits of Christ my sins are forgiven, and I reconciled to the favour of God,”) And we appeal to all mankind, do we destroy this faith, which is the life and soul of the church? Is there, in fact, less of this faith, in *England*, than there was before we went forth! I think, this is an assertion, which the father of lies himself will scarce dare to utter or maintain.

With regard then to this first point, it is undeniable, we neither undermine nor destroy the church. The second thing is, the preaching the pure word of God. And do we hinder this? Do we hinder any minister from preaching the pure word of God? If any preach not at all, or not the pure word of God, is the hindrance in us or in themselves? Or, do we lessen the number of those that hear the pure word of God? Are then the hearers thereof (whether read or preached) *fewer* than they were in times past? Are the usual places of public worship *less frequented* by means of our preaching? Wheresoever our lot has been cast for any time, are the churches *emptier* than they were before? Surely, none that has any regard left either for truth or modesty, will say, that *in this point* we are enemies to, or destroyers of, the church.

The third thing requisite (if not to the *being*, at least) to the *well being* of a church, is the due administration of the sacraments, particularly that of the Lord’s supper. And are we, in *this* respect, underminers or destroyers of the church? Do we either by our example or advice, draw men away from the Lord’s table? Where we have labour’d most, are there the fewest communicants? How does the fact stand in *London, Bristol, Newcastle*? O that you would no longer shut your eyes against the broad light which encompasses you on every side!

79. I believe you are sensible by this time, not only how weak this objection is, but likewise how easy it would be, terribly to retort every branch of it upon most of those that make it: whether we speak of *true* living faith, of preaching the *pure* word of God, or of the due administration of the sacraments, both of baptism and the Lord's supper. But I spare you. It sufficeth that our God knoweth, and will make manifest in that day, whether it be by reason of *us* or *you*, that *men abhor the offering of the Lord*.

80. Others object, "That we do not observe *the laws of the church*, and thereby undermine it." What laws? The rubricks or canons? In every parish where I have been curate yet, I have observed the rubricks with a scrupulous exactness, not for wrath, but for conscience sake. And this, so far as belongs to an unbeneficed minister, or to a private member of the church, I do now. I will just mention a few of them, and leave you to consider, which of us has observed, or does observe them most.

1. Days of fasting or abstinence to be observ'd:

The forty days of Lent,

The Ember days at the four seasons,

The three Rogation days,

All Fridays in the year, except *Christmas-day*.

2. "So many as intend to be partakers of the holy communion, shall signify their names to the curate, at least some time the day before:

"And if any of these be an open and notorious evil liver,—the curate shall advertise him, that in any wise he presume not to come to the Lord's table, until he hath openly declared himself to have truly repented.

3. "Then (after the *Nicene* creed) the curate shall declare unto the people, what holidays, or *fasting-days*, are in the week following to be observed.

4. “The minister shall first receive the communion in both kinds himself, and *then proceed to deliver the same to the bishops, priests, and deacons, in like manner, if any be present, and after that, to the people.*

5. “In cathedral and collegiate churches, and colleges, where there are many priests and deacons, they shall *all receive the communion with the priest, every Sunday at the least.*

6. “The children to be baptized must be ready at the font, *immediately after the last lesson.*

7. “The curates of every parish shall warn the people, that without great necessity, they procure not their children to be baptized *at home in their houses.*

8. “The curate of every parish shall diligently *upon Sundays and Holydays, after the second lesson at evening prayer, openly in the church,* instruct and examine so many children as he shall think convenient, in some part of the catechism.

9. “Whensoever the bishop shall give notice for children to be brought unto him for their confirmation, the curate of every parish, shall either bring or *send in writing, with his hand subscribed thereunto, the names of all such persons* within his parish, as he shall think fit to be presented to the bishop.”

81. Now the question is not, whether these rubrics ought to be observed, (you take this for granted in making the objection) but whether in fact they have been observed by you, or me, most? Many can witness, I have observed them punctually, yea, sometimes at the hazard of my life: and as many, I fear, that you, have not observed them at all, and that several of them you never pretended to observe. And is it *you* that are accusing *me*, for not observing the rubrics of the church? What grimace is this! *O tell it not in Gath! Publish not in the streets of Askelon!*

82. With regard to the canons, I would in the first place desire you to consider, two or three plain questions.

1st. Have you ever read them over?

2dly. How can these be called, “The canons of the church of *England*?” Seeing they were never legally established by the church? Never regularly confirmed in any full convocation?

3dly. By what right am I required to observe such canons as were never legally established?

And then I will join issue with you on one question more, viz. Whether you or I *have observed* them most?

To instance only in a few.

Canon 29. No person shall be admitted godfather or godmother to any child,—before the said person hath received the holy communion.

Canon 59. Every parson, vicar, or curate, upon *every Sunday and Holiday, before evening prayer, shall, for half an hour, or more,* examine and instruct the youth and ignorant persons of his parish.

Canon 64. Every parson, vicar, or curate, shall declare to the people every Sunday, whether there be any holidays or *fasting-days* the week following.

Canon 68. No minister shall *refuse* or *delay* to christen any child that is brought to the church to him upon Sundays or holidays to be christened, or bury any corps that is brought to the church or church-yard.

(*N. B.* Inability to pay fees does not alter the case.)

Canon 75. No ecclesiastical persons shall spend their time idly, by day or by night, playing at *dice, cards, or tables.*

Now let the clergyman who has observed only these five canons for one year last past, and who has read over all the canons in his congregation; (as the king’s ratification straitly enjoins him to do once every year) let him, I say, cast the first stone at us, for *not observing the canons* (so called) *of the church of England.*

83. “However we cannot be (it is said) friends to the church, because we do not *obey the governors of it*, and *submit ourselves* (as at our ordination we promised to do) *to all their godly admonitions and injunctions.*”¹ I answer, in every individual point of an indifferent nature, We do and will (by the grace of God) obey the governors of the church. But the *testifying the gospel of the grace of God*, is not a point of an indifferent nature. *The ministry which we have received of the Lord Jesus*, we are at all hazards to fulfil. It is *the burthen of the Lord* which is laid upon us here; and we are *to obey God rather than man*. Nor yet do we in any ways violate the promise which each of us made, when it was said unto him, “Take thou authority to preach the word of God, in the name of the Father, and of the Son, and of the Holy Ghost.” We then promised to *submit* (mark the words) *to the godly admonitions and injunctions of our ordinary*. But we did not, could not promise to obey *such* injunctions, as we know *are contrary to the word of God*.

¹ *The author of a tract just published at Newcastle, (entitled, The notions of the Methodists fully disproved, in a letter to the Rev. Mr. John Wesley) much insists upon this objection. I have read, and believe it quite needless to take any further notice of this performance: the writer being so utterly unacquainted with the merits of the cause; and shewing himself so perfectly a stranger, both to my life, preaching, and writing; and to the word of God, and to the articles and homilies of the church of England.*

84. “But why then (say some) do you leave the church?” *Leave the church!* What can you mean? Do we leave so much as the *church walls*? Your own eyes tell you, we do not. Do we leave the *ordinances of the church*? You daily see and know the contrary. Do we leave the *fundamental doctrine of the church*, namely, Salvation by faith? It is our constant theme, in public, in private, in writing, in conversation. Do we leave the *practice of the church*, the standard whereof are the ten commandments? Which are so essentially in-wrought in her constitution, (as little as you may apprehend it) that whosoever breaks one of the least of these, is no member of the church of *England*. I believe you do not care to put the cause on this issue. Neither do you mean this, by *leaving the church*. In truth, I cannot conceive what you mean. I doubt you cannot conceive yourself. You have retailed a sentence from somebody else, which you no more understand than he. And no marvel; for it is a true observation,

“Nonsense is never to be understood.”

85. Nearly related to this is that other objection, that we *divide the church*. Remember the church is, *The faithful people*, or true believers. Now how do we *divide these*? “Why, by our societies.” Very good. Now the case is plain. “We divide them (you say) by uniting them together.” Truly, a very uncommon way of dividing. “O, but we divide those who are thus united with each other, from the rest of the church.” By no means. Many of them were before *joined to all their brethren* of the church of *England* (and many were not, until they knew us) by *assembling themselves together*, to hear the word of God, and to eat of one bread, and drink of one cup. And do they now *forsake that assembling* themselves together? You cannot, you dare not say it. You know they are more diligent therein than ever; it being one of the fixed rules of our societies, “That every member attend the ordinances of God.” i. e. *do not divide from the church*. And if any member of the church does thus divide from or leave it, he hath no more place among us.

86. I have considered this objection the more at large, because it is of most weight with sincere minds. And to all these, if they have fairly and impartially weighed the answer as well as the objection, I believe it clearly appears, that we are neither *undermining* nor *destroying*, neither *dividing* nor *leaving* the church. So far from it, that we have great heaviness, on her account, yea, continual sorrow in our hearts. And our prayer to God is, that he would repair the breaches of Sion, and build the walls of Jerusalem, that this our desolate church may flourish again, and be the praise of the whole earth.

87. But perhaps you have heard, that “we in truth regard no church at all: that gain is the true spring of all our actions: that I, in particular, am well paid for my work, having thirteen hundred pounds a year (as a reverend author accurately computes it) at the *Foundery* alone, over and above what I receive from *Bristol*, *Kingswood*, *Newcastle*, and other places: and that whoever survives me, will see I have made good use of my time; for I shall not die a beggar.”

88. I freely own, this is one of the best devised objections, which has ever yet been made; because it not only puts us upon proving a negative, (which is seldom an easy task) but also one of such a kind as scarce admits of any demonstrative proof at all. But for such proof as the nature of the thing allows, I appeal to my manner of life which hath been from the beginning. Ye who have seen it (and not with a friendly eye) for these twelve or fourteen years last past, or for any part of that time, Have ye ever seen any thing like the love of gain therein? Did I not continually remember the words of the Lord Jesus, "*It is more blessed to give than to receive?*" Ye of *Oxford*, Do ye not know these things are so? What gain did I seek among you? Of whom did I take any thing? From whom did I covet silver, or gold, or apparel? To whom did I deny any thing which I had, even to the hour that I departed from you?—Ye of *Epworth* and *Wroote*, among whom I ministered for (nearly) the space of three years, what gain did I seek among you? Or of whom did I take or covet any thing?—Ye of *Savannah* and *Frederica*, among whom God afterwards proved me, and shewed me what was in my heart, what gain did I seek among you? Of whom did I take any thing? Or whose food or apparel did I covet (for silver or gold had ye none, no more than I myself for many months) even when I was in hunger and nakedness? Ye yourselves, and the God and Father of our Lord Jesus Christ, know that I lie not.

89. "But (it is said) things are fairly altered now. Now I can't complain of wanting any thing; having the yearly income of a bishop in *London*, over and above what I gain at other places." At what other places, my friend? Inform yourself a little better, and you will find, that both at *Newcastle*, *Bristol*, and *Kingswood*, and all other places, where any collection is made) the money collected is both received and expended by the stewards of those several societies, and never comes into my hands at all, neither first nor last. And you, or any who desire it, shall read over the accounts kept by any of those stewards, and see with your own eyes, that by all these societies I gain just as much as you do.

90. The case in *London* stands thus. In *November 1739*, two gentlemen, then unknown to me (Mr. *Ball* and Mr. *Watkins*) came and desired me once and again, to preach in a place called the *Foundery* near *Moorfields*. With much reluctance I at length complied. I was soon after pressed to take that place into my own hands. Those who were most earnest therein, lent me the purchase-money, which was 115*l*. Mr. *Watkins* and Mr. *Ball* then delivered me the names of several subscribers, who offered to pay, some four, or six, some ten shillings a year towards the repayment of the purchase-money, and the putting the buildings into repair. This amounted one year to near 200*l*. the second to about 140, and so to the last.

91. The united society began a little after, whose weekly contribution (for the poor) is received, and expended by the stewards, and comes not into my hands at all. But there is also a quarterly subscription of many of the society, which is nearly equal to that above mentioned.

92. The uses to which these subscriptions have been hitherto applied, are, 1st, the payment of that 115*l*. 2dly. The repairing (I might almost say rebuilding) that vast, uncouth heap of ruins at the *Foundery*; 3dly. The building galleries both for men and women; 4thly. The enlarging the society room to near thrice its first bigness. All taxes and occasional expences are likewise defrayed out of this fund. And it has been hitherto so far from yielding any overplus, that it has never sufficed for these purposes. So far from it, that I am still in debt, on these accounts, near 300*l*. So much have I hitherto gained by preaching the gospel! Besides a debt of 150*l*. still remaining on account of the school built at *Bristol*; and another of above 200*l*. on account of that now building at *Newcastle*. I desire any reasonable man would now sit down and lay these things together, and let him see, whether, allowing me a grain of common sense, (if not of common honesty) he can possibly conceive, that a view of *gain* would induce me to act in this manner.

93. You can never reconcile it with any degree of common sense, that a man who wants nothing, who has already all the necessities, all the conveniencies, nay, and many of the superfluities of life, and these not only independent on any one, but less liable to contingencies than even a gentleman's freehold estate, that such an one should calmly and deliberately throw up his ease, most of his friends, his reputation, and that way of life, which of all others is most agreeable both to his nature, temper, and education: that he should toil day and night, spend all his time and strength, knowingly destroy a firm constitution, and hasten into weakness, pain, diseases, death,—to gain a debt of six or seven hundred pounds.

94. But suppose the ballance on the other side, let me ask you one plain question. For what gain (setting conscience aside) will you be obliged to act thus? To live exactly as I do? For what price will you preach (and that with all your might, not in an *easy, indolent, fashionable* way) eighteen or nineteen times every week? And this throughout the year? What shall I give you, to travel seven or eight hundred miles, in all weathers, every two or three months? For what salary will you abstain from all other diversions, than the doing good, and the praising God? I am mistaken if you would not prefer strangling to such a life, even with thousands of gold and silver.

95. And what is the comfort you have found out for me in these circumstances? Why, that “I shall not die a beggar.” So now I am supposed to be heaping up riches,—“that I may leave them behind me.” Leave them behind me! For whom? My wife and children? Who are they? They are yet unborn. Unless thou meanest the children of faith whom God hath given me. But my heavenly Father feedeth them. Indeed if I lay up riches at all, it must be *to leave behind me*: (seeing my fellowship is a provision for life.) But I cannot understand this. What comfort would it be to my soul, now launched into eternity, that I had *left behind me* gold as the dust, and silver as the sand of the sea? Will it follow me over the great gulph? Or can I go back to it? Thou that liftest up thy eyes in hell, what do thy riches profit thee now? Will all thou once hadst under the sun, gain thee a drop of water to cool thy tongue? O the comfort of riches left *behind* to one who is tormented in that flame!—You put me in mind of those celebrated lines (which I once exceedingly admired) addressed by way of consolation to the soul of a poor self-murderer:

“Yet shall thy grave with rising flowers be drest,
And the green turf lie light upon thy breast!
Here shall the year its earliest beauties shew:
Here the first roses of the spring shall blow:
While angels with their silver wings o’er shade
The place now sacred by thy relics made.”

96. I will now simply tell you my sense of these matters, whether you will hear, or whether you will forbear. Food and raiment I have; such food as I chuse to eat, and such raiment as I chuse to put on. I have a place where to lay my head. I have what is needful for life and godliness. And I apprehend this is all the world can afford. The kings of the earth can give me no more. For as to gold and silver I count it dung and dross; I trample it under my feet. I (yet not I, but by the grace of God that is in me) esteem it just as the mire in the streets. I desire it not: I seek it not; I only fear lest any of it should cleave to me and I should not be able to shake it off, before my spirit returns to God. It must indeed pass through my hands; but I will take care (God being my helper) that the mammon of unrighteousness shall only pass through; it shall not rest there. None of the accursed thing shall be found in my tents, when the Lord calleth me hence. And hear ye this, all you who have discovered the treasures which I am to leave behind me. If I leave behind me ten pounds (above my debts, and my books; or what may happen to be due on account of them) you and all mankind bear witness against me, “that I lived and died a thief and a robber.”

97. Before I conclude, I cannot but intreat you who know God, to review the whole matter from the foundation. Call to mind what the state of religion was in our nation a few years since. In whom did you find the *holy tempers* that were in Christ? Bowels of mercies, lowliness, meekness, gentleness, contempt of the world, patience, temperance, long-suffering? A burning love to God, rejoicing evermore and in every thing giving thanks; and a tender love to all mankind, covering, believing, hoping, enduring all things? Perhaps you did not know one such man in the world. But how many, that had *all unholy tempers*? What vanity and pride, what stubbornness and self-will, what anger, fretfulness, discontent, what suspicion and resentment, what inordinate affections, what irregular passions, what foolish and hurtful desires might you find, in those who were called the *best* of men? In those who made the strictest profession of religion? And how few did you know who went so far as the *profession* of religion, who had even the *form of godliness*? Did you not frequently bewail, wherever your lot was cast, the general want even of *outward religion*? How few were seen at the public worship of God? How much fewer at the Lord's table? And was even this little flock zealous of good works, careful as they had time, to do good to all men? On the other hand, did you not with grief observe, *outward irreligion* in every place? Where could you be for one week, without being an eye or an ear-witness, of cursing, swearing, or prophaneness, of sabbath-breaking or drunkenness, of quarrelling or brawling, of revenge or obscenity? Were these things done in a corner? Did not gross iniquity of all kinds overspread our land as a flood? Yea, and daily increase, in spite of all the opposition which the children of God did or could make against it.

98. If you had been then told, that the jealous God would soon arise and maintain his own cause; that he would pour down his Spirit from on high, and renew the face of the earth; that he would shed abroad his love in the hearts of the outcasts of men, producing all holy and heavenly tempers, expelling anger, and pride, and evil desire, and all unholy and earthly tempers; causing outward religion, the work of faith, the patience of hope, the labour of love, to flourish and abound; and wherever it spread, abolishing outward-irreligion, destroying all the works of the devil: if you had been told, that this living knowledge of the Lord would in a short space of time overspread our land; yea, and daily increase, in spite of all the opposition which the devil and his children did or could make against it: Would you not have vehemently desired to see that day, that you might bless God and rejoice therein?

99. Behold the day of the Lord is come. He is again visiting and redeeming his people. Having eyes, see ye not? Having ears, do ye not hear? Neither understand with your hearts? At this hour the Lord is rolling away our reproach. Already his standard is set up. His spirit is poured forth on the outcasts of men, and his love shed abroad in their hearts. Love of all mankind, meekness, gentleness, humbleness of mind, holy and heavenly affections, do take place of hate, anger, pride, revenge, and vain affections. Hence wherever the power of the Lord spreads, springs outward religion in all its forms. The houses of God are filled; the table of the Lord is thronged on every side. And those who thus shew their love of God, shew they love their neighbour also, by being careful to maintain good works, by doing all manner of good, as they have time, to all men. They are likewise careful to abstain from all evil. Cursing, sabbath-breaking, drunkenness, with all other (however fashionable) works of the devil, are not once named among them. All this is plain demonstrable fact. For this also is not done in a corner. Now, do you acknowledge the day of your visitation? Do you bless God and rejoice therein?

100. What hinders? Is it this, that men say all manner of evil of those whom God is pleased to use as instruments in his work? O ye fools, did ye suppose the devil was dead? Or that he would not fight for his kingdom? And what weapons shall he fight with, if not with lies? Is he not a liar, and the father of it? Suffer ye then thus far. Let the devil and his children say all manner of evil of us. And let them go on deceiving each other, and being deceived. But ye need not be deceived also.—Or if you are, if you will believe all they say: be it so, that we are weak, silly, wicked men; without sense, without learning, without even a desire or design of doing good: yet I insist upon the fact. Christ is preached and sinners are converted to God. This none but a madman can deny. We are ready to prove it by a cloud of witnesses. Neither therefore can the inference be denied, that God is now visiting his people. O that all men may know in this their day, the things that make for their peace!

101. Upon the whole, to men of the world I would still recommend the known advice of *Gamaliel*: *Refrain from these men, and let them alone; for if this work be of men, it will come to nought; but if it be of God, ye cannot overthrow it, lest haply ye be found even to fight against God.* But unto you whom God hath chosen out of the world, I say ye are our brethren, and of our father's house, it behoveth you, in whatsoever manner ye are able, *to strengthen our hands in God.* And this ye are all able to do; to wish us good luck in the name of the Lord, and, to pray continually, that none of *these things may move us*, and that *we may not count our lives dear unto ourselves, so that we may finish our course with joy, and the ministry which we have received of the Lord Jesus!*

Written in the year 1744.

Primitive Christianity.

1 HAPPY the souls who first believ'd,
To Jesus, and each other cleav'd,

Join'd by the unction from above,

In mystic fellowship of love.

2 Meek, simple followers of the Lamb,

They liv'd, and spake, and thought the same,

Brake the commemorative bread,

And drank the Spirit of their head.

3 On God they cast their every care,

Wrestling with God in mighty prayer,

They claim'd the grace, thro' Jesus given:

By prayer, they shut, and open'd heaven.

4 To Jesus they perform'd their vows,

A little church in every house;

They joyfully conspir'd to raise

Their ceaseless sacrifice of praise.

5 Propriety was there unknown,

None call'd what he possess'd his own;

Where all the common blessings share,

No selfish happiness was there.

6 With grace abundantly endu'd,

A pure, believing multitude;

They all were of one heart and soul,

And only love inspir'd the whole.

7 O what an age of golden days!

O what a choice, peculiar race!

Wash'd in the Lamb's all-cleansing blood,

Anointed kings, and priests to God.

8 Where shall I wander now to find

The successors they left behind?

The faithful, whom I seek in vain,

Are minish'd from the sons of men.

9 Ye different sects, who all declare,

Lo! here is Christ, or Christ is there!

Your stronger proofs divinely give,

And shew me where the Christians live.

10 Your claim, alas! ye cannot prove,

Ye want the genuine mark of love:

Thou only, Lord, thine own canst shew,

For sure thou hast a church below.

11 The gates of hell cannot prevail,

The church on earth can never fail:

Ah! join me to thy secret ones,

Ah! gather all thy living stones.

12 Scatter'd o'er all the earth they lie,

'Till Thou collect them with thine eye,

Draw by the music of thy name,

And charm into a beauteous frame.

13 For this the pleading Spirit groans,

And cries in all thy banish'd ones:

Greatest of gifts, thy love impart,

And make us of one mind and heart.

14 Join every soul that looks to thee,

In bonds of perfect charity:

Now, Lord, the glorious fulness give,
And all in all for ever live.

P A R T II.

1 JESUS, from whom all blessings flow,
Great builder of thy church below,
If now thy spirit moves my breast,
Hear, and fulfil thy own request.

2 The few that truly call thee Lord,
And wait thy sanctifying word;
And thee their utmost Saviour own,
Unite, and perfect them in one.

3 Gather them in on every side,
And in thy tabernacle hide;
Give them a resting place to find,
A covert from the storm and wind.

4 O find them out some calm recess,
Some unfrequented wilderness!
Thou, Lord, the secret place prepare,
And hide and feed *the woman* there.

5 Thither collect thy little flock,
Under the shadow of their rock:
The holy seed, the royal race,
The standing monuments of thy grace?

6 O let them all thy mind express,
Stand forth thy chosen witnesses!
Thy power unto salvation shew,
And perfect holiness below.

7 The fulness of thy grace receive,
And simply to thy glory live;
Strongly reflect the light divine,
And in a land of darkness shine.

8 In them let all mankind behold,
How Christians liv'd in days of old;
(Mighty their envious foes to move,
A proverb of reproach—and love.)

9 O make them of one soul and heart,
The all-conforming mind impart;
Spirit of peace and unity,
The sinless mind that was in thee.

10 Call them into thy wond'rous light,
Worthy to walk with thee in white;
Make up thy jewels, Lord, and shew,
The glorious, spotless church below.

11 From every sinful wrinkle free,
Redeem'd from all iniquity:
The fellowship of saints make known;
And O my God, might I be one!

12 O might my lot be cast with these,
The least of Jesu's witnesses!
O that my Lord would count me meet
To wash his dear disciples feet!

13 This only thing do I require,
Thou know'st 'tis all my heart's desire,
Freely what I receive to give,

The servant of thy church to live:

14 After my lowly Lord to go,
And wait upon the saints below,
Enjoy the grace to angels given,
And serve the royal heirs of heaven.

15 Lord, if I now thy drawings feel,
And ask according to thy will,
Confirm the prayer, the zeal impart,
And speak the answer to my heart.

16 Tell me (or thou shalt never go)
“Thy prayer is heard, it shall be so”——
The word hath pass’d thy lips—and I
Shall with thy people live and die.

A farther A P P E A L

To MEN of

REASON and RELIGION.

Let the righteous smite me friendly and reprove me.

Psalms CCLI. 5.

P A R T I.

I N a former treatise I declared, in the plainest manner I could, both my principles and practice; and answered some of the most important, as well as the most common objections to each. But I have not yet delivered my own soul. I believe it is still incumbent upon me to answer other objections, particularly such as have been urged by those who are esteemed religious or reasonable men.

These partly relate to the *doctrines* I teach, partly to my *manner* of teaching them, and partly to the *effects* which are supposed to follow from teaching these doctrines in this manner.

I. 1. I will briefly mention what those doctrines are, before I consider the objections against them. Now all I teach respects either the nature and condition of *justification*, the nature and condition of *salvation*, the nature of justifying and saving *faith*, or the *Author* of faith and salvation.

2. First, The nature of justification. It sometimes means, our acquittal at the last day¹. But this is altogether out of the present question: that justification whereof our articles and homilies speak, meaning present forgiveness, pardon of sins, and consequently acceptance with God: who therein, *declares his righteousness* or mercy, by or *for the remission of the sins that are past*, saying, *I will be merciful to thy unrighteousness, and thine iniquities I will remember no more.*²

¹ Matthew xii. 37.

² Romans iii. 25.

I believe, the condition of this, is faith¹: I mean, not only, that without faith, we cannot be justified; but also, that as soon as any one has true faith, in that moment he is justified.

¹ Romans iv. 5. &c.

Good works follow this faith¹, but cannot go before it: much less can sanctification, which implies, a continued course of good works, springing from holiness of heart. *But it is allowed, that entire sanctification goes before our justification at the last day.²

¹ Luke vi. 43.

² Hebrews xii. 14.

*It is allowed also, that repentance¹ and *fruits meet for repentance*², go before faith. Repentance *absolutely must* go before faith: fruits meet for it, if there be opportunity. By repentance, I mean, conviction of sin, producing real desires and sincere resolutions of amendment: and by *fruits meet for repentance*, forgiving our brother³, ceasing from evil⁴, doing good, using the ordinances of God⁵, and in general obeying him according to the measure of grace which we have received⁶. But these, I cannot as yet, term *good works*; because they do not spring from faith and the love of God.

¹ Mark i. 15.

² Matthew iii. 8.

³ Matthew vi. 14, 15.

⁴ Luke iii. 4, 9. &c.

⁵ Matthew vii. 7.

⁶ Matthew xxv. 29.

3. By salvation I mean, not barely, according to the vulgar notion, deliverance from hell, or going to heaven: but a present deliverance from sin, a restoration of the soul to its primitive health, its original purity; a recovery of the divine nature; the renewal of our souls after the image of God, in righteousness and true holiness, in justice, mercy, and truth. This implies all holy and heavenly tempers, and by consequence all holiness of conversation.

Now, if by salvation we mean, a present salvation from sin, we cannot say, holiness is the condition of it. For it is the thing itself. Salvation, in this sense, and holiness are synonymous terms. We must therefore say, *We are saved by faith*. Faith is the sole condition of this salvation. For without faith we cannot be thus saved. But whosoever believeth, is saved already.

*Without faith we cannot be thus saved. For we cannot rightly serve God, unless we love him. And we cannot love him, unless we know him; neither can we know God, unless by faith. Therefore *salvation by faith*, is only in other words, the love of God by the knowledge of God: or, the recovery of the image of God, by a true spiritual acquaintance with him.

4. Faith, in general, is, a divine, supernatural ἔλεγχος¹ of things not seen, not discoverable by our bodily senses, as being either past, future or spiritual. *Justifying faith* implies, not only a divine ἔλεγχος, that God *was in* Christ, *reconciling the world unto himself*, but a sure trust and confidence, that Christ died for *my* sins, that he loved *me* and gave himself for *me*. And the moment a penitent sinner believes this, God pardons and absolves him.

¹ Evidence, or Conviction.

And as soon as his pardon or justification is witnessed to him by the Holy Ghost, he is saved. He loves God and all mankind. He has *the mind that was in Christ*, and power to *walk as he also walked*. From that time (unless he make shipwreck of the faith) salvation gradually increases in his soul. For *so is the kingdom of God, as if a man should cast seed into the ground.—And it springeth up, first the blade, then the ear, after that the full corn in the ear.*

5. The first sowing of this seed, I cannot conceive to be other than instantaneous: whether I consider experience, or the word of God, or the very nature of the thing—however I contend not for a circumstance, but the substance; if you can attain it another way, do. Only see that you do attain it; for if you fall short, you perish everlastingly.

*This beginning of that vast, inward change, is usually termed *The new birth*. Baptism is the outward sign of this inward grace, which is supposed by our church, to be given with, and through that sign to all infants, and to those of riper years, if they repent and believe the gospel. But how extremely idle are the common disputes on this head? I tell a sinner, “You must be born again.” “No, say you, he was born again in baptism. Therefore he cannot be born again now.” Alas! What trifling is this? What if he was *then* a child of God? He is *now* manifestly a child of the devil. For the works of his father he doth. Therefore do not play upon words. He *must* go through an entire change of heart. In one not yet baptized, you yourself would call that change, *the new birth*. In him, call it what you will; but remember mean time, that if either he or you die without it, your baptism will be so far from profiting you, that it will greatly increase your damnation.

6. The author of faith and salvation is God alone. It is he that works in us both to will and to do. He is the sole giver of every good gift, and the sole author of every good work. There is no more of power than of merit in man; but as all merit is in the Son of God, in what he has done and suffered for us, so all power is in the Spirit of God. And therefore every man, in order to believe unto salvation, must receive the Holy Ghost. This is essentially necessary to every Christian, not in order to his working miracles, but in order to faith, peace, joy, and love, the ordinary fruits of the Spirit.

Although no man on earth can explain the *particular manner*, wherein the Spirit of God works on the soul, yet whosoever has these fruits, cannot but know and *feel* that God has wrought them in his heart.

Sometimes, he acts more particularly on the understanding, opening or *inlightening* it, (as the scripture speaks) and *revealing*, unveiling, discovering to us *the deep things of God*.

Sometimes he acts on the wills and affections of men; withdrawing them from evil, inclining them to good, *inspiring*, (breathing as it were) good thoughts into them: so it has frequently been exprest, by an easy, natural metaphor, strictly analogous to $\pi\eta\tau\epsilon\sigma\tau\alpha\varsigma$, $\pi\nu\epsilon\tilde{\upsilon}\mu\alpha$, *spiritus*, and the words used in most modern tongues also, to denote the third person in the ever-blessed Trinity. But however it be exprest, it is certain, all true faith, and the whole work of salvation, every good thought, word and work, is altogether by the operation of *the Spirit of God*.

II. 1. I come now to consider the principal objections, which have lately been made against these doctrines.

I know nothing material which has been objected, as to the nature of justification: but many persons seem to be very confused, in their thoughts, concerning it, and speak as if they had never heard of any justification, antecedent to that of the last day. To clear up this, there needs only a closer inspection of our articles and homilies; wherein justification is always taken, for the present remission of our sins.

But many are the objections which have been warmly urged, against the condition of justification, faith alone: particularly in two treatises, the former intitled, *The notions of the Methodists fully disproved*: the second, *The notions of the Methodists farther disproved*. In both of which it is vehemently *affirmed*, 1. That this is not a scriptural doctrine. 2. That it is not the doctrine of the church of *England*.

It will not be needful to name the former of these any more; seeing there is neither one text produced therein, to prove this doctrine unscriptural, nor one sentence from the articles or homilies, to prove it contrary to the doctrine of the church. But so much of the latter as relates to the merits of the *cause*, I will endeavour to consider calmly. As to what is *personal*, I leave it as it is. *God be merciful to me, a sinner!*

2. To prove this doctrine unscriptural, That “Faith alone is the condition of justification,” you alledge, That “Sanctification, according to scripture, must go before it:” To evince which, you quote the following texts, which I leave as I find them: *Go, disciple all nations—teaching them to observe all things, whatsoever I have commanded them.*¹ *He that believeth and is baptized shall be saved.*² *Preach repentance and remission of sins.*³ *Repent and be baptized every one of you, for the remission of sins.*⁴ *Repent and be converted, that your sins may be blotted out.*⁵ *By one offering he hath perfected for ever them that are sanctified.*⁶ You add, “*St. Paul taught Repentance toward God, and faith toward our Lord Jesus Christ*⁷; and calls *Repentance from dead works, and faith toward God, first principles.*⁸”

¹ *Matthew xxviii. 19, 20.*

² *Mark xvi. 16.*

³ *Luke xxiv. 47.*

⁴ *Acts ii. 38.*

⁵ *♦Acts iii. 19.*

⁶ *Hebrews x. 14.*

⁷ *Acts xx. 21.*

⁸ *Hebrews vi. 1.*

♦ “C.” replaced with “Acts”

You subjoin, “*But ye are washed*, says he, *but ye are sanctified*, *but ye are justified*. By *washed* is meant their baptism; and by their baptism is meant, first their sanctification, and then their justification.” This is a flat begging the question; you take for granted, the very point which you ought to prove. “St. *Peter* also, you say, affirms, That *baptism doth save us* or justify us.” Again, you beg the question: you take for granted what I utterly deny, viz. That *save* and *justify* are here synonymous terms. ’Till this is proved, you can draw no inference at all; for you have no foundation whereon to build.

I conceive these and all the scriptures which can be quoted to prove sanctification antecedent to justification, (if they do not relate to our final justification) prove only (what I have never denied) that repentance, or conviction of sin, and fruits meet for repentance, precede that faith, whereby we are justified: but by no means, that the love of God, or any branch of true holiness, must or can precede faith.

3. It is objected, Secondly, That justification by faith alone, is not the doctrine of the church of *England*.

“You believe, says the writer above-mentioned, that no good work can be previous to justification, nor consequently a condition of it. But God be praised, our church has no where delivered such *abominable* doctrine.” *Page 14*.

“The clergy contend for inward holiness, as previous to the first justification—this is the doctrine they universally inculcate, and which you cannot oppose without contradicting the doctrine of our church.” *Page 26*.

“All your strongest persuasives to the love of God, will not blanch over the deformity of that doctrine, that men may be justified—by faith alone—Unless you publicly recant this *horrid* doctrine, your faith is vain.” *Page 27*.

“If you will vouchsafe to purge out this *venomous* part of your principles, in which the *wide, essential, fundamental, irreconcilable difference*, as you very justly term it, mainly consists, then there will be found so far no disagreement between you and the clergy of the church of *England*.” *ibid*.

4. In order to be clearly and fully satisfied, what the doctrine of the church of *England* is, (as it stands opposite to the doctrine of the *Antinomians*, on the one hand, and to that of *justification by works* on the other) I will simply set down what occurs on this head, either in her Liturgy, Articles or Homilies.

“Spare thou them, O God, which *confess their faults*: restore thou them that are *penitent*, according to thy promises declared unto mankind in Christ Jesu our Lord.”

“He pardoneth and absolveth all them that *truly repent* and *unfeignedly believe* his holy gospel.”

“Almighty God, who dost forgive the sins of them that are *penitent*, create and make in us new and contrite hearts; that we *worthily lamenting our sins* and *acknowledging our wretchedness*, may obtain of thee perfect remission and forgiveness, thro’ Jesus Christ our Lord.” Collect for *Ash-Wednesday*.

“Almighty God—hath promised forgiveness of sins to all them that with *hearty repentance and true faith* turn unto him.” *Communion office*.

“Our Lord Jesus Christ hath left power to absolve all sinners who *truly repent* and *believe* in him.” *Visitation of the sick*.

“Give him *unfeigned repentance* and stedfast *faith*, that his sins may be blotted out.” *ibid*.

“He is a merciful receiver of all true, *penitent* sinners, and is ready to pardon us, if we come unto him with *faithful repentance*.” *Commination office*.

Infants indeed our church supposes to be justified in baptism, altho’ they cannot then either *believe* or *repent*. But she expressly requires both *repentance* and *faith*, in those who come to be baptized when they are of riper years.

*As earnestly therefore as our church inculcates justification by faith alone, she nevertheless supposes *repentance* to be previous to faith, and *fruits meet for repentance*: yea, and universal holiness to be previous to final justification, as evidently appears from the following words:

*“Let us beseech him—that the rest of our life may be pure and holy, so that at the last we may come to his eternal joy.” *Absolution*.

“May we seriously apply our hearts to that holy and heavenly wisdom here, which may in the end bring us to life everlasting.” *Visitation of the sick*.

“Raise us from the death of sin unto the life of righteousness,—that at the last day we may be found acceptable in thy sight.” *Burial office*.

“If we from henceforth walk in his ways,—seeking always his glory, Christ will set us on his right hand.” *Commination office*.

5. We come next to the articles of our church: the former part of the ninth runs thus:

Of Original or Birth-Sin.

“Original sin—is the fault and corruption of the nature of every man—whereby man is very far gone from original righteousness, and is of his own nature inclined to evil, so that the flesh lusteth always contrary to the spirit: and therefore in every person born into this world, it deserveth God’s wrath and damnation.”

ARTICLE X. Of Free-Will.

“The condition of man after the fall of *Adam* is such, that he cannot turn and prepare himself by his own natural strength and good works to faith and calling upon God. Wherefore we have no power to do good works, pleasant and acceptable to God, without the grace of God by Christ preventing us, that we may have a good will, and working with us when we have that good will.”

ARTICLE XI. *Of the Justification of Man.*

“We are accounted righteous before God, only for the merit of our Lord and Saviour Jesus Christ by faith, and not for our own works or deservings. Wherefore that we are justified by faith only, is a most wholesome doctrine, and very full of comfort, as more largely is expressed in the homily of justification.”

I believe this article relates to the *meritorious cause* of justification, rather than to the *condition* of it. On this therefore I do not build any thing concerning it, but on those that follow.

ARTICLE XII. *Of Good Works.*

“Albeit that good works which are the fruits of faith and follow after justification, cannot put away our sins—yet are they pleasing and acceptable to God in Christ, and do spring out necessarily of a true and lively faith: insomuch that by them a lively faith may be as evidently known, as a tree may be known by the fruit.”

We are taught here, 1. That *good works* in general, *follow after* justification. 2. That they *spring out of* a true and lively *faith*, that faith whereby we are justified: 3. That true, justifying faith may be as evidently known by them, as a tree discerned by the fruit.

Does it not follow, that the supposing any *good work* to *go before* justification, is full as absurd as the supposing an apple or any other fruit to grow before the tree?

But let us hear the church, speaking yet more plainly.

ARTICLE XIII. *Of Works done before Justification.*

“Works done before the grace of Christ, and the inspiration of his Spirit, (*i. e.* before justification, as the title expresses it) are not pleasant to God, forasmuch as they spring not of faith in Jesu Christ—Yea rather, for that they are not done as God hath willed and commanded them to be done, we doubt not they have the nature of sin.”

Now, if all works done before justification, have the nature of sin, (both because they spring not of faith in Christ, and because they are not done as God hath willed and commanded them to be done) what becomes of sanctification previous to justification? It is utterly excluded: seeing whatever is previous to justification, is not good or holy, but evil and sinful.

*Altho' therefore our church does frequently assert, that we ought to repent and bring forth fruits meet for repentance, if ever we would attain to that faith, whereby alone we are justified: yet she never asserts (and here the hinge of the question turns) that these are *good works*, so long as they are previous to justification. Nay she expressly asserts the direct contrary, viz. That they have all the nature of sin. So that this "Horrid, scandalous, wicked, abominable, venomous, blasphemous doctrine," is nevertheless the doctrine of the church of *England*.

6. It remains, to consider what occurs in the homilies, first with regard to the *meritorious cause* of our justification, agreeable to the 11th, and then with regard to the *condition* of it, agreeable to the 12th and 13th articles.

"These things must go together in our justification; upon God's part, his great mercy and grace; upon Christ's part, the satisfaction of God's justice; and upon our part, true and lively faith in the merits of Jesus Christ."
Homily on salvation, part I.

"So that the grace of God doth not shut ♦ out the justice (or righteousness) of God in our justification; but only shutteth out the righteousness of man—as to *deserving* our justification."

♦ "our" replaced with "out"

"And therefore St. *Paul* declareth nothing on the behalf of man, concerning his justification but only a true faith."

*“And yet that faith doth not shut out repentance, hope, love, to be join’d with faith (that is, *afterwards*; see below) in every man that is justified——neither doth faith shut out the righteousness of our good works, necessarily to be done *afterwards*. But it excludeth them so, that we may not do them to this intent to be made just (or, to be justified) by doing them.”

“That we are *justified by faith alone*, is spoken, to take away clearly all *merit*, of our works, and wholly to ascribe the *merit and deserving* of our justification unto Christ only.” *ibid. Part II.*

“The true meaning of this saying, we be justified by faith only, is this, we be justified by the *merits* of Christ only, and not of our own works.” *ibid. Part III.*

7. Thus far touching the *meritorious cause* of our justification; referred to in the 11th article. The 12th and 13th are a summary of what now follows, with regard to the *condition* of it.

“Of (justifying) true faith, three things are specially to be noted, 1. That it bringeth forth good works. 2. That without it, can no good works be done. 3. What good works it doth bring forth.” *Sermon on faith. Part I.*

“Without faith can no good work be done, accepted and pleasant unto God. For *as a branch cannot bear fruit of itself*, saith our Saviour Christ, *except it abide in the vine, so cannot you, except you abide in me*. Faith giveth life to the soul; and they be as much dead to God that lack faith, as they be to the world, whose bodies lack souls. Without faith all that is done of us, is but dead before God. Even as a picture is but a dead representation of the thing itself, so be the works of all unfaithful (unbelieving) persons before God. They be but shadows of lively and good things, and not good things indeed. For true faith doth give life to the works, and without faith no work is good before God.” *ibid. Part III.*

“We must set no good works before faith, nor think that before faith a man may do any good works. For such works are as the course of an horse that runneth out of the way, which taketh great labour, but to no purpose.” *ibid.*

“Without faith we have no virtues, but only the shadows of them. All the life of them that lack the true faith is sin.” *ibid.*

“As men first have life, and after be nourished, so must our faith go before, and after be nourished with good works. And life may be without nourishment, but nourishment cannot be without life.” *Homily of works annexed to faith. Part I.*

“I can shew a man, that by faith without works lived and came to heaven. But without faith never man had life. The thief on the cross only believed, and the most merciful God justified him. Truth it is, if he had lived and not regarded faith and the works thereof, he should have lost his salvation again. But this I say, faith by itself saved him. But works by themselves never justified any man.”

“Good works go not before, in him which shall afterwards be justified. But good works do follow after, when a man is first justified.” *Homily on fasting. Part I.*

8. From the whole tenor then of her liturgy, articles and homilies, the doctrine of the church of *England* appears to be this:

1. That no *good work* properly so called, can *go before* justification:
2. That *no degree* of true sanctification can be previous to it.
3. That as the *meritorious cause* of justification is, the life and death of Christ; so the *condition* of it, is faith. Faith alone; and
4. That both inward and outward holiness, are consequent on this faith, and are the ordinary, stated condition, of final justification.

9. And what more can *you* desire, who have hitherto opposed *justification by faith alone*, merely upon a principle of conscience; because you was zealous for holiness and good works? Do I not effectually secure these from contempt, at the same time that I defend the doctrines of the church? I not only allow, but vehemently contend, that none shall ever enter into glory, who is not holy on earth, as well in heart, as *in all manner of conversation*. I cry aloud, *Let all that have believed, be careful to maintain good works*: and, *Let every one that nameth the name of Christ, depart from all iniquity*. I exhort even those who are conscious they do not believe, *Cease to do evil, learn to do well: the kingdom of heaven is at hand*; therefore *repent, and bring forth fruits meet for repentance*. Are not these directions the very same in substance, which you yourself would give to persons so circumstanced? What means then this endless *strife of words*? Or, *what doth your arguing prove*?

10. Many of those who are perhaps as zealous of good works, as you, think I have allowed you too much.—Nay, my brethren, but how can we help allowing it, if we allow the scriptures to be from God? For is it not written, and do not you yourselves believe, *Without holiness no man shall see the Lord*? And how then, without fighting about words, can we deny, that holiness is a condition of final acceptance? And, as to the first acceptance or pardon, does not all experience as well as scripture prove, that no man ever yet truly *believed the gospel*, who did not first *repent*? That none was ever yet truly *convinced of righteousness*, who was not first *convinced of sin*? Repentance therefore in *this* sense, we cannot deny to be necessarily previous to faith. Is it not equally undeniable, that the running back into known, wilful sin, (suppose it were drunkenness or uncleanness) stifles that repentance or conviction? And can that repentance come to any good issue in his soul, who resolves not to forgive his brother? Or who obstinately refrains from what God convinces him is right, whether it be prayer or hearing his word? Would you scruple yourself to tell one of these, “Why, if you *will* thus drink away all conviction, how should you ever truly know your want of Christ? Or consequently, believe in him?—If you *will* not forgive your brother *his* trespasses, neither will your heavenly Father forgive you *your* trespasses—If you will not ask, how can you expect to receive?—If you *will* not hear, how can *faith come by hearing*? It is plain, you *grieve the Spirit of God*; you *will not* have him to reign over you. Take care that he does not utterly depart from you. For *unto him that hath, shall be given: but from him that hath not, i. e. uses it not, shall be taken away, even that which he hath.*” Would you scruple, on a proper occasion to say this? You could not scruple it, if you believe the bible. But in saying this, you allow all which I have said, viz. That previous to justifying faith, there *must* be repentance, and if opportunity permit, *Fruits meet for repentance*.

*11. And yet I allow you this, that altho' both repentance and the fruits thereof are in *some sense* necessary before justification, yet neither the one nor the other is necessary in the *same sense*, or in the *same degree* with faith. Not in the *same degree*. For in whatever moment a man believes (in the Christian sense of the word) he is justified, his sins are blotted out, *his faith is counted to him for righteousness*. But it is not so, at whatever moment he repents, or brings forth any, or all the fruits of repentance. Faith alone therefore justifies; which repentance alone does not; much less any outward work. And consequently, none of these are necessary to justification, in the *same degree* with faith.

*Nor in the *same sense*. For none of these has so direct, immediate a relation to justification as faith. This is *proximately* necessary thereto; repentance, *remotely*, as it is necessary to the increase or continuance of faith. And even in this sense, these are only necessary, on supposition—if there be time and opportunity for them: for in many instances there is not: but God cuts short his work, and faith prevents the fruits of repentance. So that the general proportion is not overthrown, but clearly established by these concessions; and we conclude still, both on the authority of scripture and the church, that faith alone is the proximate condition of justification.

III. 1. I was once inclined to believe that none would openly object, against what I had any where said of the *nature of salvation*. How greatly then was I surprised some months ago, when I was shewn a kind of circular letter, which one¹ of those whom *the Holy Ghost hath made overseers* of his church, I was informed, had sent to all the clergy of his diocese!

¹ The (then) Archbishop of York.

Part of it ran (nearly, if not exactly) thus:

“There is great indiscretion in preaching up a sort of religion, as the true and only Christianity, which in their own account of it, consists in an enthusiastic ardor, to be understood or attained by very few, and not to be practised without breaking in upon the common duties of life.”

O my Lord, what manner of words are these! Supposing candour and love out of the question, are they the words of truth? I dare stake my life upon it, there is not one true clause in all this paragraph.

The propositions contained therein, are these:

1. That the religion I preach, consists in enthusiastic ardor:
2. That it can be attained by very few:
3. That it can be understood by very few:
4. That it cannot be practised without breaking in upon the common duties of life.
5. And that all this may be proved by my own account of it.

I earnestly intreat your grace, to review my own account of it, as it stands in any of my former writings; or to consider the short account which is given in this. And if you can thence make good any one of those propositions, I do hereby promise before God and the world, that I will never preach more.

At present I do not well understand what your grace means by “An enthusiastic ardor.” Surely you do not mean, the love of God! No, not though a poor, pardoned sinner should *carry it so far*, as to love the Lord his God, with all his heart, and with all his soul, and with all his strength! But this alone is the *ardor* which I *preach up*, as the foundation of *the true and only Christianity*. I pray God so to fill your whole heart therewith, that you may praise him for ever and ever.

But why should your grace believe, that the love of God, *can be attained by very few*? Or, that it *can be understood by very few*? All who attain it, understand it well. And did not he who is loving to every man design, that every man should attain true love? O that all would know in this their day, the things that make for their peace!

And *cannot* the love both of God and our neighbour *be practised, without breaking in upon the common duties of life?* Nay, can any of the common duties of life, be rightly practised without them? I apprehend not. I apprehend I am then laying the true, the only foundation for all those duties, when I preach *Thou shalt love the Lord thy God with all thy heart, and thy neighbour as thyself.*

2. With this letter was sent (I believe to every clergyman in the diocese) the pamphlet intitled, *Observations on the conduct and behaviour of a certain sect, usually distinguished by the name of Methodists.* It has been generally supposed to be wrote by a person, who is every way my superior. Perhaps one reason why he did not inscribe his name was, that his greatness might not make me afraid: and that I might have liberty to stand, as it were, on even ground, while I answer for myself.

In considering, therefore, such parts of these *observations*, as naturally fall in my way, I will take that method which, I believe, the author desires, using no ceremony at all: but speaking as to an equal, that it may the more easily be discerned, where the truth lies.

The first query relating to doctrine, is this.

“Whether notions in religion may not be heightened to such *extremes*, as to lead *some* into a disregard of religion itself, through despair of attaining such exalted heights? And whether *others* who have imbibed those notions, may not be led by them, into a disregard and disesteem of the common duties and offices of life? To such a degree, at least, as is inconsistent with that attention to them, and that diligence in them, which Providence has made necessary to the well-being of private families and public societies, and which christianity does not only require in all stations, and in all conditions, but declares at the same time, that the performance even of the lowest offices in life, *as unto God*, (whose providence has placed people in their several stations) is truly a *serving of Christ*, and will not fail of its reward in the next world?”

You have interwoven so many particulars in this general question, that I must divide and answer them one by one.

Q. 1. Whether notions in religion may not be heightened to such *extremes* as to lead *some* into a disregard of religion itself?

A. They may. But that I have so heightened them, it lies upon you to prove.

Q. 2. Whether *others* may not be led into a disregard of religion, through despair of attaining such exalted heights?

A. What heights? The loving GOD with all our heart? I believe, this is the most exalted height in man or angel. But I have not heard, that any have been led into a disregard of religion, through despair of attaining this.

Q. 3. Whether *others* who have imbibed these notions, may not be led by them, into a disregard and disesteem, of the *common* duties and offices of life?

A. My notions are, “True religion is the loving God with all our heart, and our neighbour as ourselves; and in that love abstaining from all evil, and doing all possible good to all men.” Now, it is not possible in the nature of things, that any should be *led by these notions*, into either a disregard or disesteem of the *common* duties and offices of life.

Q. 4. But may they not be *led by them* into such a degree at least, of disregard for the common duties of life, as is inconsistent with that attention to them, and diligence in them, which Providence has made necessary?

A. No. Quite the reverse. They lead men to discharge all those duties with the strictest diligence and closest attention.

Q. 5. Does not christianity require this attention and diligence in all stations and in all conditions?

A. Yes.

Q. 6. Does it not declare, that the performance even of the lowest offices of life, *as unto God*, is truly *a serving of Christ*? and will not fail of its reward in the next world?

A. It does. But whom are you confuting? Not me. For this is the doctrine I preach continually.

3. Query the second. “Whether the enemy of christianity may not find his account, in carrying christianity, which was designed for a rule to *all* stations and *all* conditions, to such *heights* as make it fairly practicable by a *very few*, in comparison, or rather by none?”

I answer, 1. The *height* to which we carry christianity (as was but now observed) is this, *Thou shalt love the Lord thy God with all thy heart, and thy neighbour as thyself*. 2. The enemy of christianity cannot find his account, in our carrying it to *this height*. 3. You will not say on reflection, that christianity, even in this height, is practicable by *very few*, or rather by *none*: You yourself will confess, this is a rule (as God designed it should) for *all* stations, and *all* conditions.

Query the third. “Whether, in particular, the carrying the doctrine of justification *by faith alone* to such a height, as not to allow that a sincere and careful observance of moral duties is so much as a *condition* of our acceptance with God, and of our being justified in his sight: Whether this, I say, does not naturally lead people to a *disregard* of those duties, and a low esteem of them; or rather to think them no part of the christian religion?”

I trust justification *by faith alone*, has been so explained above, as to secure, not only a high esteem, but also a careful and sincere observance of all moral duties.

4. Query the fourth. “Whether a due and regular attendance on the public offices of religion, paid by good men in a serious and composed way, does not answer the true ends of devotion, and is not a better evidence of the co-operation of the Holy Spirit, than those sudden agonies, roarings, screamings, tremblings, droppings down, ravings, and madnesses, into which their hearers have been cast?”

I must answer this ◆query likewise part by part.

◆ “query” replaced with “query”

Q. 1. Whether a due and regular attendance on the public offices of religion, paid in a serious and composed way, by good [*i. e.* well meaning] men, does not answer the true ends of devotion?

A. I suppose by *devotion* you mean public worship; by the *true ends* of it, the love of God and man: and by a *due and regular attendance on the public offices of religion, paid in a serious and composed way*, the going as often as we have opportunity to our parish church, and to the sacrament there administred. If so, the question is, “Whether *this attendance on those offices*, does not produce the love of God and man?” I answer, sometimes it does; and sometimes it does not. I myself thus attended them for many years; and yet am conscious to myself, that during that whole time, I had no more of the love of God than a stone. And I know many hundreds, perhaps thousands of serious persons, who are ready to testify the same thing.

Q. 2. But is not this a better evidence of the co-operation of the Holy Spirit, than those *sudden agonies*?

A. All these persons, as well as I, can testify also, that this is no evidence at all of the co-operation of the Holy Spirit. For some years I attended these public offices, *because I would not be punished for non-attendance*. And many of these attended them, *because their parents did before them*, or *because they would not lose their character*. Many more, because they confounded the means with the end, and fancied this *opus operatum* would bring them to heaven. How many thousands are now under this strong delusion? Beware, you bring not their blood on your own head?

Q. 3. However, does not this attendance better answer those ends, than those roarings, screamings, &c.?

I suppose you mean, “Better than an attendance on that preaching, which has often been accompanied with these.”

I answer. 1. There is no manner of need to set the one in opposition to the other: Seeing we continually exhort all who attend on our preaching, to attend the offices of the church. And they do pay a more regular attendance there, than ever they did before. 2. Their attending the church did not, in fact answer those ends at all, 'till they attended this preaching also. 3. It is the preaching of remission of sins through Jesus Christ, which alone answers the true ends of devotion. And this will always be accompanied with the co-operation of the Holy Spirit; tho' not always with sudden agonies, roarings, screamings, tremblings, or droppings down. Indeed if God is pleased at any time to permit any of these, I cannot hinder it. Neither can this hinder the work of his Spirit in the soul: which may be carried on either with or without them. But 4. I cannot apprehend it to be any reasonable proof, That "this is not the work of God," that a convinced sinner should *fall into an extreme agony, both of body and soul*, (Journal 3. page 26.) That another should *roar for the disquietness of her heart*, (page 40.) that others should *scream or cry with a loud and bitter cry*, "*What must we do to be saved?*" (page 50.) that others should *exceedingly tremble and quake*, (page 58.) And others, in a deep sense of the majesty of God, *should fall prostrate upon the ground*. (page 59.)

Indeed by picking out one single word from a sentence, and then putting together what you had gleaned in sixty or seventy pages, you have drawn a terrible grouse, for them who look no farther than those two lines in *the observations*. But the bare addition of half a line to each word, just as it stands in the place from which you quoted it, reconciles all both to scripture and reason, and the spectre-form vanishes away.

You have taken into your account, *ravings, and madneses too*. As instances of the former, you refer to the case of *John Haydon*, page 44. and of *Thomas Maxfield*, page 50. I wish you would calmly consider, his reasoning on that head, who is not prejudiced in my favour. "What influence sudden and sharp awakenings may have upon the body, I pretend not to explain. But I make no question *Satan*, so far as he gets power may exert himself on such occasions, partly to hinder the good work in the persons who are thus touched with the sharp arrows of conviction, and partly to disparage the work of God, as if it tended to lead people to distraction."

For instances of madness you refer to pages 88, 90, 91, 92, 93. The words in page 88. are these:

“I could not but be under some concern, with regard to one or two persons, who were tormented in an unaccountable manner, and *seemed* to be indeed *lunatic* as well as *sore vexed*—Soon after I was sent for to one of these, who was so strangely *torn of the devil*, that I almost wondered her relations did not say, much religion *hath made thee mad*. We prayed God to *bruise Satan* under her feet. Immediately *we had the petition we asked of him*. She cried out vehemently ‘He is gone, he is gone,’ and was filled with the Spirit of *love, and of a sound mind*. I have seen her many times since, strong in the Lord. When I asked abruptly, ‘What do you desire now?’ She answered, ‘Heaven.’ I asked, ‘What is in your heart?’ She replied, ‘God.’ I asked, ‘But how is your heart when any thing provokes you?’ She said, ‘By the grace of God, I am not provoked at any thing. All the things of this world pass by me as shadows.’ Are these the words of one that is beside herself? Let any man of reason judge!”

Your next instance, page 90. stands thus:

“About noon I came to *Usk*, where I preached to a small company of poor people, on, *The Son of man is come, to save that which is lost*. One grey-headed man wept and trembled exceedingly: and another who was there (I have since heard) as well as two or three who were at the *Devauden, are gone quite distracted*; that is (my express words that immediately follow, specifying what it was which *some accounted distraction*) ‘They mourn and refuse to be comforted, until they have *redemption through his blood*.’”

If *you* think the case mentioned, pages 92, 93. to be another instance of madness, I contend not. It was because I did not understand that uncommon case, that I prefaced it with this reflection, “The fact I nakedly relate, and leave every man to his own judgment upon it.” Only be pleased to observe, that this *madness*, if such it was, is no more chargeable upon *me* than upon *you*. For the subject of it had no relation to, or commerce with *me*, nor had I ever seen her before that hour.

5. Query the fifth. “Whether those exalted strains in religion, and an imagination of being already in a state of *perfection*, are not apt to lead men to spiritual pride, and to a contempt of their fellow christians; while they consider *them* as only going on in what they call the *low* and *imperfect* way, (i. e. as growing in grace and goodness only *by degrees*) even though it appear by the *lives* of those who are considered by them as in that *low* and *imperfect* way, that they are persons who are gradually working out their salvation, by their own honest endeavours, and through the ordinary assistances of God’s grace; with an humble reliance upon the merits of Christ for the pardon of their sins, and the acceptance of their sincere, though *imperfect* services?”

I must divide this query too, but first permit me to ask, What do you mean by *those exalted strains in religion*? I have said again and again, I know of no more exalted strain, than “I will love thee, O Lord, my God:” Especially according to the propriety of *David*’s expression אֶרְחֹמֶךָ יְהוָה. *Ex intimis visceribus diligam te, Domine*. This premised, let us go on step by step.

Q. 1. Whether the preaching of “loving God from our inmost bowels,” is not apt to lead men to spiritual pride, and to a contempt of their fellow Christians?

A. No: But so far as it takes place, it will humble them to the dust.

Q. 2. Whether an imagination of being already in a state of *perfection*, is not *apt to lead* men into spiritual pride.

A. 1. If it be a *false* imagination, it is spiritual pride. 2. But *true* Christian perfection is no other than humble love.

Q. 3. Do not men who imagine they have attained this, despise others, as only going on in what they account the *low* and *imperfect* way, i. e. as growing in grace and goodness *by degrees*.

A. 1. Men who *only imagine* they have attained this, may probably despise those that are going in any way. 2. But the growing in grace and goodness by degrees, is no mark of a *low* and *imperfect* way. Those who are fathers in Christ, grow in grace *by degrees*, as well as the newborn babes.

Q. 4. Do they not despise those who are working out their salvation, with an humble reliance upon the merits of Christ for the pardon of their sins, and the acceptance of their sincere, tho' *imperfect* services?

A. 1. They who really love God, despise no man. But 2. they grieve to hear many talk of thus *relying on* Christ, who, though perhaps they are grave, honest, moral men, yet by their own words, appear, not to love God at all; whose souls cleave to the dust, who love the world; who have no part of the mind that was in Christ.

6. Query the sixth. “Whether the same exalted strains and notions, do not tend to weaken the *natural* and *civil* relations among men, by leading the inferiors into whose heads those notions are infused to a disesteem of their superiors; while they consider them as in a much *lower dispensation* than themselves; though those superiors are otherwise *sober* and *good* men, and regular attendants on the ordinances of religion?”

I have mentioned before, What those exalted notions are: these do not tend to weaken either the *natural* or *civil* relations among men; or to lead inferiors to a disesteem of their superiors, even where those superiors are neither *good* nor *sober* men.

Query the seventh. “Whether a *gradual* improvement in grace and goodness is not a better foundation of comfort, and of an assurance of a gospel new-birth, than that which is founded on the doctrine of a *sudden* and *instantaneous* change; which, if there be any such thing, is not so easily distinguished from fancy and imagination; the workings whereof we may well suppose to be more *strong* and *powerful*, while the person considers himself in the state of one who is admitted as a ◆candidate for such a change, and is taught in due time to expect it?”

◆ “canditate” replaced with “candidate”

Let us go one step at a time.

Q. 1. Whether a *gradual* improvement in grace and goodness, is not a good foundation of comfort?

A. Doubtless it is, if by grace and goodness be meant the knowledge and love of God through Christ.

Q. 2. Whether it be not a good *foundation* of an assurance of a gospel new-birth?

A. If we daily grow in this knowledge and love, it is a good *proof* that we are born of the Spirit. But this does in no wise supersede the previous witness of God's Spirit with ours, that we are the children of God. And this is properly the *foundation* of the assurance of faith.

Q. 3. Whether this improvement is not a better foundation of comfort, and of an assurance of a gospel new-birth, than that which is founded on the doctrine of a sudden and instantaneous change?

A. A better foundation than *that*—*That!* What? To what substantive does this refer? According to the rules of grammar, (for all the other substantives are in the genitive case, and consequently to be considered as only parts of that which governs them) you must mean, "A better foundation than that foundation which is founded on this doctrine." As soon as I understand the question, I will endeavour to answer it.

Q. 4. Can that *sudden* and *instantaneous* change be easily distinguished from fancy and imagination?

A. Just as easily as light from darkness: seeing it brings with it a peace that passeth all understanding, a joy unspeakable, full of glory, the love of God and all mankind filling the heart, and power over all sin.

Q. 5. May we not well suppose the workings of imagination to be more *strong* and *powerful* in one who is taught to expect such a change?

A. Perhaps we may—But still the tree is known by its fruits. And such fruits as those above-mentioned imagination was never yet strong enough to produce, nor any *power*, save that of the Almighty.

7. There is only one clause in the eighth query which falls under our present enquiry.

“They make it their *principal* employ, wherever they go, to instil into people a few *favorite tenets* of their own; and this with such diligence and zeal as if the whole of Christianity depended upon them, and all efforts toward the true Christian life, without a belief of those tenets, were vain and ineffectual.”

I plead guilty to this charge. I do make it my *principal*, nay, my whole employ, and that wherever I go, to instil into the people, a few *favourite tenets*. (Only be it observed, they are not *my own*, but his that sent me.) And it is undoubtedly true, that this I do, (tho’ deeply conscious of my want, both of zeal and diligence) as if the whole of Christianity depended upon them, and all efforts without them were void and vain.

I frequently sum them all up in one, *in Christ Jesus*, (*i. e.* according to his gospel) *neither circumcision availeth any thing nor uncircumcision, but faith which worketh by love*. But many times I instil them one by one, under these, or the like expressions. *Thou shalt love the Lord thy God with all thy heart, and with all thy mind, and with all thy soul, and with all thy strength, thou shalt love thy neighbour as thyself; as thy own soul; as Christ loved us. God is love: and he that dwelleth in love, dwelleth in God, and God in him. Love worketh no ill to his neighbour: therefore love is the fulfilling of the law. While we have time let us do good unto all men; especially unto them that are of the household of faith. Whatsoever ye would that men should do unto you, even so do unto them.*

These are my *favourite tenets*, and have been for many years. O that I could instil them into every soul throughout the land! Ought they not to be instilled with such diligence and zeal, as if the whole of Christianity depended upon them? For who can deny, that all efforts toward a Christian life, without more than a bare *belief*, without a thorough *experience* and *practice* of these, are utterly vain and ineffectual?

*8. Part of your ninth *query* is to the same effect:

“A few young heads set up *their own schemes*, as the great standard of Christianity: and indulge *their own notions* to such a degree, as to perplex, unhinge, terrify and distract the minds of multitudes of people, who have lived from their infancy under a gospel-ministry, and in the regular exercise of a gospel-worship. And all this, by persuading them, that they neither are, nor can be true Christians, but by adhering to *their doctrines*.”

What do you mean by *their own schemes*? *Their own notions*? *Their doctrines*? Are they not *yours* too? Are they not the schemes, the notions, the doctrines of Jesus Christ? The great, fundamental truths of his gospel? Can you deny one of them, without denying the bible?—It is hard for you to kick against the pricks!

“They persuade (you say) multitudes of people, that they cannot be true Christians, but by adhering to their doctrines.” Why, who says they can? Whosoever he be, I will prove him to be an infidel. Do *you* say, that any man can be a true Christian, without loving God and his neighbour? Surely you have not so learned Christ! It is *your* doctrine, as well as *mine*, and St. Paul’s, *Though I speak with the tongue of men and angels, though I have all knowledge, and all faith; though I give all my goods to feed the poor, yea, my body to be burned, and have not love, I am nothing.*

Whatever public worship, therefore, people may have attended, or whatever ministry they have lived under from their infancy, they must, at all hazards, be convinced of this, or they perish for ever: yea, though that conviction at first *unhinge* them ever so much; though it should in a manner, *distract* them for a season. For it is better they should be *perplexed* and *terrified* now, than that they should sleep on and awake in hell.

9. In the 10, 12, and 13th *queries* I am not concerned. But you include me also, when you say in the 11th, “They absolutely deny, that recreations of any kind, considered as such, are, or can be innocent.”

I cannot find any such assertion of mine, either in the place you refer to, or any other. But what kinds of recreation are innocent, it is easy to determine by that plain rule, *Whether ye eat or drink, or whatever ye do, do all to the glory of God.*

I am now to take my leave of you for the present. But first I would earnestly intreat you, to acquaint yourself what our doctrines are, before you make any farther *observations* upon them. Surely, touching the *nature* of salvation we agree, That *pure religion and undefiled is this, to visit the fatherless and widow in their affliction, to do all possible good, from a principle of love to God and man: and to keep ourselves unspotted from the world,* inwardly and outwardly to abstain from all evil.

*10. With regard to the *condition* of salvation, it may be remembered, that I allow, not only faith, but likewise holiness or universal obedience, to be the ordinary condition of *final* salvation: and that when I say, faith alone is the condition of *present* salvation, what I would assert is this; 1. That without faith no man can be saved from his sins, can be either inwardly or outwardly holy. And 2. That at what time soever faith is given, holiness commences in the soul. For that instant, *the love of God,* (which is the source of holiness) *is shed abroad in the heart.*

But it is objected by the author of “*The Notions of the Methodists disproved,*” “St. James says, *Can faith save him?*” I answer, such a faith as is without works cannot *bring a man to heaven.* But this is quite beside the present question.

You object, 2. “St. Paul says, that *faith made perfect by love,* St. James, that *faith made perfect by works,* is the condition of salvation.” You mean final salvation. I say so too: but this also is beside the question.

You object, 3. *That the belief of the gospel,* is called the *obedience of faith,* Romans i. 5. And 4. That what *Isaiah* terms *believing,* St. Paul terms *obeying.* Suppose I grant you both the one and the other, what will you infer?

You object, 5. That in one scripture our Lord is stiled *The Saviour of them that believe*: and in another, *The author of eternal salvation to all them that obey him*. 6. That to the *Galatians* St. Paul writes, *Neither circumcision availeth any thing, nor uncircumcision, but faith which worketh by love*: and to the *Corinthians*, *circumcision is nothing, and uncircumcision is nothing, but the keeping the commandments of God*. And hence you conclude, “There are several texts of scripture, wherein unbelief and disobedience are equivalently used.” Very true: but can you conclude from thence, that we are not *saved by faith alone*?

11. You proceed to answer some texts which I had quoted. The first is *Ephesians ii. 8. By grace ye are saved, through faith*. “But (say you) faith does not mean here, that grace especially so called, but includes also obedience.” But how do you prove this? That circumstance you had forgot: and so run off with a comment upon the context; to which I have no other objection, than that it is nothing at all to the question.

Indeed some time after you add, “It is plain then that good works are always, in St. Paul’s judgment, joined with faith.” (So undoubtedly they are, that is, as an effect is always joined with its cause) “And *therefore* we are not saved by faith alone.” I cannot possibly allow the consequence.

You afterwards cite two more texts, and add, “You see mere faith cannot be a condition of justification.” You are out of your way. We are no more talking now of justification than of final salvation.

In considering *Acts xvi. 31. Believe in the Lord Jesus and thou shalt be saved*. You say again, “Here the word *believe* does not signify faith only.—Faith necessarily produces charity and repentance; *therefore*, these are expressed by the word *believe*.” i. e. Faith necessarily produces holiness. Therefore holiness is a condition of holiness. I want farther proof. That *Paul and Silas spake unto him the word of the Lord*; and that his faith did *in the same hour* work by love, I take to be no proof at all.

You then undertake to shew, that confessing our sins, is a condition of justification, and that a confidence in the love of God, is not a condition. Some of your words are, “This, good Sir, give me leave to say, is the greatest nonsense and contradiction possible. It [♦](#)is impossible you can understand this jargon yourself, and therefore you labour in vain to make it intelligible to others. You soar aloft on eagle’s wings, and leave the poor people to gape and stare after you.”

[♦](#) “it” replaced with “is”

This is very pretty, and very lively. But it is nothing to the purpose. For we are not now speaking of justification: neither have I said one word of “the condition of justification” in the whole tract to which you here refer.

“In the next place (say you) if we are saved (finally you mean) only by a confidence in the love of God.”—Here I must stop you again; you are now running beside the question, on the other hand. The sole position which I here advance is this: true believers are saved from inward and outward sin by faith. By faith alone the love of God and all mankind is shed abroad in their hearts, bringing with it the mind that was in *Christ*, and producing all holiness of conversation.

IV. 1. I am now to consider, what has been lately objected, with regard to the *nature* of saving *faith*.

The author last mentioned “cannot understand how those texts of St. *John* are at all to the purpose.” *1 John iii. 1. Behold what manner of love the Father hath bestowed upon us, that we should be called the sons of God. And chapter iv. 19. We love him, because he first loved us.* I answer 1. These texts were not produced in *the appeal*, by way of proof, but of illustration only. But 2. I apprehend they may be produced as a proof, both that Christian faith implies a confidence in the love of God, and that such a confidence has a direct tendency to salvation, to holiness both of heart and life.

Behold what manner of love the Father hath bestowed upon us, that we should be called the sons of God! Are not these words an expression of Christian faith? As direct an one as can well be conceived? And I appeal to every man, whether they do not express the strongest confidence of the love of God? Your own comment puts this beyond dispute. “Let us consider attentively and with grateful hearts, the great love and mercy of God, in calling us to be his sons, and bestowing on us the privileges belonging to such.” Do you not perceive, that you have given up the cause? You have yourself taught us, that these words imply “a sense of the great love and mercy of God, in bestowing upon us the privileges belonging to his sons.”

The apostle adds, *Beloved, now are we the sons of God; and it doth not yet appear what we shall be: but we know that when he shall appear, we shall be like him; for we shall see him as he is.*

I suppose no one will say, either that these words are not expressive of Christian faith; or, that they do not imply the strongest confidence in the love of God. It follows, *And every man that hath this hope in him, purifieth himself even as he is pure.*

Hence it appears, that this faith is a saving faith, that there is the closest connexion between this faith and holiness. This text therefore is directly to the purpose, in respect of both the propositions to be proved.

The other is, *We love him, because he first loved us.* And here also, for fear I should fail in the proof, you have drawn it up ready to my hands.

“God sent his only son—to redeem us from sin, by purchasing for us grace and salvation. By which grace we—thro’ faith and repentance have our sins pardoned—and therefore we are bound to return the tribute of our love and gratitude, and to obey him faithfully as long as we live.”

Now, that *we have our sins pardoned*, if we *do not* know they are pardoned, cannot bind us either to love or obedience. But if we do know it, and by that very knowledge, or confidence in the pardoning love of God, are both bound and enabled to love and obey him, this is the whole of what I contend for.

2. You afterwards object against some other text which I had cited, to illustrate the nature of saving faith. My words were, “Hear believing *Job*, declaring his faith, *I know that my Redeemer liveth.*” I here affirm two things, 1. That *Job* was then a believer. 2. That he declared his faith in these words. And all I affirm, you allow. Your own words are, “God was pleased to bestow upon him a strong assurance of his favour—to inspire him with a prophecy of the resurrection, and that he should have a share in it.”

I went on, “Hear *Thomas*, when having seen he believed, crying out my Lord and my God.” Hereon you comment thus, “The meaning of which is that St. *Thomas* makes a confession, both of his faith and repentance.” I agree with you. But you add, “in St. *Thomas*’s confession there is not implied an assurance of pardon,” you cannot agree with yourself in this; but immediately subjoin, “If it did imply such an assurance, he might well have it, since he had an immediate revelation of it from God himself.”

Yet a little before you endeavoured to prove that one who was not a whit behind the very chief apostles had not such an assurance: where, in order to shew that faith does not imply this, you said, St. *Paul* methinks has fully determined this point (*1 Corinthians iv. 4.*) *I know nothing by myself*, says he, *yet am I not hereby justified.*—“And if an apostle so illuminated, don’t think himself justified”—Then I grant, he has fully determined the point. But before you absolutely fix upon that conclusion, be pleased to remember your own comment that follows, on those other words of St. *Paul*, *the life I now live, I live by faith in the Son of God, who loved me and gave himself for me.* Your words are, “And no question a person indowed with such extraordinary gifts, might arrive at a very eminent degree of assurance.”—So he *did arrive at a very eminent degree of assurance*, tho’ *he did not think himself justified!*

I can scarce think you have read over that chapter to the *Colossians*: else surely you would not assert, that those words on which the stress lies, (*viz. Who hath delivered us from the power of darkness, and hath translated us into the kingdom of his dear Son: In whom we have redemption thro' his blood, even the forgiveness of sins*) do not relate to *Paul* and *Timothy* who wrote the epistle, but to the *Colossians*, to whom they wrote, I need be at no pains to answer this; for presently after your own words are, “he hath made us, meaning the *Colossians*, as well as himself, meet to be inheritors.”——

3. You may easily observe, that I quoted the council of *Trent* by memory, not having the book then by me. I own, and thank you for correcting my mistake: but in correcting one, you make another. For the decrees of the sixth session were not “published on the 13th of *January*,” but the session itself began on that day.

I cannot help reciting your next words, although they are not exactly to the present question.

“The words of the 12th canon of the council of *Trent* are,”

“If any man shall say that justifying faith is nothing else but a confidence in the divine mercy, remitting sins for Christ’s sake, and that this confidence is that alone by which we are justified, let him be accursed.” You add,

“This Sir, I am sure is true doctrine, and perfectly agreeable to the doctrine of our church. And so you are not only anathematized by the council of *Trent*, but also condemned by our own church.”

“Our church holds no such scandalous and disgraceful opinion.”——According to our church, no man can have “the true faith, who has not a loving heart.”——*Therefore* faith is not a confidence that any man’s sins are actually forgiven, and he reconciled to God.” (What have the premisses to do with the conclusion!)

4. To decide this, let our church speak for herself. Whether she does not suppose and teach, that every particular believer knows that his sins are forgiven, and he himself is reconciled to God.

First then, our church supposes and teaches every particular believer, to say concerning himself, “In my baptism *I was made a member of Christ, a child of God, and an inheritor of the kingdom of heaven. And I thank God who hath called me to that state of salvation. And I pray to God that I may continue in the same to my life’s end.*”

Now does this person *know* what he says to be true? If not, it is the grossest hypocrisy. But if he does, then he knows, that *he in particular* is reconciled to God.

The next words I shall quote may be a comment on these: May God write them in our hearts!

“A true christian man is not afraid to die, who is the very member of Christ, the temple of the Holy Ghost, the Son of God, and the very inheritor of the everlasting kingdom of heaven. But plainly contrary, he not only puts away the fear of death, but wishes, desires and longs heartily for it. *Sermon against the fear of death.*” I. part.

Can this be, unless he has a sure confidence that he, in particular, is reconciled to God?

“Men commonly fear death, first because of leaving their worldly goods and pleasures. 2. For fear of the pains of death; and 3. For fear of perpetual damnation. But none of these causes trouble good men, because they stay themselves by true faith, perfect charity, and sure hope of endless joy and bliss everlasting.” *ibid.* II. part.

“All these therefore have great cause to be full of joy, and not to fear death nor everlasting damnation. For death cannot deprive them of Jesus Christ, death cannot take him from us, nor us from him. Death not only cannot harm us, but also shall profit us and join us to God more perfectly. And thereof a christian heart may be surely certified. *It is God*, saith St. Paul, *which hath given us an earnest of his Spirit.* As long as we be in the body, we are in a strange country. But we have a desire rather to be at home with God.” *ibid.*

He that runneth may read in all these words, the confidence which our church supposes, every particular believer to have, that he himself is reconciled to God.

To proceed, “The only instrument of salvation required on our parts is faith, that is, a sure trust and confidence, that God both hath and will forgive our sins, that he hath accepted us again into his favour, for the merits of Christ’s death and passion.” *Second sermon on the passion.*

“But here, we must take heed that we do not halt with God through an unconstant, wavering faith. *Peter* coming to Christ upon the water, because he fainted in faith was in danger of drowning. So we, if we begin to waver or doubt, it is to be feared lest we should sink as *Peter* did: not into the water, but into the bottomless pit of hell-fire. Therefore I say unto you, that we must apprehend the merits of Christ’s death by faith, and that with a strong and stedfast faith; nothing doubting, but that Christ by his own oblation hath taken away our sins, and hath restored us again to God’s favour.” *ibid.*

5. If it be still said, that the church speaks only of men in general, but not of the confidence of this or that particular person: even this last, poor subterfuge, is utterly cut off by the following words:

“*Thou*, O man, hast received the body of Christ which was once broken, and his blood which was shed for the remission of *thy* sin. Thou hast received his body to have within *thee* the Father, the Son, and the Holy Ghost, for to endow *thee* with grace, and to comfort *thee* with their presence. Thou hast received his body, to endow *thee* with everlasting righteousness, and to assure *thee* of everlasting bliss.” *Sermon on the resurrection.*

I shall add but one passage more, from the first part of the sermon on the sacrament.

“Have a sure and constant faith, not only that the death of Christ is available for all the world, but that he hath made a full and sufficient sacrifice for *thee*, a perfect cleansing of *thy* sins, so that thou mayst say with the apostle, *he loved thee* and gave himself for *thee*. For this is to make Christ *thine own*, and to apply his merits unto *thyself*.”

Let every reasonable man now judge for himself, what is the sense of our church as to the *nature of saving faith*. Does it not abundantly appear, that the church of *England* supposes every particular believer, to have a sure confidence, that *his* sins are forgiven, and he *himself* reconciled to God? Yea, and how can the absolute necessity of this faith, this unwavering confidence, be more strongly or peremptorily asserted, than it is in those words: “If we begin to waver or doubt, it is to be feared, lest we sink as *Peter* did: Not into the water; but into the bottomless pit of hell-fire?”

6. I would willingly dismiss this writer here. I had said in *the earnest appeal* (what I am daily more and more confirmed in) that this faith is usually given in a moment. This you greatly dislike. Your argument against it, if put into form, will run thus:

“They who first apprehend the meaning of the words delivered, then gave their assent to them, then had confidence in the promises to which they assented, and lastly, loved God, did not receive faith in a moment.”

But the believers mentioned in *the Acts*, first apprehended the meaning of the words, then gave their assent, then had confidence in the promises, and lastly, loved God: Therefore

“The believers mentioned in *the Acts*, did not receive faith in a moment.”

I deny the major. They might first apprehend, then assent, then confide, then love, and yet receive faith in a moment: In *that* moment, wherein their general confidence became particular, so that each could say, “*My Lord, and my God.*”

One paragraph more I will be at the pains to transcribe. “You insinuate, that the sacraments are only requisite to the well-being of a visible church: Whereas the church declares, that the due administration of them, is an essential *property thereof*. I suppose you hinted this to gratify your loving disciples the Quakers.”

This is flat and plain. Here is a fact positively averred: and a reason also assigned for it. Now do you take yourself to be a man of candor, I had almost said, of common honesty? My very words in the place referred to, are, “A visible church is a company of faithful people. This is the essence of it. And the *properties thereof* are, That the pure word of God be preached therein, and the sacraments duly administered.”

7. Before I take my leave, I cannot but recommend to you that advice of a wise and good man,

“Be calm in arguing; for fierceness makes

Error a fault, and truth discourtesy.”

I am grieved at your extreme warmth: You are in a thorough ill-humour from the very beginning of your book to the end. This cannot hurt *me*. But it may *yourself*. And it does not at all help your cause. If you denounce against me all the curses from *Genesis* to the *Revelation*, they will not amount to one argument. I am willing (so far as I know myself) to be reproved either by you or any other. But whatever you do let it be done in love, in patience, in meekness of wisdom.

V. 1. With regard to the author of faith and salvation, abundance of objections have been made: It being a current opinion, that “Christians are not now to receive the Holy Ghost.”

Accordingly, whenever we speak of the Spirit of God, of his operations on the souls of men, of his *revealing* unto us the things of God, or *inspiring* us with good desires or tempers: whenever we mention the *feeling* his mighty power, *working in us*, according to his good pleasure: The general answer we have to expect is, “This is rank *enthusiasm*. So it was with the apostles and first christians. But only *enthusiasts* pretend to this now.”

Thus all the scriptures, abundance of which might be produced, are set aside at one stroke. And whoever cites them, as *belonging to all Christians*, is set down for an *enthusiast*.

The first tract I have seen, wrote expressly on this head, is remarkably intitled,

“The operations of the Holy Spirit *imperceptible*, and how men may *know*, when they are under the guidance and influence of the Spirit.”

You begin, “As we have some among us who pretend, to a more than ordinary guidance by the Spirit—(indeed I do not: I pretend to no other guidance, than is ordinarily given to all Christians) it may not be improper to discourse, on the operation of God’s Holy Spirit.”——

“To this end be thou pleased, O gracious fountain of truth, to assist me with thy heavenly direction in speaking of thee.”

Alas, Sir, what need have you to speak any more? You have already granted all I desire, viz. That “we may *all now* enjoy, and *know* that we do enjoy, the heavenly direction of God’s Spirit.”

However, you go on, and observe that the *extraordinary gifts* of the Holy Ghost, were granted to the first Christians only, but his *ordinary graces* to all Christians in all ages: Both which you then attempt to enumerate: Only suspending your discourse a little, when “some conceited *enthusiasts*” come in your way.

2. You next enquire, “After what manner these graces are raised in our souls?” And answer, “How to distinguish these heavenly motions, from the natural operations of our minds, we have no light to discover. The scriptures—declaring that the operations of the Holy Spirit, are not subject to any sensible *feelings* or perceptions. For what communication can there be between *feelings*, which are properties peculiar to matter, and the suggestions of the Spirit?—All reasonable Christians believe, that he works his graces in us in an imperceptible manner; and that there is no sensible difference between his and the natural operations of our minds.”

I conceive this to be the strength of your cause. To support that conclusion, that the operations of the Spirit are imperceptible, you here alledge, 1. “That all reasonable Christians believe this.” So you say. But I want proof. 2. “That there can be no communications (I fear, you mistook the word) between the suggestions of the Spirit, and *feelings* which are *properties peculiar to matter*.” How! Are the *feelings* now in question, *properties peculiar to matter*? The *feeling* of peace, joy, love? Or any *feelings* at all? I can no more understand the philosophy than the divinity of this. 3. “That the scriptures declare, the operations of the Spirit are not subject to any *sensible feelings*.” You are here disproving, as you suppose, a proposition of mine. But are you sure you understand it? By *feeling*, I mean, being inwardly conscious of. By *the operations of the Spirit*, I do not mean *the manner* in which he operates, but *the graces* which he operates in a Christian. Now be pleased to produce those Scriptures which declare, “That a Christian cannot *feel* or *perceive these operations*.”

3. Are you not convinced, Sir, that you have laid to my charge things which I know not? I do not gravely tell you (as much an *enthusiast* as you over and over affirm me to be) “That I *sensibly feel* (in *your* sense) the motions of the Holy Spirit.” Much less do I “make this, any more than convulsions, agonies, howlings, roarings, and violent contorsions of the body,” either “Certain signs of mens being in a state of salvation,” or “necessary in order thereunto.” You might with equal justice and truth inform the world, and the worshipful the magistrates of *Newcastle*, that I make *seeing the wind*, or *feeling the light*, necessary to salvation.

Neither do I “confound the *extraordinary* with the *ordinary* operations of the Spirit.” And as to your last enquiry, “What is the best proof of our being led by the Spirit?” I have no exception to that just and scriptural answer, which you yourself have given, “A thorough change and renovation of mind and heart, and the leading a new and holy life.”

4. “That I confound the *extraordinary* with the *ordinary* operations of the Spirit, and therefore am an *enthusiast*,” is also strongly urged, in a charge delivered to his clergy, and lately published by the Lord Bishop of *Litchfield* and *Coventry*.

An extract of the former part of this, I subjoin, in his Lordship’s words.

“I cannot think it improper to obviate the contagion, of those *enthusiastical* pretensions, that have lately betrayed whole multitudes, either into presumption or melancholy. *Enthusiasm* indeed when detected, is apt to create infidelity; and infidelity is so shocking a thing, that many rather run into the other extreme, and take refuge in *enthusiasm*. But infidelity and *enthusiasm* seem now to act in concert against our established religion. As infidelity has been sufficiently opposed, I shall now lay before you the weakness of those *enthusiastical* pretensions.” page 1, 2.

Now to confute effectually, and strike at the root of those *enthusiastical* pretensions,

“First, I shall shew, that it is necessary to lay down some method for distinguishing real from pretended inspiration.” page 3, 5.

“Many expressions occur in the *new Testament*, concerning the operations of the holy Spirit. But men of an *enthusiastical* temper, have confounded passages of a quite different nature, and have jumbled together those that relate to the *extraordinary* operations of the Spirit, with those that relate only to his *ordinary* influences. It is therefore necessary to use some method for separating those passages, relating to the operations of the Spirit, that have been so misapplied to the service of *enthusiastical* pretenders.” Page 5, 6, 7.

“I proceed therefore to shew,

“Secondly, That a distinction is to be made between those passages of scripture about the blessed Spirit that peculiarly belong to the primitive church, and those that relate to Christians in all ages.” Page 7.

“The exigencies of the apostolical age required the *miraculous* gifts of the Spirit. But these soon ceased. When therefore we meet in the scripture with an account of those *extraordinary* gifts, and likewise with an account of his *ordinary* operations, we must distinguish the one from the other. And that not only for our own satisfaction, but as a means to stop the growth of *enthusiasm*.” Page 8, 9, 10.

“And such a distinction ought to be made, by the best methods of interpreting the scriptures: which most certainly are an attentive consideration of the occasion and scope of those passages, in concurrence with the general sense of the primitive church.” page 11.

“I propose, Thirdly, to specify some of the chief passages of scripture, that are misapplied by modern *Enthusiasts*, and to shew that they are to be interpreted *chiefly, if not only*, of the apostolical church; and that they very little, if at all relate, to the present state of Christians.” page 12.

“I begin, says your Lordship, with the original promise of the Spirit, as made by our Lord a little before he left the world.”

I must take the liberty to stop your Lordship on the threshold. I deny this original promise of the Spirit. I expect his assistance, in virtue of many promises, some hundred years prior to this.

If you say, “However this is *the original or first promise of the Spirit*, in the new Testament.” No, my Lord; those words were spoken long before: *he shall baptize you with the Holy Ghost, and with fire.*

Will you reply? “Well, but this is the original promise *made by our Lord*.” I answer, not so neither, for it was before this, Jesus himself *stood and cried, If any man thirst, let him come unto me and drink, he that believeth on me, as the scripture hath said, out of his belly shall flow rivers of living water. And this he spake of the Spirit, which they should receive who believed on him* (♦ οὐ ἔμελλον λαμβάνειν οἱ πιστεύσαντες εἰς αὐτόν). If I mistake not, this may more justly be termed, *our Lord’s original promise of the Spirit*. And who will assert, that this is to be interpreted chiefly, *if not only* of the apostolical church?”

♦ “οὐ ἔμελλον λαμβάνειν οἱ πιστεύοντες εἰς αὐτόν” replaced with “οὐ ἔμελλον λαμβάνειν οἱ πιστεύσαντες εἰς αὐτόν”

6. Your Lordship proceeds: “It occurs in the 14th and 16th chapters of St. *John’s* gospel; in which he uses these words”——in what verses, my Lord? Why is not this specified?¹ Unless to furnish your Lordship with an opportunity of doing the very things whereof you before complained, of “confounding passages of a quite contrary nature, and jumbling together those that relate to the ♦ *extraordinary* operations of the Spirit, with those that relate to his *ordinary* influences?”

¹ I take it for granted, that the citation of texts in the margin, which is totally wrong, is a blunder of the printer’s.

♦ “extraordinary” replaced with “extraordinary”

You cite the words thus; *When the Spirit of truth is come he will guide you into all truth, and he will shew you things to come*. (These are nearly the words that occur, chapter xvi. verse 13.)

“And again, *The Comforter, which is the Holy Ghost, whom the Father will send in my name, he shall teach you all things, and bring all things to your remembrance, whatsoever I have said unto you*. These words occur in the 14th chapter, at the 26th verse.”

But my Lord, I want the original promise still; the original (I mean) of those made in this very discourse. Indeed your margin tells us, where it is, (chapter xiv. verse 16.) but the words appear not. Taken together with the context they run thus:

If ye love me, keep my commandments.

And I will pray the Father, and he will give you another Comforter, that he may abide with you for ever:

Even the Spirit of truth, whom the world cannot receive, because it seeth him not, neither knoweth him. Chapter xiv. verses 15, 16, 17.

My Lord, suffer me to enquire, why you slipt over this text? Was it not (I appeal to the Searcher of your heart!) because you was conscious to yourself, that it would necessarily drive you to that unhappy dilemma, either to assert that *for ever*, εἰς τὸν αἰῶνα, meant only sixty or seventy years; or to allow, that the text must be interpreted of the *ordinary* operations of the Spirit, in all future ages of the church.

And indeed that the promise in this text belongs to all Christians, evidently appears, not only from your Lordship's own concession, and from the text itself, (for who can deny, that this Comforter or paraclete is now given to all them that believe?) but also from the preceding, as well as following, words. The preceding are, *If ye love me, keep my commandments. And I will pray the Father*—none surely can doubt, but these belong to all Christians in all ages. The following words are, *Even the Spirit of truth, whom the world cannot receive.* True; the *world* cannot; but *all Christians* can, and will receive him *for ever*.

6. The second promise of the Comforter, made in this chapter, together with its context, stands thus:

Judas saith unto him (not Iscariot) Lord, how is it that thou wilt manifest thyself unto us, and not unto the world? Verse 22.

Jesus answered and said unto him, if any man love me, he will keep my word. And my Father will love him, and we will come unto him, and make our abode with him. Verse 23.

He that loveth me not, keepeth not my word: and the word which ye hear is not mine, but the Father's which sent me. Verse 24.

These things have I spoken unto you, being yet with you. Verse 25.

But the Comforter, which is the Holy Ghost, whom the Father will send in my name, he will teach you all things, and bring all things to your remembrance, whatsoever I have said unto you. Verse 26.

Now, How does your Lordship prove that this promise belongs only to the primitive church? Why, 1. You say, "It is very clear from the bare recital of the words." I apprehend not. But this is the very question, which is not to be begged, but proved. 2. You say, "*The Spirit's bringing all things to their remembrance, whatsoever he had said unto them*," cannot possibly be applied to any other persons but the apostles." "Cannot be applied!" This is a flat begging the question again, which I cannot give up without better reasons. 3. "The gifts of *prophecy* and of being *guided into all truth, and taught all things*, can be applied only to the apostles, and those of that age who were immediately inspired." Here your Lordship, in order the more plausibly to beg the question again, "Jumbles together the *extraordinary* with the *ordinary* operations of the Spirit." The gift of *prophecy*, we know, is one of his *extraordinary* operations; but there is not a word of it in this text: nor, therefore ought it to be "confounded with his *ordinary* operations," such as the being *guided into all truth*, (all that is necessary to salvation) and *taught all (necessary) things*, in a due use of the *means* he hath ordained. Verse 26.

In the same manner, namely, in a serious and constant use of proper *means*, I believe the assistance of the Holy Ghost is given to all Christians, to *bring all things needful to their remembrance, whatsoever Christ hath spoken to them* in his word. So that I see no occasion to grant, without some kind of proof, (especially considering the occasion of this, and the scope of the preceding verses) that even "this promise cannot possibly be applied to any other persons but the apostles."

7. In the same discourse of our Lord we have a third promise of the Comforter, the whole clause runs thus:

If I go not away, the Comforter will not come unto you; but if I go, I will send him unto you. Chapter xvi. verse 7.

And when he is come, he will reprove (or convince) the world of sin, and of righteousness, and of judgment. Verse 8.

Of sin, because they believe not on me;

Of righteousness, because I go to my Father, and ye see me no more:

Of judgment, because the prince of this world is judged; verses 9, 10, 11.

I have yet many things to say unto you; but ye cannot bear them now: (Verse 12.) but when he shall come, the Spirit of truth, he will guide you into all truth—And he will shew you things to come. Verse 13.

There is only one sentence here which has not already been considered, *He will shew you things to come.*

And this, it is granted, relates to the gift of *prophecy*, one of the *extraordinary* operations of the Spirit.

The general conclusion which your Lordship draws, is exprest in these words. “Consequently all pretensions to the Spirit, in the proper sense of the words of this promise (*i. e.* of these several texts of *St. John*) are vain and insignificant, as they are claimed by modern *Enthusiasts*.” And in the end of the same paragraph you add, “None but the *ordinary* operations of the Spirit are to be now expected, since those that are of a *miraculous* (or *extraordinary*) kind are NOT PRETENDED TO, even by modern *Enthusiasts*.”

My Lord, this is surprizing. I read it over and over, before I could credit my own eyes. I verily believe this one clause, with unprejudiced persons, will be an answer to the whole book. You have been vehemently crying out all along against those *enthusiastical* pretenders; nay, the very design of your book, as you openly declare, “was to stop the growth of their *Enthusiasm*; who have had the assurance (as you positively affirm, page 6,) to claim to themselves the *extraordinary* operations of the Holy Spirit.” And here you as positively affirm, that those *extraordinary* operations “are not pretended to by them at all!”

8. Yet your Lordship proceeds, “The next passage of scripture, I shall mention as peculiarly belonging to the primitive times, though misapplied to the present state of Christians by modern *Enthusiasts*, is what relates to the *testimony of the Spirit*, and *praying by the Spirit*, in the 8th chapter of the epistle to the *Romans*.” Page 16.

I believe it incumbent upon me thoroughly to weigh the force of your Lordship’s reasoning on this head. You begin, “After St. *Paul* had treated of that spiritual principle in Christians, which enables them *to mortify the deeds of the body*—he says, *if any man have not the Spirit of Christ, he is none of his*. This makes the distinction of a true Christian, particularly in opposition to the *Jews*.” I apprehend it is just here, that ♦ your Lordship turns out of the way, when you say, “particularly in opposition to the *Jews*.” Such a *particular* opposition I cannot allow, till some stronger proof is produced, than St. *Paul*’s occasionally mentioning six verses before, “the imperfection of the *Jewish* law.”

♦ “you” replaced with “your”

Yet your Lordship's mind is so full of this, that after repeating the 14th and 15th verses (*as many as are led by the Spirit of God, they are the sons of God: for ye have not received the Spirit of bondage again to fear: but ye have received the Spirit of adoption, whereby we cry, Abba, Father!*) you add, "in the former part of this verse, the apostle shews again the imperfection of the *Jewish* law." This also calls for proof: otherwise, it will not be allowed, that he here speaks of the *Jewish* law at all: not, tho' we grant that "the *Jews* were subject to the *fear* of death, and lived in consequence of it, in a state of *bondage*." For are not all unbelievers, as ◆well as the *Jews*, more or less, in the same *fear* and *bondage*?

◆ "will" replaced with "well"

Your Lordship goes on, "In the latter part of the verse he shews the superiority of the *Christian* law to that of the *Jews*." Page 18. Where is the proof, my Lord? How does it appear, that he is speaking either of the *Christian* or *Jewish* law, in those words, *Ye have received the Spirit of adoption, whereby we cry, Abba, Father?* However you infer, "*Christians* then are the adopted sons of God, in contradistinction to the *Jews*, as the former had the gifts of the Holy Ghost, which none of the latter had at that time: and *the body of the Jews* never had." No, nor *the body of the Christians* neither. So that if this be a ◆proof against the *Jews*, it is the very same against the *Christians*.

◆ "poof" replaced with "proof"

I must observe farther on the preceding words, 1. That your Lordship begins here, to take the word *Christians* in a new and peculiar sense, for the whole body of the then Christian Church: 2. That it is a bad inference, "as, or because they had the gifts of the Holy Ghost, therefore they were the sons of God." On the one hand, if they were the children of God, it was not, because they had gifts. On the other, a man may have all those gifts, and yet be a child of the devil.

9. I conceive, not only that your Lordship has *proved* nothing hitherto, not one point that has any relation to the question: but that, strictly speaking, you have not *attempted to prove* any thing, having *taken for granted* whatever came in your way. In the same manner you proceed, “The apostle goes on, *The Spirit itself beareth witness with our spirit, that we are the children of God*. This passage, as it is connected with the preceding one, relates to the general adoption of Christians, or their becoming the sons of God instead of the *Jews*.”—“This passage relates”—How is that proved? By its connexion with the preceding? In no wise, unless it be good arguing to prove *Ignotum per ignotius*. It has not yet been proved, that the preceeding passage itself has any relation to this matter.

Your Lordship adds, “But what was the ground of this preference that was given to Christians? It was plainly the (miraculous) *gifts of the Spirit*, which they had, and which the *Jews* had not.” *This preference given to Christians*, was just before exprest by their *becoming the sons of God instead of the Jews*. Were the gifts of the Spirit then *the ground of this preference*? The ground of their becoming the sons of God? What an assertion is this! And how little is it mended, though I allow, that “these miraculous gifts of the Spirit, were a testimony that God acknowledged the *Christians* to be his people and not the *Jews*: (since the *Christians* who worked miracles, did it not *by the works of the law*, but by *the hearing of faith*?”))

Your Lordship concludes, “From these passages of St. *Paul*, compared together, it clearly follows, that the fore-mentioned *testimony of the Spirit*, was the *public testimony* of miraculous gifts—and, consequently, *the witness of the Spirit that we are the children of God*, cannot possibly be applied, to the *private testimony* of the Spirit given to our own consciences, as is pretended by modern *enthusiasts*.” Page 20.

If your conclusion, my Lord, will stand without the premisses it may: but that it has no manner of connection with them, I trust does partly, and will more fully appear, when we view the whole passage to which you refer. And I believe that passage, with very little comment, will prove, in direct opposition to that conclusion, that the testimony of the Spirit there mentioned, is not the *public testimony* of miraculous gifts, but must be applied to the *private testimony* of the Spirit, given to our own consciences.

10. St. Paul begins the 8th chapter of his Epistle to the *Romans*, with the great privilege of every Christian believer, (whether *Jew* or *Gentile* before) *There is now no condemnation for them that are in Christ Jesus, engrafted into him by faith, who walk not after the flesh, but after the Spirit. For now every one of them may truly say, The law (or power) of the Spirit of life in Christ Jesus (given unto me for his sake) hath made me free from the law (or power) of sin and death. For that which the law could not do, in that it was weak through the flesh, God sending his own Son, in the likeness of sinful flesh, and for sin, did; when he condemned, (crucified, put to death, destroyed) sin in the flesh: that the righteousness of the law might be fulfilled in us, who walk not after the flesh, but after the Spirit. For they that are after the flesh, mind the things of the flesh; but they that are after the Spirit, the things of the Spirit.* Verse 1–5.

Is it not evident, that the apostle is here describing a true Christian, a holy believer? In opposition, not particularly to a *Jew*, much less to the *Jewish law*, but to every unholy man, to all, whether *Jews* or *Gentiles*, *who walk after the flesh*? He goes on

For, to be carnally-minded is death; but to be spiritually-minded is life and peace. Because the carnal mind is enmity against God: for it is not subject to the law of God; neither indeed can be. So then they that are in the flesh, cannot please God. Verses 6, 7, 8.

The opposition between a holy and unholy man, is still glaring and undeniable. But can any man discern, the least glimmering of opposition, between the *Christian* and the *Jewish Law*.

The apostle goes on, *But ye are not in the flesh, but in the Spirit, if so be that the Spirit of God dwell in you. Now if any man have not the Spirit of Christ, he is none of his. But if Christ be in you, the body is dead, because of sin, but the spirit is life because of righteousness. But if the Spirit of him that raised up Jesus from the dead dwell in you, he that raised up Christ from the dead shall also quicken your mortal bodies by his Spirit which dwelleth in you. Therefore, brethren, we are debtors, not to the flesh, to live after the flesh. For if ye live after the flesh ye shall die; but if ye, through the Spirit, do mortify the deeds of the body, ye shall live. For as many as are led by the Spirit of God, they are the sons of God.* Verse 9–14.

Is there one word here, is there any the least intimation of *miraculous* gifts, or of the *Jewish law*?

It follows, *For ye have not received the spirit of bondage again, to fear* (such as all sinners have, when they at first stirred up to seek God, and begin to serve him from a slavish fear of punishment) *But ye have received the spirit of adoption* (of free love) *whereby we cry, Abba, Father. The Spirit itself* (which God hath sent forth into our hearts, crying, *Abba, Father,*) *beareth witness with our spirit, that we are the children of God.* Verse 15, 16.

I am now willing to leave it, without farther comment, to the judgment of every impartial reader, whether it does not appear from the whole scope and tenor of the text and context taken together, that this passage does not refer to the *Jewish law*, nor to the *public testimony of miracles*: neither of which can be dragged in, without putting the utmost force on the natural meaning of the words. And if so, it will follow, that this *witness of the Spirit* is *the private testimony given to our own consciences*: which, consequently, all sober Christians may claim, without any danger of *enthusiasm*.

11. “But I go on (says your Lordship, page 21.) to the consideration of the other passages in the same chapter, relating to our *praying by the Spirit*, namely at verse 26 and 27, which runs thus, *Likewise the Spirit also helpeth our infirmities: for we know not what we should pray for as we ought; but the Spirit itself maketh intercession for us, with groanings which cannot be uttered. And he that searcheth the hearts, knoweth what is the mind of the spirit, because he maketh intercession for the saints, according to the will of God.*”

Here is a circumstance highly needful to be observed, before we enter upon this question. Your Lordship undertakes to fix the meaning of an expression used by St. *Paul*, in the 14th chapter of his first epistle to the *Corinthians*. And in order thereto, you laboriously explain part of the 8th chapter of the *Romans*. My Lord, how is this? Will it be said, Why *this* is often alledged to prove the wrong sense of *that* scripture? I conceive, this will not salve the matter at all. Your Lordship had before laid down a particular method, as the only sure one whereby to distinguish what scriptures belong to all Christians, and what do not. This method is, the considering the occasion and scope of those passages, by comparing the text and context together. You then propose, by the use of this method, to shew, that several texts have been misapplied by *Enthusiasts*. One of these is the 15th verse of the 14th chapter of the first epistle to the *Corinthians*. And to shew, that *Enthusiasts* have misapplied this, you comment on the 8th chapter to the *Romans*!

However, let us weigh the comment itself. The material part of it begins thus: (page 22.) “Now he adds another proof of the truth of Christianity: *Likewise the Spirit helpeth our infirmities* (or our *distresses*, for ♦ἀσθενείας signifies both.” I doubt that: I require authority for it.) “And then he mentions, in what instances he does so, viz. In *prayers* to God about afflictions”—(In nothing else, my Lord? Did he *help their infirmities*, in no other instance than this?) “*We know not*, says he, *what we should pray for as we ought*. That is, whether it be best for us to bear afflictions, or to be delivered from them. But *the Spirit*, OR the gift of the Spirit, instructs us how to *pray* in a manner agreeable to the will of God.” *The Spirit*, OR the gift of the Spirit! What marvellous reasoning is this? If these “are often put for each other,” what then? How is that evinced to be the case here?

♦ “ἀθeneίας” replaced with “ἀσθeneίας”

12. “The apostle goes on, *The Spirit itself* (page 23) *maketh intercession for us, with groanings which cannot be uttered*: That is, the *spiritual* or *inspired person* prayed in that capacity for the whole assembly.” “That is!” Nay, that is again the very point to be proved, else we get not one step farther.

“The apostle goes on thus, verse 27. *And he that* (page 24) *searcheth the hearts, knoweth what is the mind of the spirit*, (that is, of the *spiritual* or *inspired person*) *because he maketh intercession for the saints, according to the will of God*. That is, God knows the intention of the *spiritual* person, who has the *gift of prayer*, which he uses for the benefit of the whole assembly; he, I say, leaves it entirely to God, whether it be best that they should suffer afflictions, or be delivered from them.” Page 25.

My Lord, this is more astonishing than all the rest! I was expecting all along in reading the preceding pages (and so I suppose, was every thinking reader) when your Lordship would mention, that the person *miraculously inspired* for that intent, and praying κατὰ Θεὸν either for the support or deliverance of the people, should *have the very petition which he asked of him*. Whereas you intended no such thing! But shut up the whole with that lame and impotent conclusion, “He leaves it to God, whether it be best they should suffer afflictions, or be delivered from them.”

Had he then that *miraculous* gift of God, that he might do what any common Christian might have done without it? Why, any person in the congregation might have prayed thus: nay, could not pray otherwise, if he had the *ordinary* grace of God: “Leaving it to God, whether he should suffer afflictions still, or be delivered from them.” Was it *only* in the apostolical age, that “the Spirit instructed Christians *thus* to pray?” Cannot a man pray *thus*, either for himself or others, unless he has the *miraculous* gift of prayer!—So, according to your Lordship’s judgment, “To pray in such a manner, as in the event to leave the continuance of our sufferings, or our deliverance from them, with a due submission, to the good pleasure of God,” is one of those “*extraordinary* operations of the Spirit,” which none now pretend to but “modern *enthusiasts*!”

I beseech your Lordship to consider. Can you coolly maintain, that “the praying with a due submission to the will of God,” even in heavy affliction, is a *miraculous gift*? An *extraordinary operation* of the Holy Ghost? Is *this* peculiar to the primitive times? Is it what *none* but *enthusiasts* now pretend to? If not, then your Lordship’s own account of *praying by the Spirit* indisputably proves, that this is one of the *ordinary* privileges of all Christians, to the end of the world.

13. “I go on (your Lordship adds) to another passage of scripture, that has been entirely (page 27.) misapplied by modern *enthusiasts*. 1 Corinthians ii. 4, 5. *And my speech and my preaching were not with enticing words of man’s wisdom, but in the demonstration of the spirit and of power; that your faith should not stand in the wisdom of man, but in the power of God.*” Page 29.

“It is only necessary to evince, that by *the demonstration of the spirit and power* is meant the demonstration of the truth of Christianity, that arises from the prophecies of the *Old Testament*, and the *miracles* of *Christ* and his *apostles*.” Yes, it is necessary farther to evince, that these words have *no other* meaning. But first, How will you evince, that they bear this? In order thereto, your Lordship argues thus:

“The former *seems to be* the demonstration of the Spirit, with regard to the prophetical testimonies of him.—And *the demonstration of power, must signify* the power of God, exerted in miracles.” (page 30.) “Must;” Why so? That δύναμις often signifies *miraculous power*, is allowed—But what follows? That it *must mean* so in this place? That still remains to be proved.

Indeed your Lordship says, this “appears from the following verse, in which is assigned the reason for using this method of proving Christianity to be true, viz. *That your faith should not stand in the wisdom of man, but in the power of God*. By the power of God therefore must necessarily be understood, the miracles performed by Christ and his apostles.” By the illative particle, *therefore*, this proposition should be an inference from some other: but what other I cannot yet discern. So that, for the present, I can only look upon it, as a fresh instance of begging the question.

“He goes on in the 7th, 10th and following verses, to explain this *demonstration of the spirit and of power*.” But he does not say one syllable therein, either of the *ancient prophecies*, or of *miracles*. Nor will it be easily proved, that he speaks either of one or the other, from the beginning of the chapter to the end.

After transcribing the 13th verse, *which things also we speak, not in the words which man’s wisdom teacheth, but which the Holy Ghost teacheth, comparing spiritual things with spiritual*, your Lordship adds, “From which last passage it appears, that the words which the Holy Ghost is said *to teach, must be* the prophetical revelations of the *Old Testament*, which were discovered to the apostles by the same Spirit.” I cannot apprehend, how this appears. I cannot as yet see any connection at all between the premisses and the conclusion.

Upon the whole, I desire any calm and serious man, to read over this whole chapter; and then he will easily judge, what is the natural meaning of the words in question: and whether (although it be allowed, that they were *peculiarly* fulfilled in the apostles, yet) they do not manifestly belong, *in a lower sense*, to every true minister of Christ? For what can be more undeniable than this, that *our* preaching also is vain, unless it be attended with *the power* of that Spirit, who alone pierceth the heart? And that your hearing is vain, unless the same *power be present to heal* your soul, and to give you a faith which *standeth not in the wisdom of man, but in the power of God*?

14. “Another passage that (your Lordship thinks) has been misapplied by *enthusiasts*, but was really peculiar to the times of the apostles, is 1 John ii. 20. and 27. (page 35.) *Ye have an unction from the Holy One, and ye know all things.—But the anointing which ye have received of him abideth in you: And ye need not that any man teach you, but as the same anointing teacheth you of all things, and is truth, and is no lie. And even as it hath taught you, ye shall abide in him.*” “Here the apostle arms the true Christians ♦ against seducers, by an argument drawn from *the unction from the Holy One*, that was *in* or rather *among* them: that is, from the *immediate inspiration* of some of their teachers.” page 37.

♦ “again” replaced with “against”

Here it rests upon your lordship, to prove (as well as affirm) 1. That *év* should be translated *among*: 2. That this *unction from the Holy One* means, “The inspiration of some of their teachers.”

The latter your lordship attempts to prove thus: “The inspired teachers of old were set apart for that office, by an extraordinary effusion of the Holy Ghost: Therefore page 38. ♦ *The unction from the Holy One* here, means such an effusion.” I deny the consequence; so the question is still to be proved.

♦ Printer incorrectly started a new paragraph here.

Your lordship's second argument is drawn from the 26th verse of the 14th chapter of St. *John's* gospel,

Proposed in form, it will stand thus:

"If those words, *He shall teach you all things*, relate only to a *miraculous* gift of the Holy Ghost, then these words, *The same anointing teacheth you of all things*, relate to the *miraculous* gift:

"But those words relate only to a *miraculous* gift:

"Therefore these relate to the same."

I conceive, it will not be very easy to make good the consequence in the first proposition. But I deny the minor also: the contradictory whereto, I trust, has appeared to be true.

I grant indeed, that these words were more *eminently* fulfilled, in the age of the apostles. But this is altogether consistent with their belonging *in a lower sense*, to all Christians in all ages: Seeing they have all need of *an unction from the Holy One*, a supernatural assistance from the Holy Ghost, that they may know in the due use of all proper means, *all things* needful for their souls health. Therefore it is no *enthusiasm*, to teach that *the unction from the Holy One*, belongs to all Christians in all ages.

15. There is one topic of your lordship's yet untouched; that is authority: One you have very frequently made use of, and wherein, probably, the generality of readers suppose your lordship's great strength lies. And indeed when your lordship first mentioned, (page 11.) "The general sense of the primitive church," I presumed you would have produced so numerous authorities, that I should not easily be able to consult them all. But I soon found my mistake; your lordship naming only *Chrysostom, Jerome, Origen, and Athanasius*.

However, though these four can no more be termed the primitive church, than the church universal, yet I consent to abide by their suffrage. Nay, I will go a step farther still. If any two of these affirm, that those seven texts belong *only to the apostolical age*, and *not to the Christians of succeeding times*, I will give up the whole cause.

But let it be observed: If they should affirm, that these *primarily* belong to the [♦](#)*Christians of the apostolical age*, that does not prove the point, because they may in a secondary sense belong to *others* notwithstanding: Nor does any of them speak home to the question, unless he maintain in express terms, that these texts refer *only* to the *miraculous* gifts of the Spirit, and *not at all* to the state of *ordinary* Christians.

[♦](#) “Christans” replaced with “Christians”

16. Concerning those three texts, *John xiv. verse 16.* and the 26. and *John xvi. verse 13.* “I could easily add (says your lordship,^{[1](#)}) the authorities of *Chrysostom* and the other antient commentators.” St. *Chrysostom*’s authority I will consider now, and that of the others, when they are produced.

^{[1](#)} Page 15.

It is granted, that he interprets not only *John xvi. 13.* but also both the passages in the 14th chapter, as primarily belonging to the apostles. Yet part of his comment on the 26th verse, is as follows.

“Such is that grace (of *the Comforter*) that if it finds sadness it takes it away; if evil desire, it consumes it. It casts out fear, and suffers him that receives it to be a man no longer, but translates him, as it were, into heaven. Hence *none of them counted any thing his own*, but *continued in prayer, with gladness and singleness of heart*. For this *chiefly* is there need of the Holy Ghost. For the fruit of the Spirit is joy, peace, faith, meekness. Indeed spiritual men often grieve; but that grief is sweeter than joy. For whatever is of the Spirit, is the greatest gain, as whatever is of the world, is the greatest loss. Let us therefore in keeping the commandments” (according to our Lord’s exhortation, verse 15.) “secure the unconquerable assistance of the Spirit, and we shall be nothing inferior to angels.”

St. *Chrysostom* here, after he had shewn, that the promise of the Comforter primarily belonged to the apostles: And who ever questioned it? undeniably teaches, That in a secondary sense, it belongs to all Christians: To all *spiritual men*, all who *keep the commandments*. I appeal therefore to all mankind, whether his authority, touching the promise of our Lord in those texts, does not overthrow the proposition it was cited to prove?

Although your lordship names no other author here, yet page 42. you say, “The assigned sense of these passages was confirmed by the authority of *Origen*.” It is needful therefore to add, what occurs in his works, with regard to the present question.

He occasionally mentions this promise of our Lord, in four several places. But it is in one only that he speaks pertinently to the point in hand, (Volume II. page 403. Edition Benedictine.) where his words are these:

When the Spirit of truth is come, he will guide you into all truth, and he will teach you all things. “The sum of all good things consists in this, that a man be found worthy to receive the grace of the Holy Ghost. Otherwise, nothing will be accounted perfect in him, who hath not the Holy Spirit.”

Do these words confirm that “sense of those passages that your lordship had assigned?” Rather do they not utterly overturn it? And prove, (as above) that although this promise of our Lord, *primarily* belongs to the apostles, yet in the *secondary* sense, it belongs (according to *Origen*’s judgment) to all Christians in all ages?

17. The fourth text mentioned as belonging to the first Christians only, is *Romans viii. 15, 16*: and page 26. it is said, “This interpretation is confirmed by the authority of the most eminent fathers.” The reader is particularly referred to *Origen* and *Jerom in locum*. But here seems to be a mistake of the name. *Jerom in locum* should mean, *Jerom* upon the place, upon *Romans viii. 15, 16*. But I cannot perceive that there is one word upon that place, in all St. *Jerom*’s works.

Nor indeed has *Origen* commented upon it any more than *Jerom*. But he occasionally mentions it in these words:

“He is a babe who is fed with milk—but if he seeks the things that are above—without doubt he will be of the number of those, who *receive not the Spirit of bondage again unto fear, but the spirit of adoption*, through whom they cry, *Abba Father*.” Volume I. page 79.

Again, “The fulness of time is come—when they who are willing, receive the adoption, as *Paul* teaches in these words, *Ye have not received the Spirit of bondage again unto fear; but ye have received the Spirit of adoption, whereby we cry, Abba, Father!* And it is written in the gospel according to St. *John*, *To as many as received him, to them gave he power to become the sons of God, even to them that believe in his name.*” Volume I. page 231, 232.

Yet again, “Every one that is born of God, and doth not commit sin, by his very actions saith, Our Father which art in heaven, *the Spirit itself bearing witness with their spirit, that they are the children of God.*” *ibid*.

According to *Origen* therefore, this *testimony of the Spirit*, is not any *publick* testimony by *miracles*, peculiar to the first times, but an *inward* testimony, belonging in common to all that are *born of God*. And consequently the authority of *Origen* does not “confirm that interpretation” neither; but absolutely destroys it.

18. The last authority your Lordship appeals to on this text is, “that of the great *John Chrysostom*, who reckons the *testimony of the spirit* of adoption by which we cry *Abba, Father!* among the *miraculous* gifts of the Spirit.” “I rather chuse (your Lordship adds, page 26.) to refer you to the words of St. *Chrysostom*, than to transcribe them here, as having almost translated them in the present account of the *testimony of the Spirit*.”

However, I believe it will not be labour lost to transcribe a few of those words.

It is his comment on the 14th verse, that he first mentions, St. *Paul*’s comparison between a *Jew* and a *Christian*. How fairly your Lordship has represented this, let every reader judge.

As many as are led by the Spirit of God, they are the sons of God.—“Whereas the same title had been given of old to the *Jews* also,—he shews in the sequel, how great a difference there is, between that honour and this. For though, says he, the titles are the same, yet the things are not. And he plainly proves it, by comparing both what they had received, and what they looked for. And first he shews what they had received, viz. *A Spirit of bondage*. Therefore he adds, *Ye have not received the Spirit of bondage again unto fear: but ye have received the Spirit of adoption*. What means *the spirit of fear*?—*Observe their whole life, and you will know clearly. For punishments were at their heels, and much fear was on every side, and before their face.—But with us it is not so. For our mind and conscience are cleansed, so that we do all things well, not for fear of present punishment, but through our love of God, and an habit of virtue. They therefore, though they were called sons, yet were as slaves; but we, being made free, have received the adoption, and look not for a land of milk and honey, but for heaven.”

*“He brings also another proof, that *we have the Spirit of adoption, by which*, says he, *we cry, Abba, Father*.—This is the first word we utter μετὰ τὰς θαυμαστάς ὠδῖνας ἐκείνας, καὶ τὸν ξένον παράδοξον λοχευμάτων νόμον: after those amazing throes (or birth-pangs) and that strange and wonderful manner of bringing forth.”

“He brings yet another proof of the superiority of those who had *this Spirit of adoption. The Spirit itself beareth witness with our spirit that we are the children of God.* I prove this, says he, not only from the voice itself, but also from the cause whence that voice proceeds. For the Spirit suggests the words while we thus speak, which he hath elsewhere exprest more plainly, *God hath sent forth the Spirit of his Son into our hearts, crying, Abba, Father!* But what is, *The Spirit beareth witness with our spirit?* He means, the paraclete by the gift given unto us.” (But that this was an *extraordinary* gift, we have no intimation at all, neither before nor after) **“And when the Spirit beareth witness, what doubt is left? If a man or an angel spake, some might doubt. But when the Most High beareth witness to us, who can doubt any longer?”*

Now let any reasonable man judge how far your Lordship has “translated the words of St. *Chrysostom*? And whether he reckons the testimony of the Spirit among the *miraculous* gifts of the Holy Ghost?” Or among those *ordinary* gifts of the Spirit of Christ, which if a man have not, he is none of his?

19. The fifth text your Lordship quotes, as describing a *miraculous* gift of the Spirit, is *1 Corinthians xiv. 15.* To prove which, you comment on the 8th chapter to the *Romans*, particularly the 26th verse: and here again it is said, “That the interpretation assigned, is confirmed by several of the most eminent fathers, more especially the great *John Chrysostom*, as well as by *Origen* and *Jerome upon the place.*”

I cannot find St. *Jerome* to have writ one line *upon the place.* And it is obvious, that St. *Chrysostom* supposes, the whole context from the 17th to the 25th verse, to relate to all Christians in all ages. How this can be said to “confirm the interpretation assigned,” I cannot conjecture. Nay, it is remarkable, that he expounds the former part of the 26th verse, as describing the *ordinary* privilege of all Christians. Thus far, therefore, he does not confirm, but overthrow “the interpretation before assigned.” But in the middle of the verse he breaks off, and expounds the latter part, as describing one of the *miraculous* gifts.

Yet I must do the justice to this venerable man to observe, he does not suppose that a *miraculous* gift was given, only that the inspired might do what any *ordinary* Christian might have done without it. (This interpretation, even of the latter part of the verse, he does in no wise confirm.) But that he might ask in every particular circumstance, the determinate thing which it was the will of God to give.

20. The third father by whom it is said this interpretation is confirmed is *Origen*. The first passage of his, which relates to *Romans viii. 26.* runs thus: (volume I. page 199.)

“*Paul* perceiving how far he was, after all these things, from knowing to pray for what he ought, as he ought,” says, *We know not what we should pray for as we ought.* But he adds, whence, what is wanting may be had by one who indeed does not know, but labours to be found worthy of having the defect supplied. For he says *Likewise the Spirit also helpeth our infirmities. “For we know not what we should pray for as we ought. But the Spirit itself maketh intercession for us, with groanings which cannot be uttered. And he that searcheth the hearts knoweth what is the mind of the spirit; because he maketh intercession for the saints, according to the will of God.* The Spirit which crieth *Abba, Father,* in the hearts of the saints, knowing well our groanings in this tabernacle, *maketh intercession for us to God, with groanings which cannot be uttered.* To the same effect is that scripture, *1 Corinthians xiv. 15. I will pray with the Spirit, I will pray with the understanding also.* For our understanding (or mind ♦ὁ νοῦς) cannot pray, if the Spirit do not pray before it, and the understanding, as it were, listen to it.”

♦ “ὁ νοῦς” replaced with “ὁ νοῦς”

*Again (Volume II. page 146.) “I would know, how the saints cry to God without a voice. The apostle shews, God *hath sent forth the Spirit of his son into our hearts, crying, Abba, Father!* And he adds, *the Spirit itself maketh intercession for us, with groanings which cannot be uttered.* And again, *he that searcheth the hearts, knoweth what is the mind of the spirit, because he maketh intercession for the saints, according to the will of God.* Thus therefore, the Spirit making intercession for us with God, the cry of the saints is heard without a voice.”

Once more in his Homily on *Joshua*, (volume II. page 419.)

“Jesus, our Lord, doth not forsake us; but although when we would pray, we *know not what to pray for as we ought*, yet *the Spirit itself maketh intercession for us with groanings which cannot be uttered.* Now the Lord is that Spirit: The Spirit assists our prayers, and offers them to God with groanings which we cannot express in words.”

I believe all rational men will observe from hence, that *Origen* is so far from confirming, that he quite overturns your Lordship’s interpretation of the 16th as well as the 26th verse of this chapter: seeing, in his judgment, both *that testimony of the spirit and this prayer* belong to all Christians in all ages.

21. The sixth scripture which your Lordship has undertaken to shew, “relates only to the apostolical times,” is *1 Corinthians ii. 4, 5.* And “this interpretation also, (it is said) is confirmed by the authority of *Chrysostom, Origen*, and other ancient writers.” (page 33) With those other “antient writers” I have no concern yet. St. *Chrysostom* so far confirms this interpretation, as to explain that whole phrase *the demonstration of the spirit and of power*, of “the power of the Spirit shewn by miracles.” But he says not one word, of any “proof of the Christian religion, arising from the types and prophecies of the old Testament.”

Origen has these words (Volume I. page 321.)

“Our word has a certain peculiar demonstration, more divine than the Grecian, logical demonstration. This the apostle terms, *The demonstration of the Spirit and of power*: of the Spirit because of the prophecies, sufficient to convince any one, especially of the things that relate to Christ; of power, because of the miraculous powers, some footsteps of which still remain.”

Hence we may doubtless infer, ◆that *Origen* judged this text to relate, in its *primary* sense to the apostles: but can we thence infer, that he did not judge it to belong, *in a lower sense*, to all true ministers of Christ?

◆ “thas” replaced with “that”

Let us hear him speaking for himself in the same treatise (page 377.)

“*And my speech and my preaching were not with enticing words of man’s wisdom, but in demonstration of the Spirit and of power: that your faith should not stand in the wisdom of men, but in the power of God.*” *Those who hear the word preached *with power*, are themselves filled *with power*,” (N. B. Not the power of working miracles) which they *demonstrate* both in their disposition, and in their life, and in their striving for the truth unto death. But some although they profess to believe, have not this *power* of God in them, but are empty thereof.”

(Did *Origen* then believe, that *the power* mentioned in this text, belonged *only* to the apostolical age?)

“See the force of the word, conquering believers by a persuasiveness attended with the power of God! I speak this to shew the meaning of him that said, *And my speech and my preaching were not with the enticing words of man’s wisdom, but in demonstration of the Spirit and of power; that your faith should not stand in the wisdom of men, but in the power of God.* This divine saying means, that what is spoken is not sufficient of itself (although it be true and most worthy to be believed) to pierce a man’s soul, if there be not also a certain *power from God* given to the speaker, and grace bloom upon what is spoken, and this grace cannot be but from God.”

After observing, that this is the very passage which your Lordship mentions at the close of the other (but does not cite) I desire every unprejudiced person to judge, whether *Origen* does not clearly determine, that *the power*, spoken of in this text, is in some measure given to all true ministers in all ages?

22. The last scripture which your Lordship affirms “to be peculiar to the times of the apostles,” is that in the first epistle of St. *John*, concerning *the unction of the Holy One*.

To confirm this interpretation, we are referred to the authority of *Origen* and *Chrysostom*, on the parallel passages in St. *John*’s gospel,” (page 42.)

But it has appeared, that both these fathers suppose those passages to belong to all Christians. And consequently their authority (if these are parallel passages) stands full against this interpretation.

Your Lordship subjoins, “I shall here only add that of the great *Athanasius*, who (in his epistle to *Serapion*) interprets *The unction from the Holy One*, not *merely* of divine grace, but of the *extraordinary* gifts of the Holy Spirit.”

Nay, it is enough, if he interprets it *at all* of *ordinary grace*, such as is common to all Christians.

And this your Lordship allows he does. But I cannot allow that he interprets it of any thing else. I cannot perceive, that he interprets it *at all*, “of the *extraordinary* gifts of the Holy Spirit.”

His words are, “The Holy Spirit is called, and is, the unction and the seal. For *John* writes, *The anointing which ye have received of him, abideth in you; and ye need not that any man should teach you, but as his anointing, his Spirit, teacheth you of all things.* Again, it is written in the prophet *Isaiah*, *The Spirit of the Lord is upon me, because he hath anointed me.* And *Paul* writes thus; *In whom also ye were sealed.* And again, *Grieve not the Holy Spirit of God, whereby ye are sealed unto the day of redemption.* This anointing is the breath of the Son, so that he who hath the Spirit may say, *We are the sweet-smelling savour of Christ.* Because we are partakers of the Holy Spirit, we have the Son: And having the Son, we have *the Spirit, crying in our hearts, Abba, Father.*”

And so, in his oration against the *Arians*.

*“*He sendeth the Spirit of his Son into our hearts, crying, Abba, Father.* His Son in us, invoking the Father, makes him to be called our Father. Certainly God cannot be called their Father, who have not the Son in their hearts.”

Is it not easy to be observed here, 1. That *Athanasius* makes *that testimony of the Spirit* common to all the children of God: 2. That he joins *the anointing of the Holy One*, with that seal of the Spirit wherewith all that *persevere are sealed to the day of redemption*: And 3. That he does not, throughout this passage, speak of the *extraordinary gifts* at all?

Therefore, upon the whole, the sense of the primitive church, so far as it can be gathered from the authors above cited, is, That “although some of the scriptures *primarily* refer, to those *extraordinary* gifts of the Spirit, which were given to the apostles, and a few other persons in the apostolical age: yet they refer also, in a *secondary* sense, to those *ordinary* operations of the Holy Spirit, which all the children of God do and will experience, even to the end of the world.”

23. What I mean by *The ordinary operations of the Holy Ghost*, I sum up in the words of a modern writer:

“Sanctification being opposed to our corruption, and answering fully to the latitude thereof, whatsoever of holiness and perfection is wanting in our nature, must be supplied by the Spirit of God. Wherefore being by nature we are totally void of all saving truth, and under an impossibility of knowing the will of God; this *Spirit searcheth all things, yea, even the deep things of God*, and *revealeth* them unto the sons of men, so that thereby the darkness of their understanding is expelled, and they are enlightened with the knowledge of God. The same Spirit which *revealeth* the object of faith generally to the universal church, doth also illuminate the understanding of such as believe, that they may receive the truth. For *faith is the gift of God*, not only in the object, but also in the act. And this gift is a gift of the Holy Ghost working within us—And as the increase of perfection, so the original of faith is from the Spirit of God, by an internal illumination of the soul.”

“The second part of the office of the Holy Ghost is, the renewing of man in all the parts and faculties of his soul. For our natural corruption consisting in an aversion of our wills, and a depravation of our affections, and inclination of them to the will of God, is wrought within us by the Spirit of God.”

“The third part of this office is, To lead, direct and govern us in our actions and conversations. *If we live in the Spirit*, quickened by his renovation, we must also *walk in the Spirit*, following his direction, led by his manuduction. We are also animated and acted by the Spirit of God, who giveth *both to will and to do*: And *as many as are thus led by the Spirit of God, are the sons of God*.¹ Moreover, that this direction may prove more effectual, we are guided in our prayers by the same Spirit: according to the promise, *I will pour upon the house of David, and upon the inhabitants of Jerusalem, the spirit of grace and supplication*. (Zechariah xii. 10.) Whereas then *this is the confidence which we have in him, that if we ask any thing according to his will, he heareth us*: and whereas we know not what we should pray for as we ought, the Spirit itself maketh intercession for us with groanings which cannot be uttered²: And he that searcheth the hearts, knoweth what is the mind of the spirit, because he maketh intercession for the saints, according to the will of God.³ From which intercession” (made for all true Christians) “he hath the name of the *Paraclete* given him by Christ, who said, *I will pray the Father, and he will give you another Paraclete*.⁴ For *if any man sin, we have a Paraclete with the Father*, Jesus Christ *the righteous*, saith St. John: *Who maketh intercession for us*, saith St. Paul, (Romans viii. 34.) And we have *another Paraclete*⁵, saith our Saviour: *Which also maketh intercession for us*⁶, saith St. Paul. A *Paraclete* then, in the notion of the scriptures, is an intercessor.”

¹ Romans viii. 14.

² Verse 26.

³ Verse 26.

⁴ John xiv. 16, 26.

⁵ John xiv. 16.

⁶ Romans viii. 27.

“It is also the office of the Holy Ghost, to *assure us of the adoption of sons*, to create in us a sense of the paternal love of God towards us, to give us an earnest of our everlasting inheritance. *The love of God shed abroad in our hearts, by the Holy Ghost which is given unto us.* For as many as are led by the Spirit of God, they are the sons of God. And because we are sons, God hath sent forth the Spirit of his Son into our hearts, crying, *Abba, Father.* For we have not received the spirit of bondage again to fear, but we have received the spirit of adoption, whereby we cry, *Abba, Father: the Spirit itself bearing witness with our spirit, that we are the children of God.*¹”

¹ Verses 15, 16.

“As therefore we are born again by the Spirit, and receive from him our regeneration, so we are also by the same Spirit *assured of our adoption.* Because being sons we are also heirs, heirs of God, and joint-heirs with Christ, by the same Spirit we have the *pledge*, or rather the *earnest of our inheritance.* For he which establisheth us in Christ, and hath anointed us is God; who hath also sealed us, and hath given us the earnest of his Spirit in our hearts: So that we are sealed with that Holy Spirit of promise, which is the earnest of our inheritance. The Spirit of God, as given unto us in this life, is to be looked upon as an earnest, being part of that reward which is promised, and, upon performance of the covenant which God hath made with us, certainly to be received.”

Your Lordship observed, that “the interpretation of those passages, which relate to the *Unction from the Holy One*, depends on the sense of those other passages of holy scripture, particularly, those in St. John’s gospel.” Now if so, then these words fix the sense of six out of the seven texts in question: and every one of them, in the judgment of this writer, describes the *ordinary gifts* bestowed on all Christians.

It now rests with your Lordship, to take your choice; either to condemn or to acquit both. Either your Lordship must condemn Bishop *Pearson* for an *enthusiast*, (a man no ways inferior to Bishop *Chrysostom*;) or you must acquit me: for I have his express authority on my side, concerning every text which I affirm to belong to all Christians.

24. But I have greater authority than his, and such as I reverence, only less than that of the oracles of God. I mean, that of our own church. I shall close this head, by setting down what occurs in her authentic records, concerning either our *receiving the Holy Ghost*, or his *ordinary* operations in all true Christians.

In her daily service, she teaches us all to *beseech* God, *to grant us his Holy Spirit, that those things may please him which we do at this present, and that the rest of our life may be pure and holy*: To pray for our Sovereign Lord the King, that God would *replenish him with the grace of his Holy Spirit*; for *all the Royal Family*, that they may be *endued with his Holy Spirit*, and *enriched with his heavenly grace*: for all the clergy and people, that he would *send down upon them the healthful Spirit of his grace*: for the *Catholick Church*, that *it may be guided and governed by his good Spirit*: and for all therein who at any time *make their common supplication unto him*, that *the fellowship or communication of the Holy Ghost may be with them all evermore*.

Her collects are full of petitions to the same effect: “Grant that we may daily be renewed by thy Holy Spirit.¹—Grant that in all our sufferings here, for the testimony of thy truth, we may by faith behold the glory that shall be revealed, and *being filled with the Holy Ghost*, may love and bless our persecutors.² Send thy Holy Ghost and pour into our hearts that most excellent gift of charity.³ O Lord, from whom all good things do come, grant to us thy humble servants, that by thy *holy inspiration* we may think those things that are good, and by thy merciful guidance may perform the same.⁴ Grant us by the same Spirit to have a right judgment in all things, and evermore to rejoice in his holy comfort.⁵ (N. B. The church here teaches all Christians to claim *the Comforter*, in virtue of the promise made *John xiv.*) Grant us, Lord, we beseech thee, the Spirit, to think and do always such things as be rightful.⁶ O God, forasmuch as without thee, we are not able to please thee, merciful grant that thy Holy Spirit, may in all things direct and rule our hearts.⁷ Cleanse the thoughts of our hearts by *the inspiration of thy Holy Spirit*, that we may perfectly love thee, and worthily magnify thy holy name.⁸”

¹ Collect for Christmas-Day.

² St. Stephen’s Day.

³ Quinquagesima Sunday.

⁴ 5th Sunday after Easter.

⁵ Sunday after Ascension Day.

⁶ 9th Sunday after Trinity.

⁷ 19th Sunday after Trinity.

⁸ Communion Office.

“Give thy Holy Spirit to this infant (or this person) that he may be born again.—Give thy Holy Spirit to these persons (N. B. already baptized) that they may continue thy servants.”

“Almighty God, who hast vouchsafed to regenerate these persons by water and the Holy Ghost—Strengthen them with the Holy Ghost the Comforter, and daily increase in them the manifold gifts of thy grace.”
Office of Confirmation.

From these passages it may sufficiently appear, for what purposes every Christian, according to the doctrine of the church of *England*, does now *receive the Holy Ghost*. But this will be still more clear from those that follow: wherein the reader may likewise observe, a plain, rational sense of God's *revealing* himself to us, of the *inspiration* of the Holy Ghost, and of a believer's *feeling* in himself *the mighty working* of the Spirit of Christ.

25. "God gave them of old grace to be his children, as he doth us now. But now, by the coming of our Saviour Christ, *we have received* more abundantly *the Spirit of God* in our hearts." *Homily on Faith*. Part II.

"He died to destroy the rule of the devil in us, and he rose again to send down his Holy Spirit, to *rule in our hearts*." *Homily on the Resurrection*.

"We have the Holy Spirit in our hearts, as a *seal and pledge* of our everlasting inheritance." *ibid*.

"The Holy Ghost sat upon each of them, like as it had been cloven tongues of fire: to teach, that it is he which *giveth eloquence and utterance* in preaching the gospel; which engendereth a burning *zeal* towards God's word, and giveth all men *a tongue*, yea, a fiery tongue." (N. B. Whatever occurs in any of the journals, of God's "giving me utterance," or "enabling me to speak *with power*," cannot therefore be quoted as *enthusiasm*, without wounding the church through my side) "So that if any man be a dumb Christian, not professing his faith openly, he giveth men occasion to doubt, least he have not the grace of the Holy Ghost within him." *Homily on Whitsunday*. Part I.

“It is the office of the Holy Ghost to sanctify; which the more it is hid from our understanding” (*i. e.* the particular manner of his working) “the more it ought to move all men, to wonder at the secret and mighty workings of God’s Holy Spirit which is within us, for it is the Holy Ghost that doth *quicken* the minds of men, *stirring up* godly motions in their hearts. Neither doth he think it sufficient inwardly to work the new birth of man, unless he do also dwell and abide in him. *Know ye not*, saith St. Paul, *that ye are the temple of God, and that his Spirit dwelleth in you? Know ye not that your bodies are the temple of the Holy Ghost which is in you?* Again he saith, *Ye are not in the flesh but in the Spirit*, For why? *The Spirit of God dwelleth in you.* To this agreeth St. John. *The anointing which ye have received* (he meaneth the Holy Ghost) *abideth in you.*¹ And St. Peter saith the same, *The Spirit of glory and of God resteth upon you.* O what comfort is this to the heart of a true Christian, to think that the Holy Ghost dwelleth in him! *If God be with us*, as the apostle saith, *who can be against us?* He giveth patience and joyfulness of heart, in temptation and affliction, and is therefore worthily called *the Comforter*². He doth instruct the hearts of the simple, in the knowledge of God and his word; therefore he is justly termed *The Spirit of truth*³. And where the Holy Ghost doth instruct and teach, there is no delay at all in learning.” *ibid.*

¹ 1 John ii. 27.

² John xiv. 16.

³ John xvi. 13.

(From this passage I learn, 1. That every true Christian now *receives the Holy Ghost*, as *the Paraclete* or *Comforter* promised by our Lord, *John xiv. 13*. Secondly, that every Christian receives him as *the Spirit of truth* (promised *John xvi.*) to *teach him all things*: and 3. That *the anointing* mentioned in the first epistle of St. John, *abides in every Christian.*)

26. “In reading of God’s word, he profiteth most, that is most *inspired* with the Holy Ghost.” *Homily on reading the scripture.* Part I.

“Human and worldly wisdom is not needful to the understanding of scripture, but the *revelation* of the Holy Ghost, who *inspireth* the true meaning unto them that with humility and diligence search for it.” *ibid.* Part II.

“Make him know and *feel*, that there is no other name under heaven given unto men, whereby we can be saved.”

“If we *feel* our conscience at peace with God, through remission of our sin,—all is of God.” *Homily on Rogation week*. Part III.

“If you *feel* such a faith in you, rejoice in it, and let it be daily increasing by well-working.” *Homily on faith*. Part III.

“The faithful may *feel* wrought tranquility of conscience, the increase of faith and hope, with many other graces of God.” *Homily on the sacrament*. Part I.

“Godly men *feel* inwardly God’s Holy Spirit, inflaming their hearts with love.” *Homily on certain places of scripture*. Part I.

“God give us grace, to know these things, and to *feel* them in our hearts! This knowledge and *feeling* is not of ourselves. Let us therefore meekly call upon the bountiful Spirit, the Holy Ghost, to *inspire* us with his presence, that we may be able to hear the goodness of God to our salvation. For without his lively *inspiration*, can we not so much as speak the name of the Mediator. *No man can say that Jesus is the Lord, but by the Holy Ghost*. Much less should we be able to believe and know these great mysteries that be opened to us by Christ. *But we have received* saith St. Paul, *not the spirit of the world, but the Spirit which is of God*; for this purpose, *that we may know the things which are freely given to us of God*. In the power of the Holy Ghost resteth all ability to *know* God and to *please* him. It is he that *purifieth* the mind by his secret working. He *enlighteneth* the heart, to conceive worthy thoughts of Almighty God. He sitteth in the *tongue* of man, to stir him to speak his honour. He only ministreth spiritual *strength* to the powers of the *soul* and *body*. And if we have any gift, whereby we may profit our neighbour, all is wrought by this one and the self-same Spirit.” *Homily for Rogation week*. Part III.

27. Every proposition which I have any where advanced, concerning those *operations* of the Holy Ghost, which I believe are *common* to all Christians in all ages, is here clearly maintained by our own church.

Under a full sense of this, I could not well understand for many years, how it was, that on the mentioning any of these great truths, even among men of education, the cry, immediately arose, “An Enthusiast, an Enthusiast!” But I now plainly perceive, this is only an old fallacy in a new shape. To object *Enthusiasm* to any person or doctrine, is but a decent method of begging the question. It generally spares the objector the trouble of reasoning, and is a shorter and easier way of carrying his cause.

For instance, I assert that “till a man *receives the Holy Ghost*, he is without God in the world; that he cannot know the things of God, unless God *reveal* them unto him by the Spirit: no, nor have even one holy or heavenly temper, without the *inspiration of the Holy One*.” Now should one who is conscious to himself, that he has ◆experienced none of these things, attempt to confute these propositions, either from scripture or antiquity, it might prove a difficult task. What then shall he do? Why, cry out, “*Enthusiasm! Enthusiasm!*” And the work is done.

◆ “experinced” replaced with “experienced”

But what does he mean by *Enthusiasm*? Perhaps nothing at all: few have any distinct ideas of its meaning. Perhaps, “something very bad,” or, “something I never experienced and do not understand.” Shall I tell you then, what that “terrible something” is? I believe, thinking men mean by *Enthusiasm*, a sort of religious madness; a *false imagination* of being inspired by God: and by an *Enthusiast*, one that *fancies* himself under the influence of the Holy Ghost, when in fact he is not.

Let him prove me guilty of this, who can. I will tell you once more the whole of my belief on these heads. And if any man will shew me (by arguments, not hard names) what is wrong, I will thank God and him.

28. Every good gift is from God, and is given to man by the Holy Ghost. By nature there is in us no good thing. And there can be none, but so far as it is wrought in us by that good Spirit. Have we any true knowledge of what is good? This is not the result of our natural understanding. *The natural man discerneth not the things of the Spirit of God*: so that we never can discern them, until God *reveals them unto us by his Spirit*. Reveals, that is unveils, uncovers; gives us to know what we did not know before. Have we love? *It is shed abroad in our hearts, by the Holy Ghost which is given unto us*. He *inspires*, breathes, infuses into our soul, what of ourselves we could not have. Does our Spirit rejoice in God our Saviour? It is *joy in* (or by) *the Holy Ghost*. Have we true inward peace? It is *the peace of God*, wrought in us by the same Spirit. Faith, peace, joy, love, are all his fruits. And as we are figuratively said, to see the light of faith, so by a like figure of speech we are said to *feel*, this peace and joy and love: that is, we have an inward experience of them, which we cannot find any fitter word to express.

*The reasons why in speaking of these things I use those terms, (*inspiration* particularly) are, 1. Because they are scriptural. 2. Because they are used by our church. 3. Because I know none better. The word “*influence of the Holy Ghost*,” which I suppose you use, is both a far stronger and a less natural term than *inspiration*. It is far stronger; even as far as “flowing into the soul” is a stronger expression than “breathing upon it:” and less natural; as *breathing* bears a near relation to Spirit; to which *flowing in* has only a distant relation.

“But you thought I had meant *immediate inspiration*.” So I do, or I mean nothing at all. Not indeed such inspiration as is *sine mediis*. But all inspiration, tho’ by means, is *immediate*. Suppose, for instance, you are employed in private prayer, and God pours his love into your heart. God then acts *immediately* on your soul: and the love of him which you then experience, is as *immediately* breathed into you by the Holy Ghost, as if you had lived 1700 years ago. Change the term. Say, “God then *assists* you to love him?” Well, and is not this *immediate assistance*? Say, “His Spirit *concurs* with yours.” You gain no ground. It is *immediate concurrence* or none at all. God, a Spirit acts upon your Spirit. Make it out any otherwise if you can.

*I cannot conceive, how that harmless word *immediate*, came to be such a bugbear in the world: “Why, I thought you meant *such inspiration* as the apostles had; and *such a receiving* the Holy Ghost as that was at the day of *Pentecost*.” I do, in part: indeed I do not mean, that Christians now receive the Holy Ghost, in order to work miracles: but they do doubtless now receive, yea, *are filled with the Holy Ghost*, in order to be filled with the fruits of that blessed Spirit. And he *inspires* into all true believers now, a degree of the same peace and joy and love, which the apostles felt in themselves on that day, when they were first *filled with the Holy Ghost*.

29. I have now considered the most material objections I know, which have been lately made against the great doctrines I teach. I have produced, so far as in me lay, the strength of those objections, and then answered them, I hope, in the Spirit of meekness. And now I trust it appears, that these doctrines are no other than the doctrines of Jesus Christ: that they are all evidently contained in the word of God, by which alone I desire to stand or fall; and that they are fundamentally the same with the doctrines of the church of *England*, of which I do, and ever did profess myself a member.

But there remains one objection, which though relating to the head of doctrine, yet is independent on all that went before. And that is, “You cannot agree in your doctrines among yourselves. One holds one thing, and one another. Mr. *Whitefield* anathematizes Mr. *Wesley*; and Mr. *Wesley* anathematizes Mr. *Whitefield*. And yet each pretends to be led by the Holy Ghost, by the infallible Spirit of God! Every reasonable man must conclude from hence, that neither one nor the other is led by that Spirit.”

I need not say, how continually this has been urged, both in common conversation and from the press: (I am grieved to add, and from the pulpit too: for, if the argument were good, it would overturn the bible.) Nor, how great stress has been continually laid upon it: whoever proposes it, proposes it as demonstration, and generally claps his wings, as being quite assured, it will admit of no answer.

And indeed I am in doubt, whether it does admit (I am sure, it does not *require*) any other answer, than that course one of the countryman to the *Romish* champion, “*Bellarmino*, Thou liest.” For every proposition contained herein, is grossly, shamelessly false. 1. “You cannot agree in your doctrines among yourselves.”—Who told you so? All our fundamental doctrines, I have recited above. And in every one of these we do and have agreed for several years. In these we hold one and the same thing. In smaller points, each of us thinks, and lets think. 2. “Mr. *Whitefield* anathematizes Mr. *Wesley*.” Another shameless untruth. Let any one read what Mr. *Whitefield* wrote, even in the heat of controversy, and he will be convinced of the contrary. 3. “And Mr. *Wesley* anathematizes Mr. *Whitefield*.” This is equally false and scandalous. I reverence Mr. *Whitefield*, both as a child of God, and a true minister of Jesus Christ. 4. “And yet each pretends to be led by the Holy Ghost, by the infallible Spirit of God.” Not in our private opinions: nor does either of us pretend to be any farther led by the Spirit of God, than every Christian must pretend to be, unless he will deny the bible. For only *as many as are led by the Spirit of God, are the sons of God*. Therefore, if *you* do not pretend to be led by him too, yea, if it be not so in fact, *you are none of his*.

And now, what is become of your demonstration? Leave it to the carmen and porters, its just proprietors: to the zealous apple-women that cry after me in the street, “This is he that rails at the *Whole Dutyful* of Man.” But let every one that pretends to learning or reason, be ashamed to mention it any more.

30. The first inference, easily deduced from what has been said, is, “That we are not *false prophets*.” In one sense of the word, we are no prophets at all; for we do not foretel things to come. But in another (wherein every minister is a prophet) we are. For we do speak in the name of God. Now a false prophet (in this sense of the word) is one, who declares as the will of God, what is not so. But we declare (as has been shewn at large) nothing else as the will of God, but what is evidently contained in his written word, as explained by our own church. Therefore, unless you can prove the bible to be a *false book*, you cannot possibly prove us to be *false prophets*.

The text which is generally cited on this occasion, is *Matthew vii. verse 15*. But how unhappily chosen! In the preceeding chapters, our Lord had been describing, that *righteousness which exceeds the righteousness of the Scribes and Pharisees*, and without which we cannot *enter into the kingdom of heaven*: Even the life of God in the soul; holiness of heart, producing all holiness of conversation. In this, he closes that rule which sums up the whole, with those solemn words, *Enter ye in at the strait gate*: (such indeed is that of universal holiness) *For wide is the gate, and broad is the way that leadeth to destruction. The gate of hell is wide as the whole earth; the way of unholiness is broad as the great deep. And many there be which go in thereat*; yea, and excuse themselves in so doing, *Because strait is the gate and narrow is the way that leadeth unto life, and few there be that find it*. It follows, *Beware of false prophets*; of those who speak as from God, what God hath not spoken; those who shew you any other way to life, than that which I have now shewn. So that the *false prophets*, here spoken of, are those who point out any other way to heaven than this; who teach men to find *a wider gate, a broader way*, than that described in the foregoing chapters. But it has been abundantly shewn, that we do not. Therefore (whatever we are beside) we are not *false prophets*.

Neither are we (as has been frequently and vehemently affirmed) *deceivers of the people*. If we teach *the truth as it is in Jesus*, if we *speak as the oracles of God*, it follows, that we do not *deceive* those that hear, though they should believe whatever we speak. *Let God be true and every man a liar*: every man that contradicts his truth. But he will *be justified in his saying, and clear when he is judged*.

One thing more I infer, “That we are not *enthusiasts*.” This accusation has been considered at large; and the main arguments hitherto brought to support it, have been weighed in the balance and found wanting: Particularly this, “That none but *enthusiasts* suppose either that *promise* of the Comforter¹ or the witness of the Spirit², or that *unutterable prayer*³, or the *unction from the Holy One*⁴, to belong, in common, to all Christians.” O my Lord, how deeply have you condemned the generation of God’s children! Whom you have represented as rank, dreaming *enthusiasts*? As either *deluded* or *designing* men? Not only bishop *Pearson*, a man hitherto accounted both sound in heart, and of good understanding: but likewise archbishop *Cranmer*, bishop *Ridley*, bishop *Latimer*, bishop *Hooper*! and all the venerable compilers of our liturgy and homilies: All the members of both the houses of convocation, by whom they were revised and approved: Yea, king *Edward*, and all his lords and commons together, by whose authority they were established! And, with these *modern enthusiasts*, *Origen*, *Chrysostom*, and *Athanasius* are comprehended in the same censure!

¹ John xiv. 16, 26. xvi. 13.

² Romans viii. 15, 16.

³ Romans viii. 26, 27.

⁴ 1 John ii. 20, 27.

I grant a deist might rank both us and them, in the number of *religious madmen*: Nay, ought so to do, on *his* supposition, that the gospel is but a *cunningly-devised fable*. And on this ground, some of them have done so in fact. One of them was asking me, some years since, “What! are *you* one of the knight-errants? How, I pray, got this quixotism into *your* head? You want nothing: you have a good provision for life; and are in a fair way of preferment. And must *you* leave all, to fight windmills; to convert savages in *America*?” I could only reply, “Sir, if the bible is a lie, I am as very a madman as you can conceive. But if it be true, I am in my senses. I am neither a madman nor *enthusiast*. For there is no man who hath left father, or mother, or wife, or house, or land, for the gospel’s sake; but he shall receive an hundred fold, in this world, with persecutions, and in the world to come, eternal life.”

Nominal, outside Christians too, men of form, may pass the same judgment. For we give up all our pretensions to what they account happiness, for what they (with the deists) believe to be a mere dream. We expect, therefore, to pass for *enthusiasts*, with these also. *But wisdom is justified of all her children.*

32. I cannot conclude this head without one obvious remark. Suppose we really were *enthusiasts*; suppose our doctrines were false and unsupported either by reason, scripture, or authority: Then why hath not some one, *who is a wise man, and endued with knowledge among you*, attempted at least, to shew us our fault *in love and meekness of wisdom*? Brethren, *if ye have bitter zeal in your hearts, your wisdom descendeth not from above. The wisdom that is from above, is pure, peaceable, gentle, easy to be intreated, full of mercy or pity.* Does this spirit appear in one single tract of all those which have been published against us? Is there one writer that has reproved us in love? Bring it to a single point. *Love hopeth all things.* If you had loved us in any degree, you would have hoped, that God would some time give us the knowledge of his truth. But where shall we find even this slender instance of love? Has not every one who has wrote at all (I do not remember so much as one exception) treated us as *incorrigible*? Brethren, how is this? Why do ye labour to teach us an evil lesson against yourselves? O may God never suffer others to deal with you, as ye have dealt with us!

VI. 1. Before I enter upon the consideration of those objections, which have been made to the manner of our preaching, I believe it may be satisfactory to some readers, if I relate how I began to preach in this manner.

I was ordained deacon in 1725, and priest in the year following. But it was many years after this, before I was convinced of the great truths above recited. During all that time I was utterly ignorant of the nature and condition of *justification*. Sometimes I confounded it with sanctification (particularly when I was in *Georgia*.) At other times I had some confused notion about the forgiveness of sins: but then I took it for granted, the time of this must be, either the hour of death, or the day of judgment.

I was equally ignorant of the nature of *saving faith*; apprehending it to mean no more, than a “firm assent to all the propositions contained in the old and new Testament.”

2. As soon as, by the great blessing of God, I had a clearer view of these things, I began to declare them to others also. *I believed, and therefore I spake*. Wherever I was now desired to preach, salvation by faith was my only theme. My constant subjects were, *Believe in the Lord Jesus Christ, and thou shalt be saved. Him hath God exalted to be a Prince and a Saviour, to give repentance and remission of sins*. These I explained and enforced with all my might, both in every church where I was asked to preach, and occasionally in the religious societies of *London* and *Westminster*; to some or other of which I was continually pressed to go, by the stewards or other members of them.

Things were in this posture, when I was told, “I must preach no more in this, and this, and another church.” The reason was usually added without reserve, “Because you preach such doctrines.” So much the more those who could not hear me there, flocked together when I was at any of the societies; where I spoke more or less, though with much inconvenience, to as many as the room I was in would contain.

3. But after a time, finding those rooms could not contain a tenth part of the people that were earnest to hear, I determined to do the same thing in *England*, which I had often done in a warmer climate: namely, when the house would not contain the congregation, to preach in the open air. This I accordingly did, first at *Bristol*, where the society rooms were exceeding small, and at *Kingswood*, where we had no room at all; afterwards in or near *London*.

And I cannot say, I have ever seen a more awful sight, than when on *Rose-green*, or the top of *Hanham-mount*, some thousands of people were calmly joined together in solemn waiting upon God, while

“They stood and under open air adored

The God who made both air, earth, heaven and sky.”

And whether they were listening to his word, with attention still as night; or were lifting up their voice in praise, as the sound of many waters; many a time have I been constrained to say in my heart, *How dreadful is this place! This also is no other than the house of God! This is the gate of heaven!*

*Be pleased to observe. 1. That I was forbidden, as by a general consent, to preach in any church (though not by any judicial sentence) “for preaching such doctrine.” This was the open, avowed cause: there was at that time no other, either real or pretended; (except that the people crowded so:) 2. That I had no desire or design to preach in the open air, till after this prohibition; 3. That when I did, as it was no matter of choice, so neither of premeditation. There was no scheme at all previously formed, which was to be supported thereby; nor had I any other end in view than this, to save as many souls as I could. 4. *Field-preaching* was therefore a sudden expedient, a thing submitted to, rather than chosen, and therefore submitted to because I thought preaching even *thus*, better than *not* preaching *at all*: First, in regard to my own soul, because *a dispensation of the gospel being committed to me*, I did not dare, *Not to preach the gospel*; Secondly, in regard to the souls of others, whom I every where saw, *seeking death in the error of their life*.

4. But the author of *the observations* and of *the case of the Methodists* briefly stated, more particularly in the point of field-preaching, thinks *field-preaching* worse than *not preaching at all*, “because it is illegal.”

Your argument, in form, runs thus:

“That preaching which is contrary to the laws of the land, is worse than not preaching at all:

“But *field preaching* is *contrary* to the laws of the land:

“Therefore, it is worse than not preaching at all.”

*The first proposition is not self-evident, nor indeed universally true. For the preaching of all the primitive Christians was contrary to the whole tenor of the *Roman* law; the worship of the devil-gods being established by the strongest laws then in being. Nor is it ever true, but on supposition, that the preaching in question is an indifferent thing.

But ◆ waving this, I deny the second proposition; I deny that *field-preaching* is contrary to the laws of our land.

◆ “waveing” replaced with “waving” for consistency

To prove which, you begin thus, “It does not appear, that any of the preachers among the *Methodists*, have qualified themselves and the places of their assembling, according to the act of toleration.”

*I answer, 1. That act grants toleration to those who *dissent* from the established church. But we do not dissent from it. Therefore we *cannot* make use of that act. 2. That act exempts dissenters from penalties consequent on their *breach of preceding laws*. But we are not conscious of *breaking any law at all*. Therefore we *need not* make use of it.

In the next section you say, “They have broken through all these provisions, *in open defiance* of government: and have met, not only in houses, but in the *fields*, notwithstanding the statute (22 *Charles II.* chapter 1.) which forbids this by name.”

*I answer, 1. We do nothing *in defiance* of government. We reverence magistrates, as the ministers of God. 2. Although we have met in the *fields*, yet we do not conceive that statute at all affects us: not only because that act points wholly at *dissenters*; whereas we are members of the established church; but also because (they are your own words) *it was evidently intended to suppress and prevent sedition*: whereas no sedition, nor any the least approach thereto, can with any colour be laid to our charge.

In your third section you affirm, “That the act of toleration itself cannot secure us in *field-preaching*, from the penalties of former laws.” We have no desire it should; as not apprehending ourselves to be condemned by any former law whatever. Nor does what you add, “That the act of toleration forbids any assembly of persons *dissenting* from the church of *England*, to meet with the doors locked,” affect us at all; because we do not *dissent* from it.

5. In *the case of the Methodists briefly stated*, your first observation is, “The act of toleration leaves them liable to the penalties of several statutes made against unlawful assemblies.”

I suppose then these several statutes specify what those *unlawful assemblies* are; and whether unlawful, as being condemned by previous laws, or made unlawful by those statutes.

And it still remains to be proved, that our assemblies are *unlawful*, in one or other of these senses.

You next observe, that, “the *dissenters* of all denominations, qualify themselves according to the act of toleration: otherwise, they are liable to the penalties of all the laws recited in this act.”

I answer, as before, all this strikes wide. It relates wholly to “persons *dissenting* from the church.” But we are not the men. We do not *dissent* from the church. Whoever affirms it, we put him to the proof.

You go on, “One of those laws so recited (*viz. 22 Charles II. chapter 1.*) is that which forbids *field-preaching* by name; and was evidently intended, not only to *suppress*, but also to *prevent* sedition. As the title of the *act declares*, and as the preamble expresses it, *to provide farther and more speedy remedies against it.*”

*Was this then, in your own judgment, *the evident intention of that act*, viz. *To provide remedies against sedition*? Does the very *title of the act declare this*? And *the preamble* also express it? With what justice then, with what ingenuity or candor, with what shadow of truth or reason, can any man cite this act against us? Whom you yourself no more suspect of a design to raise sedition (I appeal to your own conscience in the sight of God) than of a design to blow up the city of *London*.

6. Hitherto therefore it hath not been made to appear, that *field-preaching* is contrary to any law in being. However, “It is dangerous.” This you strongly insist on. “It may be attended with mischievous consequences. It may give advantages to the enemies of the established government. It is big with mischief.” (*Observations*, Section I. and II.)

With what mischief? Why, “evil-minded men, by meeting together *in the fields*, under pretence of religion, may raise riots and tumults; or by meeting *secretly*, may carry on *private* cabals against the state.” (*Case of the Methodists*, page 2.)

“And if the *Methodists* themselves are a *harmless* and *loyal* people, it is nothing to the point in hand. For disloyal and seditious persons, may use such an opportunity of getting together, in order to execute any private design. Mr. *Whitefield* says, 30, 50 or 80,000 have attended his preaching at once. Now, 1. He cannot know one tenth part of such a congregation. 2. All people may come and carry on what designs they will: Therefore 3. This is a great opportunity put into the hands of seditious persons to raise disturbances.

“With what safety to the public these field-preachings may be continued, let the world judge.” (*Ibid.* page 2, 3, 4.).

*May I speak without offence? I cannot think you are *in earnest*. You do not *mean* what you say. Do you *believe*, Mr. Whitefield had *eighty thousand* hearers at once? No more that you believe he had *eighty millions*. Is not all this talk of *danger*, mere finesse? Thrown in purely *ad movendam invidiam*? You know governments generally are suspicious; especially in time of war: and therefore apply, as you suppose, to their weak side; in hopes, if possible, to deliver over these hereticks to the secular arm. However, I will answer, *as if* you spoke from your heart. For I am in earnest, if you are not.

First, “The preacher cannot know a tenth part of his congregation.” Let us come to the *present* state of things. The largest congregation that *now* attend the preaching of any *Methodist*, are those (God be merciful to me!) that attend mine. And cannot I know a tenth part of one of these congregations, either at *Bristol, Kingswood, Newcastle, or London*? As strange as it may seem, I generally know two-thirds of the congregation in every place, even on Sunday evening, and nine in ten of those who attend at most other times. 2. “All people may come and carry on what designs they will.” Not so. All *field-preaching* is now in the open day. And were only ten persons, to come to such an assembly with arms, it would soon be inquired, with what design they came. This is therefore, 3. No “great opportunity put into the hands of seditious persons to raise disturbances.” And if ever any disturbance has been raised, it was quite of another kind.

The public then is entirely safe, if it be in no other danger than arises from *field-preaching*.

7. There is one other sentence belonging to this head, in the eighth section of *the observations*. “The religious societies, you say, in *London* and *Westminster*, for many years past, have received no discouragements, but on the contrary have been *countenanced* and incouraged both by the bishops and clergy.” How is this? Have *they* then “qualified themselves and places of their assembling, according to the act of toleration?” Have *they* “embraced the protection which that act might give them, in case they complied with the conditions of it?” If not, are they not all “liable to the penalties of the several statutes made before that time against unlawful assemblies?”

How can they escape? Have they “qualified themselves for holding these separate assemblies, according to the tenor of that act”? “Have then the several members thereof taken the oaths to the government?” And are the “doors of the places wherein they meet, always open at the time of such meeting?” I presume, you know they are not: and that neither “the persons nor places are so qualified as that act directs.”

How then come “the bishops and clergy, to *countenance* and *encourage*” unlawful assemblies? If it be said, “They meet in a private, inoffensive way;” that is nothing to the point in hand. If those meetings are *unlawful* in themselves, all their inoffensiveness will not make them lawful. “O, but they behave with modesty and decency.” Very well; but the law! What is that to the law? There can be no solid defence but this: They are not *dissenters* from the church; therefore they *cannot use*, and they do *not need* the act of toleration. And their meetings are not seditious; therefore the statute against seditious meetings does not affect them.

The application is obvious. If our meetings are illegal, so are theirs also. But if this plea be good (as doubtless it is) in the one case, it is good in the other also.

9. You propose another objection to our *manner* of preaching, in the second part of the *observations*. The substance of it I will repeat, and answer as briefly as I can.

“They run up and down from place to place, and from county to county:” that is, *they preach in several places*. This is undoubtedly true. “They draw after them confused multitudes of people:” that is, “*Many come to hear them*.” This is true also. “But they would do well to remember, God is not the author of *confusion* or of *tumult*, but of peace.” I trust we do: nor is there any *confusion* or *tumult* at all, in our largest congregations; unless at some rare times when the sons of *Belial* mix therewith, on purpose to disturb the *peaceable* worshippers of God.

“But our church has provided against this preaching up and down, in the ordination of a priest, by expressly limiting the exercise of the powers then conferred upon him, to *the congregation where he shall be lawfully appointed thereunto*.”

I answer, 1. Your argument proves too much. If it be allowed just as you propose it, it proves, That no priest has authority, either to preach or minister the sacraments, in any other than his own congregation.

2. Had the powers conferred been *so limited* when I was ordained priest, my ordination would have signified just nothing. For I was not *appointed to any congregation* at all: but was ordained as a member of that “College of divines,” (so our statutes express it) “founded to overturn all heresies; and defend the Catholic faith.”

3. For many years after I was ordained priest, this *limitation* was never heard of. I heard not one syllable of it, by way of objection, to my preaching up and down in *Oxford* or *London*, or the parts adjacent, in *Gloucestershire*, or *Worcestershire*; *Lancashire*, *Yorkshire* or *Lincolnshire*. Nor did the strictest disciplinarian scruple suffering me to exercise those powers wherever I came.

4. And in fact, Is it not universally allowed, that every priest, as such, has a power, in virtue of his ordination, either to preach or to administer the sacraments, in any congregation, [♦](#) wherever the rector or curate desires his assistance? Does not every one then, see through this thin pretence?

[♦](#) “whereever” replaced with “wherever”

10. “The bishops and universities indeed have power to grant licences to *Itinerants*. But the church has provided in *that* case; They are not to preach in any church (Canon 50.) till they shew their licence.”

The church has well provided in *that* case. But what has *that* case to do with the case of common clergymen? Only so much as to shew, how grossly this canon has been abused, at *Islington* in particular: where the churchwardens were instructed to hinder, by main force, the priest whom the vicar himself had appointed, from preaching, and to quote this canon; which, as you plainly shew, belongs to quite another thing.

In the note you add, “Mr. Wesley being asked, By what authority he preached, replied, By the authority of Jesus Christ conveyed to me by the (now) archbishop of *Canterbury*, when he laid his hands upon me and said, Take thou authority to preach the gospel. In this reply he thought fit, for a plain reason, to leave out *this latter part* of the commission: for that would have shewn his reader, the *restraint* and *limitation*, under which the exercise of the power is granted.” Nay, I did not *print the latter part* of the words, for a plainer reason, because I did not *speak* them. And I did not *speak* them then, because they did not come into my mind. Tho’ probably if they had, I should not have spoken them: it being my only concern, to answer the question proposed, in as few words as I could.

But before those words, which you suppose to imply such a *restraint*, as would condemn all the bishops and clergy in the nation, were those spoken without any *restraint* or *limitation* at all, which I apprehend to convey an indelible character, “Receive the Holy Ghost, for the office and work of a priest in the church of God, now committed unto thee, by the imposition of our hands. Whose sins thou dost forgive, they are forgiven, and whose sins thou dost retain, they are retained. And be thou a faithful dispenser of the word of God, and of his Holy sacraments, in the name of the Father, and of the Son, and of the Holy Ghost.”

You proceed, “In the same journal he declares, that he looks upon all the world as his parish, and explains his meaning as follows; ‘In whatever part of it I am, I judge it meet, right, and my bounden duty, to declare unto all that are willing to hear, the glad tidings of salvation. This is the work which I know God hath called me to.’ Namely, *by the laying on of the hands of the presbytery*: which directs me how to obey that general command, *while we have time, let us do good unto all men.*”

11. You object farther, “That the *methodists* do not observe the rubrick before the communion service; which directs, so many as desire to partake of the holy communion, to signify their names to the curate the day before.” What curate desires they should? Whenever any minister will give but one week’s notice of this, I undertake, all that have any relation to me, shall signify their names within the time appointed.

You object also, that they break through the twenty-eighth canon, which requires, “That if strangers come often to any church from other parishes, they should be remitted to their own churches, there to receive the communion with their neighbours.”

But what if there be no communion there? Then this canon does not touch the case; nor does any one break it, by coming to another church purely because there is no communion at his own.

As to your next advice, “To have a greater regard to the rules and orders of the church,” *I cannot*; for I now regard them, next to the word of God. And as to your last, “To renounce communion with the church,” *I dare not*. Nay but let them thrust us out. *We will not* leave the ship: if you *cast us* out of it, then our Lord will take us up.

12. To the same head may be referred the objection some time urged, by a friendly and candid man, viz. “That it was unlawful to use extemporary prayer, because there was a canon against it.”

It was not quite clear to me, that the canon he cited was against extemporary prayer. But supposing it were, my plain answer would be, “That the canon I dare not obey: because the law of man binds only so far as it is consistent with the word of God.”

The same person objected, my not obeying the bishops and governors of the church. I answer, I both do and will obey them, in whatsoever I can with a clear conscience. So that there is no just ground for that charge, that I despise either the rules, or the governors of the church. I obey them in all things where I do not apprehend there is some particular law of God to the contrary. Even in that case, I shew all the deference I can; I endeavour to act as inoffensively as possible: and am ready to submit to any penalty, which can by law be inflicted upon me. Would to God every minister and member of the church, were herein altogether as I am!

VII. 1. I have considered the chief objections that have lately been urged against the *doctrines* I teach. The main arguments brought against this *manner of teaching*, have been considered also. It remains, to examine the most current objections, concerning *the effects* of this teaching.

Many affirm, “That it does abundance of hurt: that it has had very bad effects; insomuch that if any good at all has been done, yet it bears no proportion to the evil.”

But to come to particulars, “First then, you are disturbers of the public peace.”

What, do we either teach or raise sedition? Do we speak evil of the ruler of our people? Or do we stir them up against any of those that are put in authority under him? Do we directly or indirectly promote faction, mutiny, or rebellion? I have not found any man in his senses yet, that would affirm this.

“But it is plain, peace is broke and disturbances do arise, in consequence of your preaching.” I grant it. But what would you infer? Have you never read the bible? Have you not read, that the Prince of peace himself was, in *this* sense, a disturber of the public peace? *When he came into Jerusalem, (Matthew xxi. 10.) all the city was moved, (ἐσείσθη) shaken as with an earthquake. And the disturbance arose higher and higher, till the whole multitude cried out together, Away with him, away with him; crucify him, crucify him, and Pilate gave sentence, it should be done.* Such another disturber of the public peace, was that *Stephen*, even from the time he began *disputing with the Libertines and Cyrenians*, till the people *stopped their ears, and ran upon him with one accord, and cast him out of the city and stoned him.* Such disturbers of the peace were all those ringleaders of the sect of the *Nazarenes*, (commonly called *apostles*) who wherever they came, *turned the world upside down.* And above all the rest, that *Paul of Tarsius*, who occasioned so much disturbance at *Damascus*, (Acts ix.) at *Antioch of Pisidia* (chapter xiii.) at *Iconium* (chapter xiv.) at *Lystra* (verse 19.) at *Philippi* (chapter xvi.) at *Thessalonica* (chapter xvii.) and particularly at *Ephesus*. The consequence of his preaching there was, That *the whole city was filled with confusion. And they all ran together with one accord, some crying one thing, some another: inasmuch as the greater part of them knew not wherefore they were come together.*

*2. And can we expect it to be any otherwise *now*? Although what we preach is the gospel of peace, yet if you will violently and illegally hinder our preaching, must not this create disturbance? But observe, the disturbance begins on *your* part. All is peace, till you raise that disturbance. And then you very modestly impute it to *us*, and lay your *own* riot at *our* door!

But of all this, our Lord hath told us before. *Think not that I am come to send peace upon earth*: that this will be the immediate effect, wherever my gospel is preached with power. *I am not come to send peace, but a sword*: this (so far as the wisdom of God permits, by whom *the hairs of your head are all numbred*) will be the first consequence of my coming, whenever my word turns sinners from darkness to light, from the power of *Satan* unto God.

I would wish all you who see this scripture fulfilled, by disturbance following the preaching the gospel, to remember the behaviour of that wise magistrate at *Ephesus* on the like occasion. He did not lay the disturbance to the preacher's charge, but *beckoned to the multitude and said, ye men of Ephesus—Ye ought to be quiet, and to do nothing rashly. For ye have brought these men, who are neither robbers of temples, nor yet blasphemers of your goddess*: (not convicted of any such notorious crime, as can at all excuse this lawless violence.) *But if Demetrius hath a matter against any, the law is open, and there are deputies* (or proconsuls, capable of hearing and deciding the cause) *let them implead one another. But if ye enquire any thing concerning other things, it shall be determined in a lawful assembly.*

3. “But you create divisions in private families.” Accidentally, we do. For instance, suppose an entire family to have the form but not the power of godliness; or to have neither the form nor the power; in either case, they may in some sort agree together. But suppose, when these hear the plain word of God, one or two of them are convinced, “This is the truth. And I have been all this time in the broad way that leadeth to destruction.” These then will begin to mourn after God; while the rest remain as they were. Will they not therefore of consequence divide, and form themselves into separate parties? Must it not be so, in the very nature of things? And how exactly does this agree with the words of our Lord? *Suppose ye that I came to send peace upon earth? I tell you nay: But rather division. For from henceforth there shall be five divided in one house, three against two, and two against three. The father shall be divided against the son, and the son against the father: the mother against her daughter, and the daughter against the mother; the mother-in-law against the daughter-in-law, and the daughter-in-law against the mother-in-law.* (Luke xii. 51, 52, 53.) *And the foes of a man, shall be they of his own houshold.* (Matthew x. 36.)

Thus it was from the very beginning. For is it to be supposed, that a *Heathen* parent, would long endure a *Christian* child? Or, that a *Heathen* husband would agree with a *Christian* wife? Unless either the believing wife could gain her husband; or the unbelieving husband prevailed on the wife to renounce *her way* of worshipping God: at least, unless she would obey him in going no more to those *societies* or *conventicles*, (ἐταίρια) as they termed the Christian assemblies.

*4. Do you think now, I have an eye to *your* case? Doubtless I have; for I do not fight as one that beateth the air. “Why have not I a right to hinder my own wife or child, from going to a conventicle? And is it not the duty of wives to obey their husbands? And of children to obey their parents?” Only set the case seventeen hundred years back, and your own conscience gives you the answer. What would St. *Paul* have said to one whose husband forbade her, to follow *this way* any more? What directions would our Saviour have given to him whose father enjoined him, not to hear the gospel? His words are extant still, *He that loveth father or mother more than me, is not worthy of me. And he that loveth son or daughter more than me, is not worthy of me.* (Matthew x. 37, 38.) Nay more, *If any man cometh to me, and hateth not* (in comparison of me) *his father, and mother, and wife, and children, yea and his own life, he cannot be my disciple.* (Luke xiv. 26.)

*“O, but this is not a parallel case. For they were *Heathens*; but I am a *Christian*.” A Christian! Are you so? Do you understand the word? Do you know what a Christian is? If you are a Christian, you have the mind that was in Christ; and you so walk as he also walked. You are holy as he is holy, both in heart, and in all manner of conversation. Have you then the mind that was in Christ? And do you walk as Christ walked? Are you inwardly and outwardly holy? I fear, not even outwardly. No; you live in known sin. Alas! How then are you a Christian? What a railer, a Christian? A common swearer, a Christian? A sabbath-breaker, a Christian? A drunkard or whoremonger, a Christian? Thou art a Heathen barefaced; the wrath of God is on thy head, and the curse of God upon thy back. Thy damnation slumbereth not. By reason of such Christians it is that the holy name of Christ is blasphemed. Such as thou they are, that cause the very savages in the *Indian* woods to cry out, “*Christian much drunk, Christian beat men, Christian tell lies, Devil-Christian! Me no Christian.*”

*And so *thou* wilt direct thy wife and children in the way of salvation! —Woe unto thee, thou Devil-Christian! Woe unto thee thou blind leader of the blind! What wilt thou make them? Two-fold more the children of hell than thyself? Be ashamed, blush, if thou canst blush. Hide thy face. Lay thee in the dust. Out of the deep cry unto God, if haply he may hear thy voice. Instantly smite upon thy breast. Who knoweth but God may take thee out of the belly of hell?

*5. “But you are not one of these. You fear God, and labour to have a conscience void of offence. And it is from a principle of *conscience*, that you restrain your wife and children from hearing *false doctrine*.” But how do you know it is false doctrine? Have you heard for yourself? Or, if you have not heard, have you carefully read what we have occasionally answered for ourselves? A man of conscience cannot condemn any one unheard. This is not common humanity. Nor will he refrain from hearing what *may be* the truth, for no better reason than fear of his reputation. Pray observe, I do not say, every man (or any man) is obliged in conscience to hear us. But I do say, every man in *England* who condemns us, is obliged to hear us first. This is only common justice, such as is not denied to a thief or a murderer. Take your choice therefore. Either hear us, or condemn us not. Either speak nothing at all, or hear before you speak.

But suppose you have both read and heard *more than you like*: Did you read and hear fairly? Was not you loaden with prejudice? Did you not read or hear, *expecting no good*; perhaps desiring to find fault? If so, what wonder you judge as you do? What a poor mock-trial is this? You had decided the cause in your own breast, before you heard one word of the evidence. And still do *you* talk of acting out of conscience? Yea, a conscience void of offence?

*We will put the case farther yet. Suppose your censure was just, and this was actually false doctrine. Still every one must give an account of himself to God: and you cannot *force* the conscience of any one. You cannot *compel* another, to see as you see. You ought not to attempt it. Reason and persuasion are the only weapons you ought to use, even toward your own wife and children. Nay, and it is impossible to *starve* them into conviction, or to *beat* even truth into their head, You may *destroy* them, in this way, but cannot *convert* them. Remember what our own poet has said,

“By force beasts act and are by force restrain’d;

The human mind by gentle means is gain’d.

Thou canst not take, what I refuse to yield:

Nor reap the harvest, tho’ thou spoilst the field.”

6. Every reasonable man is convinced of this. And perhaps you do not concern yourself so much about the doctrine, but the mischief that is done, “How many poor families are starved, ruined, brought to beggary!” By what? Not by *contributing* a penny a week (the usual contribution in our societies) and *letting that alone*, when they please, when there is any shadow of reason to suppose they cannot afford it. You will not say, any are brought to beggary by this. Not by gifts to me: for I receive none; save (sometimes) the food I eat. And publick collections are nothing to me. That it may evidently appear they are not, when any such collection is made, to cloathe the poor, or for any other determinate purpose, the money is both received and expended before many witnesses, without ever going through my hands at all. And then likewise all possible regard is had, to the circumstances of those who contribute any thing. And they are told over and over, *if there be a willing mind, it is accepted according to that a man hath.*

But where are all these families that have been brought to beggary? How is it, that none of them is forth-coming? Are they all, *out of town*? Then indeed I am in no danger of clearing myself from *their* indictment. It is the easiest thing of a thousand, for one at *Newcastle* to say, that I have beggared him and all his kindred. If one of the long-bearded men on *Tyne-bridge*, were to say so just now, I could not readily confute him. But why will you not bring a few of these to tell me so to my face? I have not found one that would do this yet. They pray, you would have them excused.

I remember a man coming to me with a doleful countenance, putting himself into many lamentable postures, gaping as wide as he could, and pointing to his mouth, as tho' he would say, "he could not speak." I enquired of his companion, what was the matter? And was informed, "he had fallen into the hands of the *Turks*, who had used him in a barbarous manner, and cut out his tongue by the roots." I believed him. But when the man had had a chearful cup, he could find his tongue as well as another. I reflected, how is it that I could so readily believe that tale? The answer was easy, "because it was told of a *Turk*." My friend, take knowledge of your own case. If you had not first took me for a *Turk*, or something equally bad, you could not so readily have believed that tale!

7. "But can it be, that there is no ground at all for a report, which is in every ones mouth?" I will simply tell you, all the ground which I can conceive. I believe many of those who attend on my ministry, have less of this world's goods than they had before, or at least, might have had if they did not attend it. This fact I allow; and it may be easily accounted for, in one or other of the following ways.

First, I frequently preach on such texts as these: *Having food and raiment, let us be content therewith. They who desire to be rich, fall into temptation and a snare, and many foolish and hurtful lusts, which drown men in destruction and perdition. Lay not up for yourselves treasures upon earth, where the rust and moth doth corrupt, and where thieves break thro' and steal. But lay up for yourselves treasures in heaven, where neither rust nor moth doth corrupt, and where thieves do not break thro' and steal.*

Now should any of those who are labouring by all possible means, *to lay up treasure upon earth*, feel these words, they would not *inlarge their desires as hell*; but be *content with such things as they had*. They then probably might not heap up so much for their heirs, as otherwise they would have done. These would therefore *have less* than if they had not heard *me*: because they would *grasp at less*.

Secondly, wherever the gospel takes effect, *the foes of a man will be those of his own household*. By this means then some who hear and receive it with joy, will be poorer then they were before. Their domestic foes will, in many cases, hinder, embroil, and disturb the course of their affairs. And their relations, who assisted them before, or promised at least so to do, will probably withdraw or deny that assistance, *unless they will be advised by them*. Perhaps their nearest relations: it being no new thing, for parents to disown their children, if *after the way which they call heresy, these worship the God of their fathers*. Hence therefore some *have less*, of this world's goods then they had in times past, either because they *earn less*, or because they *receive less*, from them on whom they depend.

Thirdly, It is written, that *those who received not the mark of the beast, either on their fore-heads, or in their right hands*, either openly or secretly were not permitted *to buy or sell any more*. Now whatever the mystery contained herein may be, I apprehend the plain mark of the beast is wickedness; inward and outward unholiness, whatever is secretly or openly contrary to justice, mercy or truth. And certain it is, the time is [well](#) nigh come, when those who have not this mark, can neither buy nor sell, can scarce follow any profession, so as to gain a subsistence thereby. Therefore, many of those who attend on my ministry, are by this means poorer than before. They will not receive the mark of the beast, either on their forehead or in their hand: or if they had received it, before, they rid themselves of it as soon as possible. Some cannot follow their former way of life *at all*; (as pawnbrokers, smugglers, buyers or sellers of uncustomed goods) others cannot follow it *as they did before*. For they cannot oppress, cheat or defraud their neighbour: they cannot lie, or say what they do not mean; they *must* now speak the truth from their heart. On all these accounts, they *have less* of this world's goods; because they *gain less* than they did before.

◆ “will” replaced with “well”

Fourthly, *all that will live godly in Christ Jesus shall suffer persecution*: If in no other way, yet at least in this, that *men will by revilings persecute them; and say all manner of evil against them falsely, for his sake*. One unavoidable effect of this will be, that men whose subsistence depends on their daily labour, will be often in want, for few will care to employ those of so *bad a character*. And even those who did employ them before, perhaps for many years, will employ them no more; so that hereby some may indeed be brought to beggary.

*8. What does this touch *you*? Are *you* one of those, “who will have nothing to do with those scandalous wretches?” Perhaps you will say, “And who can blame me for it: may I not employ whom I please?” We will weigh this. You employed *A. B.* for several years. By your own account, he was an honest, diligent man. You had no objection to him but his following *this way*. For this reason you turn him off. In a short time, having spent his little all, and having no supply, he wants bread. So does his family too as well as himself. Before he can get into other business to procure it, thro’ want of convenient food to eat, and raiment to put on, he sickens and dies. This is not an imaginary scene. I have known the case; tho’ too late to remedy it.

“And what then?” What then *you* are a murderer. *O earth, cover not thou his blood!* No it doth not. *The cry thereof hath entered into the ears of the Lord God of sabbaoth*. And God requireth it at *your* hands: and will require it in an hour when you think not. For *you* have as effectually murdered that man, as if you had stabbed him to the heart.

It is not I then who ruin and starve that family; it is *you*; *you* who call yourself a *protestant*! *You* who cry out against the *persecuting* spirit of the *Papists*! Ye fools and blind! What are ye better then they? Why, *Edmund Bonner* would have *starved* the hereticks in *prison*: whereas *you* starve them in their *own houses*.

*And all this time you talk of *liberty of conscience*! Yes, liberty for such a conscience as your own: a conscience *past feeling*; (for sure it had some once) a conscience *seared with a hot iron*. Liberty to serve the devil, according to your poor, hardened conscience, you allow; but not liberty to serve God.

*Nay, and what marvel? Whosoever thou art that readest this, and feelest in thy heart a real desire to serve God, I warn thee, expect no liberty for thy conscience, from him that hath no conscience at all. All ungodly, unthankful, unholy men; all villains of whatever denomination, will have liberty indeed all the world over, as long as their master is *God of this world*. But expect not liberty to worship God in spirit and in truth, to practise pure and undefiled religion (unless the Lord should work a new thing in the earth) from any but those who themselves love and serve God.

9. “However, ’tis plain, you make men idle. And this tends to beggar their families.” This objection having been continually urged for some years, I will trace it from the foundation.

Two or three years after my return from *America*, one Captain *Robert Williams* of *Bristol*, made affidavit before the (then) mayor of the city, that “it was a common report in *Georgia*, Mr. *Wesley* took people off from their work and *made them idle*, by preaching so much.”

The fact stood thus: at my first coming to *Savannah*, the generality of the people rose at seven or eight in the morning. And that part of them who were accustomed to work, usually worked till six in the evening. A few of them sometimes worked till seven; which is the time of sun-set there at Midsummer.

I immediately began reading prayers and expounded the second lesson, both in the morning and evening. The morning service began at five, and ended at, or before six: the evening service began at seven.

Now supposing all the grown persons in the town, had been present every morning and evening, would this have *made them idle*? Would they hereby have had *less*, or considerably *more time for working*?

10. The same rule I follow now, both at *London*, *Bristol* and *Newcastle-upon-Tyne*: concluding the service at every place, winter and summer, before six in the morning: and not ordinarily beginning to preach, till near seven in the evening.

Now do you, who make this objection, work longer, throughout the year, than from six to six? Do you desire, that the generality of people should? Or, can you count them idle, that work so long?

Some few are indeed accustomed to work longer. These I advise, not to come on weekdays. And it is apparent, that they take this advice, unless on some rare and extraordinary occasion.

But I hope, none of *you* who turn them out of their employment, have the confidence to talk of *my* making them idle! Do you (as the homely phrase is) cry wh— first? I admire your cunning; but not your modesty.

So far am I from either *causing* or *encouraging* idleness, that an idle person, known to be such, is not suffered to remain in any of our societies; we drive him out, as we would a thief or a murderer. “To shew all possible diligence,” (as well as frugality) is one of our standing rules: and one, concerning the observance of which, we continually make the strictest enquiry.

11. “But you drive them out of their senses. You *make them mad*.” Nay, then they are idle with a vengeance. This objection therefore being of the utmost importance, deserves our deepest consideration.

And first, I grant, it is my earnest desire to drive all the world, into what you probably call *madness*: (I mean, inward religion) to make them just as *mad*, as *Paul* was when he was so accounted by *Festus*.

The counting all things on earth but dung and dross, so we may win Christ; the ♦trampling under foot all the pleasures of the world, the seeking no treasure but in heaven; the having no desire of the praise of men, a good character, a fair reputation; the being exceeding glad when men revile us, and persecute us, and say all manner of evil against us falsely; the giving God thanks, when our father and mother forsake us, when we have neither food to eat, nor raiment to put on, nor a friend but what shoots out bitter words, nor a place where to lay our head: this is utter *distraction* in *your* account; but in God's it is sober, rational religion: the genuine fruit, not of a distempered brain, not of a sickly imagination, but *of the power* of God in the heart, *of victorious love, and of a sound mind*.

♦ “trampleing” replaced with “trampling”

12. I grant, secondly, It is my endeavour to drive all I can, into what *you* may term another species of *madness*, which is usually preparatory to this, and which I term *repentance* or *conviction*.

I cannot describe this better than a writer of our own has done. I will therefore transcribe his words.

“When men *feel* in themselves the heavy burden of sin, see damnation to be the reward of it, and behold with the eye of their mind the horror of hell; they tremble, they quake, and are inwardly touched with sorrowfulness of heart, and cannot but accuse themselves, and open their grief unto Almighty God, and call unto him for mercy. This being done seriously, their mind is so occupied, partly with sorrow and heaviness, partly with an earnest desire to be delivered from this danger of hell and damnation, that all desire of meat and drink is laid apart, and loathsomeness (or loathing) of all worldly things and pleasure cometh in place. So that nothing then liketh them, more than to weep, to lament, to mourn, and both with words and behaviour of body to shew themselves weary of life.”

Now what if your wife, or daughter, or acquaintance, after hearing one of these field-preachers, should come and tell you, that they *saw damnation* before them, and *beheld with the eye of their mind the horror of hell*? What if they should *tremble and quake*, and be so taken up *partly with sorrow and heaviness, partly with an earnest desire to be delivered from this danger of hell and damnation*, as to weep, to lament, to mourn, and both with words and behaviour to *shew themselves weary of life*; would you scruple to say, that they were *stark mad*? That these fellows had driven them *out of their senses*? And that whatever writer it was, that *talked at this rate*, he was fitter for *Bedlam* than any other place?

You have overshot yourself now to some purpose. These are the very words of our own church. You may read them, if you are so inclined, in the first part of the *homily on fasting*. And consequently, what you have peremptorily determined to be *mere lunacy and destruction*, is that *repentance unto life*, which, in the judgment both of the church and of St. Paul, is *never to be repented of*.

13. I grant, thirdly, that *extraordinary* circumstances have attended this conviction in some instances. A particular account of these I have frequently given. While the word of God was preached, some persons have dropped down as dead; some have been, as it were, in strong convulsions; some roared aloud, though not with an ◆articulate voice; and others spoke the anguish of their souls.

◆ “articlute” replaced with “articulate”

This, I suppose, you believe to be perfect madness. But it is easily accounted for, either on principles of reason or scripture.

First, on principles of reason. For how easy is it to suppose, that a strong, lively and sudden apprehension of the heinousness of sin, the wrath of God, and the bitter pains of eternal death, should affect the body as well as the soul, during the present laws of vital union; should interrupt or disturb the ordinary circulations, and put nature out of its course? Yea, we may question, whether while this union subsists, it be possible for the mind to be affected, in so violent a degree, without some or other of those bodily symptoms following?

It is likewise easy to account for these things, on principles of scripture. For when we take a view of them in this light, we are to add to the consideration of natural causes, the agency of those spirits who still excel in strength, and as far as they have leave from God, will not fail to torment whom they cannot destroy; to *tear* those *that are coming* to Christ. It is also remarkable, that there is plain scripture precedent of every symptom which has lately appeared. So that we cannot allow even the *conviction* attended with these to be *madness*, without giving up both reason and scripture.

*14. I grant, fourthly, That touches of extravagance, bordering on madness may sometime attend severe conviction. And this also is easy to be accounted for, by the present laws of the animal œconomy. For we know, fear or grief, from a temporal cause, may occasion a fever and thereby a delirium.

It is not strange then that some, while under strong impressions of grief or fear, from a sense of the wrath of God, should for a season *forget* almost all things else, and scarce be able to answer a common question: that some should *fancy* they see the flames of hell, or the devil and his angels around them: or that others, for a space, should be *afraid*, like *Cain*, *whosoever meeteth me will slay me*. All these, and whatever less common effects may sometimes accompany this conviction, are easily known from the natural distemper of madness, were it only by this one circumstance, that whenever the person convinced tastes the pardoning love of God, they all vanish away in a moment.

Lastly, I have seen one instance (I pray God I may see no more such!) of real, lasting madness.

Two or three years since, I took one with me to *Bristol*, who was under deep convictions; but of as sound an understanding in all respects, as ever he had been in his life. I went a short journey, and when I came to *Bristol* again, found him really distracted. I enquired particularly, at what time and place, and in what manner this disorder began? And I believe there are, at least, threescore witnesses, alive, and ready to testify what follows. When I went from *Bristol*, he contracted an acquaintance with some persons, who were not of the same judgment with me. He was soon prejudiced against me: quickly after, when our society were met together in *Kingswood-house*, he began a vehement invective both against my person and doctrines. In the midst of this, he was struck raving mad. And so he continued till his friends put him into *bedlam*: and probably, laid *his* madness too to *my* charge.

15. I fear, there may also be some instances of real madness, proceeding from a different cause.

Suppose, for instance, a person, hearing me, is strongly convinced, that a liar cannot enter into the kingdom of heaven. He comes home, and relates this to his parents or friends, and appears to be very uneasy. These *good Christians* are disturbed at this, and afraid he is running mad too. They are resolved, he shall never hear any of those fellows more; and keep to it in spite of all his intreaties. They will not suffer him, when at home, to be alone, for fear he should read or pray. And perhaps in a while they will constrain him, at least by repeated importunities, to do again the very thing, for which he was convinced the wrath of God cometh upon the children of disobedience.

What is the event of this? Sometimes the Spirit of God is quenched and departs from him. Now you have carried the point. The man is easy as ever, and sins on without any remorse. But in other instances, where those convictions sink deep, and the arrows of the Almighty stick fast in the soul, you will drive the person into real, settled madness, before you can quench the Spirit of God. I am afraid, there have been several instances of this. You have forced the man's conscience, till he is stark mad. But then, pray do not impute that madness to me. Had you left him to my direction, or rather to the direction of the Spirit of God, he would have been filled with love and a sound mind. But you have taken the matter out of God's hand. And now you have brought it to a fair conclusion!

16. How frequent this case may be, I know not. But doubtless most of those who make this objection, of our driving men mad, have never met with such an instance in their lives. The common cry is occasioned, either by those who are *convinced* of sin, or those who are inwardly *converted* to God: mere madness both (as was observed before) to those who are without God in the world. Yet I do not deny, but you may have seen one in *bedlam*, who *said* he had followed *me*. But observe, a madman's saying this, is no proof of the fact: nay, and if he really had, it should be farther considered, that his being in *bedlam*, is no sure proof of his being mad. Witness the well-known case of Mr. *Periam*; and I doubt more such are to be found. Yea, it is well if some have not been sent thither, for no other reason, but because they followed *me*: their kind relations either concluding, that they must be distracted, before they could do this: or, perhaps hoping, that *bedlam* would *make* them mad, if it did not *find* them so.

*17. And it must be owned, a confinement of such a sort, is as fit to *cause* as to *cure* distraction. For what scene of distress is to be compared to it? To be separated at once from all who are near and dear to you; to be cut off from all reasonable conversation, to be secluded from all business, from all reading, from every innocent entertainment of the mind, which is left to prey wholly upon itself, and day and night to pore over your misfortunes: to be shut up day by day in a gloomy cell, with only the walls to employ your heavy eyes, in the midst either of melancholy silence, or horrid cries, groans and laughter intermixt: to be forced by the main strength of those

“Who laugh at human nature and compassion,”

to take drenches of nauseous, perhaps torturing medicines, which you know you have no need of now, but know not how soon you may, possibly by the operation of these very drugs on a weak and tender constitution: here is distress! It is an astonishing thing, a signal proof of the power of God, if any creature who has his senses when the confinement begins, does not lose them, before it is at an end!

How must it heighten the distress, if such a poor wretch, being deeply convinced of sin, and growing worse and worse (as he probably will, seeing there is no medicine here for *his* sickness, no such physician as his case requires) be soon placed among *the incurables*! Can imagination itself paint such a hell upon earth? Where even “hope never comes, that comes to all!”—For what remedy? If a man of sense and humanity, should happen to visit that house of woe, would he give the hearing to a madman’s tale? Or if he did, would he credit it? “Do we not know, might he say, how well any of these will talk in their lucid intervals?” So that a thousand to one he would concern himself no more about it, but leave the weary to wait for rest in the grave!

18. I have now answered most of the current objections, particularly such as have appeared of weight to religious or reasonable men. I have endeavoured to shew, first, That the doctrines I teach are no other than the great truths of the gospel. 2. That though I teach them, not as I would, but as I *can*, yet it is in a *manner* not contrary to law: And 3. That the *effects* of thus preaching the gospel, have not been such as was weakly or wickedly reported: those reports being mere artifices of the devil, to hinder the work of God. Whosoever therefore ye are, who look for God to *revive his work in the midst of the years*, cry aloud, that he may *finish* it nevertheless, may *cut it short in righteousness*. Cry to *Messiah the Prince*, that he may soon *end the transgression*, that he may *lift up his standard* upon earth, sending by whom he will send, and working his own work, when he pleaseth, and as he pleaseth, till *all the kindreds of the people worship before him*, and the earth *be full of the knowledge of the glory of the Lord*!

December 22, 1744.

An A C T of D E V O T I O N.

1 **B**EHOLD the servant of the Lord!
I wait thy guiding eye to feel,

To hear, and keep thine every word,

To prove, and do thy perfect will:

Joyful from all my works to cease,

Glad to fulfil all righteousness.

2 Me if thy grace vouchsafe to use,

Meanest of all thy creatures me,

The deed, the time, the manner chuse;

Let all my fruit be found of thee;

Let all my works in thee be wrought,

By thee to full perfection brought.

3 My every weak, though good design,

O'er-rule, or change as seems thee meet;

Jesus, let all the work be thine;

Thy work, O Lord, is all-compleat,

And pleasing in thy Father's sight;

Thou only hast done all things right.

4 Here then to thee thine own I leave,

Mould as thou wilt the passive clay;

But let me all thy stamp receive,

But let me all thy words obey;

Serve with a single heart and eye,

And to thy glory live and die.

The *End* of the *Fourteenth Volume*.

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